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**Usability Testing for an Internet Self-Response Mode of the Current Population Survey:
Findings and Recommendations**

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Abstract

The Current Population Survey (CPS), which is currently conducted via face-to-face and telephone interviewing, is the primary source of monthly labor force statistics in the U.S. Because of increasing costs of interviewer-administered surveys and lower response rates, the CPS is undergoing a modernization initiative to add an Internet self-response mode to its data collection. Designing the survey questions in web is a major change and requires extensive pretesting. RTI International and Research Support Services Inc. (RSS) conducted two rounds of usability testing to evaluate how respondents interacted with the prototype instrument in the Census Bureau's production environment. Testing focused on how participants navigated through the prototype instrument and whether they encountered any issues with the design and usability of the instrument when answering the survey questions. This report documents the findings and recommendations from the usability testing of the CPS prototype instrument.

Keywords: labor force, employment, usability, survey methods, longitudinal, dependent data, roster, log in, drop downs

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Current Population Survey Usability Testing

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1. Project Background

Sponsored jointly by the U.S. Census Bureau and the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), the Current Population Survey (CPS) is the premier source of data on employment and unemployment in the United States. It is a longitudinal survey conducted by trained U.S. Census Bureau interviewers, either by telephone or in person. The CPS comprises a core that asks the same employment, income, and demographic questions every month (see [Questionnaires](#)) and supplements that vary in sponsorship and content. The interviewer plays an important role in ensuring the quality of CPS data because the survey questions are complex, and careful probing may be needed before the respondent is able to provide a complete answer. The interviewer also plays an important role in maintaining the respondent's motivation to complete the CPS survey, allowing item and unit response rates to remain high. Despite the importance of the interviewer for a successful completion of the CPS, there are compelling reasons to consider adding a self-administered web mode, including the potential to reduce data collection costs and improve response rates (both nationally and within demographic subgroups).

To support this effort, RTI International and Research Support Services Inc. (RSS) conducted cognitive interviews to evaluate how well the CPS instrument performs in a self-administered web mode (see [Cognitive Testing Results Report](#)). RTI/RSS conducted two rounds of usability testing interviews with a prototype CPS web instrument programmed in the Census Bureau's survey production environment to determine whether there were any issues with the usability that would result in errors or confusion or would otherwise hinder respondents from accurately completed the CPS internet instrument. This report summarizes the recruitment efforts and findings from the first and second round of usability testing interviews.

2. Methodology

2.1 Introduction

Since the CPS is a longitudinal survey, usability testing was also conducted using the same participants in Round 1 and Round 2. The first interview instrument (Month in Sample 1 or “MIS-1”) was tested in Round 1 and the MIS-2 instrument in Round 2. In the MIS-1 instrument, the respondent is asked to roster their household, provide demographic information about themselves and their household members, and then complete the labor force section of the instrument for all household members ages 15 and older. In the MIS-2 instrument, the previously collected roster is presented to the respondent for any updates or revisions and the respondent proceeds to the labor force section for all eligible household members. Dependent interviewing—providing respondents with their previously reported responses—is used in some questions within the labor force section in the MIS-2 instrument. In the Census Bureau’s production environment, logging into the instrument differs for those who are logging in for the first time and those who are returning users. Due to differences in login procedures and instrument functionality, this usability study tested both the MIS-1 and MIS-2 instruments using the same participants in each round of testing.

This section provides an overview of the recruitment efforts and interviewing methods for Round 1 and Round 2 of the CPS usability testing interviews. An overview of the recruitment strategies, eligibility criteria, usability testing participants, and the usability testing protocol and procedures are discussed in the sections that follow.

2.2 Recruitment Methods

2.2.1 Overview

The RTI/RSS team recruited participants for Round 1 of Call Order 11 CPS Usability testing from June 25, 2024, to August 19, 2024, and participants for Round 2 from October 15, 2024, to November 13, 2024. Round 2 participants were individuals who had previously completed a Round 1 interview; no new individuals were recruited for Round 2.

The RTI/RSS team posted online recruitment advertisements in selected areas on Craigslist, releasing advertisements on a rolling basis to maintain a steady stream of prospective recruits for screening and scheduling for Round 1 interviews (see **Section 2.2.2** for details).

The Census Bureau programmed a web-based eligibility screener in Qualtrics. The RTI/RSS team also established a toll-free telephone line dedicated to recruitment purposes. The web link of the screening instrument and the toll-free phone number were presented in the online advertisements (see **Appendix A**) to support participant recruitment.

During the data collection period, the RTI/RSS team provided the Census Bureau with a weekly recruitment and interviewing progress report. The weekly report sought to present

the status of interview participants with respect to recruitment goals and needed sub-characteristics. The results of Round 1 and Round 2 recruitment presented in **Section 2.2.4** of this report reflect the final recruitment outcomes.

2.2.2 Recruitment and Advertising Procedures

During Call Order 11 CPS usability testing, the RTI/RSS team used Craigslist as the main venue for recruitment advertising. Craigslist is one of the best-known online bulletin boards and provides the most comprehensive coverage of metropolitan areas in the United States. To leverage Craigslist's broad reach, RTI/RSS did not use advertisements that focused on specific characteristics and instead used a customized general advertisement. Additionally, RTI/RSS also posted the general recruitment advertisement on Reddit under the subreddit "r/samplesize" to further expand the reach to prospective recruits.

The RTI/RSS team began the participant recruitment by posting the general recruitment advertisement on Craigslist under the "jobs/et cetera" sections. See **Appendix A-1** for the text used in the recruitment ads.

During Round 1, the first round of monthly paid advertising started on June 14, 2024, when we posted two advertisements. As completions gradually decreased, the team posted the second general advertisement (two new advertisements) on July 10 to boost the response to the web recruitment screener. The third general advertisement (three new advertisements) was posted on July 24, followed by the fourth posting (one new advertisement) on August 2.

The RTI/RSS team also pursued avenues outside of Reddit and Craigslist during recruitment. We leveraged personal connections to contact potential participants who may fit the study criteria. We also posted advertisements to Facebook groups geared toward sharing job or work listings.

The RTI/RSS team recorded screening responses from more than 950 prospective participants from all the advertisements in Round 1.

For Round 2, the RTI/RSS team selected a subset of participants from Round 1 to complete a Round 2 interview. During Round 1 interviews, interviewers assessed participants' interest and availability to complete a Round 2 interview. If participants were interested in participating in a second interview, interviewers made note of the participant's availability/schedule for the Round 2 interviewing period (i.e., October and November). Interested participants were marked in the recruitment tracker as either a priority to schedule for Round 2 or a backup; priority participants were selected for Round 2 to achieve a sample that varied on employment status and device (e.g., cell phone, laptop or desktop) used to complete the Round 1 interview. Priority participants were sent a reminder in September about the Round 2 interviews and in early October, recruiters contacted those interested Round 1 participants to schedule them for their Round 2 interview.

2.2.3 Participant Selection Strategy

To facilitate efficient screening for the Round 1 CPS usability interviews, the RTI/RSS team created two automated spreadsheets to process screening data to determine participant eligibility for the required characteristics of interest. First, the team created the main intake sheet to import the screening responses from Qualtrics and to determine whether participants were eligible.

Within the main intake spreadsheet, the RTI/RSS team employed a two-step review strategy to prioritize participants for selection. The spreadsheet first calculated the total number of eligible participant characteristics (recruitment criteria are displayed in **Table 2.1**). Next, the lead recruiter proceeded to review the screener responses of all prospective participants in the intake sheet, focusing on the self-reports of the contact information and the IP addresses in the paradata. Entries were screened for duplicates, and those with a foreign IP address were excluded.

After reviewing and cleaning the tentative assignments, we exported records of eligible recruits to the CPS recruitment tracking sheet, which served as the main reference for recruitment and interview progress for the entire project team, including recruiters and interviewers. This recruitment tracker displayed which primary and secondary recruitment characteristic each participant represented (see **Table 2.1** and **Table 2.2**). In this recruitment tracker, we created formulas in Microsoft Excel to make these eligibility criteria mutually exclusive; for example, self-employed participants were not also counted as employed full time.

During the CPS usability testing data collection in Round 1, the RTI/RSS team processed and reviewed the screening data at least once a week to select eligible participants for an interview. After reviewing a batch of screening data, about 1 week would elapse before new assignments to recruiters/interviewers would be made to allow recruiters/interviewers sufficient time to contact their existing assignments by phone or email. How quickly interviewers contacted a selected participant after their assignment varied based on several factors, including the interviewer's case load at the time of assignment, the number of scheduled interviews, and the speed with which other participants responded to the interviewer's contact attempts.

2.2.4 CPS Usability Testing Participants

For the first round of usability testing, the RTI/RSS team completed 80 interviews. During Round 1, RTI/RSS selected and contacted an additional 71 eligible participants; 27 participants did not respond to our invitation, four refused to participate, 18 did not attend their scheduled interview, and another 22 decided to withdraw their participation after they were scheduled for an interview or experienced severe technical issues that prevented them from being able to participate.

The 80 Round 1 participants served as the participant pool for Round 2. During Round 2, RTI/RSS completed 47 interviews. RTI/RSS selected and contacted an additional 13 eligible participants; six participants did not respond to our invitation, three did not attend their scheduled interview, and four decided to withdraw their participation after they were scheduled for an interview. RTI/RSS did not attempt to contact the remaining 20 participants. See **Appendix A** for all materials that recruiters used when contacting eligible participants and scheduling interviews, including the initial contact email (**Appendix A-2**), the scripts for speaking with eligible participants on the telephone (**Appendix A-3**), the template for the calendar invitation (**Appendix A-4**), and the template for the reminder emails (**Appendix A-5**).

During Round 1, participants were asked to complete the interview on either a smartphone or a computer. Early in the data collection period, one participant participated in the interview on a tablet; however, as tablets were not a focus of this usability testing effort, no other participants were permitted to complete the interview on a tablet. This participant who completed on a tablet was counted as a computer interview for recruitment purposes. The recruitment team was flexible on the device that participants used (i.e., asked if the participant would prefer to participate on a desktop/laptop or a smartphone) until we got to the end of the interview period and asked participants if they were able to complete the interview on a specific device to meet recruitment goals. Device assignment had no observable impact on the pattern of results. During Round 2, we asked participants to use the same device that they used in Round 1 and all participants were able to do so.

Table 2.1. Recruitment Outcomes for Round 1 and Round 2 Usability Testing

Recruitment Outcomes – Round 1			
Outcome Category	Smartphone	Computer	Total
GOALS	40	40	80
Completed	38	42	80
No response			27
Refused			4
No show			18
Withdrawal			22
Recruitment Outcomes – Round 2			
Outcome Category	Smartphone	Computer	Total
GOALS	20–25	20–25	40–50
Completed	25	22	47
Did not contact			20
Contacted			60

Recruitment Outcomes – Round 2			
Outcome Category	Smartphone	Computer	Total
No response			6
Refused			0
No show			3
Withdrawal			4

Table 2.2 details the participant characteristics for the completed interviews from each round. These interviews sought to gather information from those with various employment statuses. First, for Round 1, it demonstrates that we nearly met the goal of completing at least 80% of interviews (i.e., at least 64) with participants living in a household with at least one other person. It also includes the Round 1 required recruitment goals of participants who are employed full time (35+ hours per week), those employed part time (<35 hours per week), those with more than one job, those who have hours that usually vary (including gig economy), those who are self-employed, those who are not working but actively looking for work, those who are not in the labor force (e.g., retired or disabled), and those who are not working and either not searching or only passively searching for jobs. **Table 2.2** also shows the two Round 1 soft recruitment criteria of participants who may be marginally attached to the labor force (e.g., discouraged workers) and those who had a deviation in their usual schedule in the reference week (on vacation, in school, temporarily ill, on jury duty).

For Round 2, all participant characteristics were defined by the screener data used in Round 1. Because Census Bureau/RTI/RSS staff were unsure what the attrition rate would be between Round 1 and Round 2, there were no specific Round 2 recruitment goals for the primary and secondary criteria listed in **Tables 2.1** and **2.2**.

Table 2.2. Primary Participant Characteristics for Round 1 and Round 2 Usability Testing

Primary Criteria: Household Composition				
Round	Round 1		Round 2	
Characteristic	Total	Goal	Total	Goal
Lives with >1 person	63	At least 64	39	–
Smartphone	28		20	
Computer	35		19	

Primary Criteria: Employed				
Round	Round 1		Round 2	
Characteristic	Total	Goal	Total	Goal
Full time	8	8	5	–
Smartphone	3		2	
Computer	5		3	
Part time	12	12	7	–
Smartphone	5		2	
Computer	7		5	
More than one job/gig workers	13*	12	7	–
Smartphone	4		3	
Computer	9		4	
Self-employed	11*	12	6	–
Smartphone	7		5	
Computer	4		1	
Primary Criteria: Not Working				
Round	Round 1		Round 2	
Characteristic	Total	Goal	Total	Goal
Actively looking for work	12	12	8	–
Smartphone	7	–	6	–
Computer	5	–	2	–
Not in the labor force	12	12	7	–
Smartphone	6	–	4	–
Computer	6	–	3	–
Not looking/passively searching	12	12	7	–
Smartphone	6	–	3	–
Computer	6	–	4	–
Non-required criteria				
Round	Round 1		Round 2	
Characteristic	Total	Goal	Total	Goal
Discouraged workers**	0	0+	0	–
Deviation in usual schedule	5	0+	3	–
Smartphone	1	–	1	–
Computer	4	–	2	–

*Note: Self-employed participants were likely to report having more than one job or being gig workers. This caused challenges in meeting the goal for those who are classified as self-employed during recruitment. Therefore, in order to meet our goal for the self-employed group, we conducted one interview with a participant who is self-employed with more than one job (but is not a gig worker/seasonal worker); resulting in 11 self-employed interviews and 13 interviews with those with more than one job/are gig workers.

**Note: “Discouraged workers” for recruitment purposes were defined as those who looked for work in the last year but not in the last 4 weeks based on responses to the Round 1 screener survey.

Table 2.3 further presents the soft recruitment goals of other demographic characteristics, such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography, of the participants of the usability testing interviews.

Table 2.3. Secondary Participant Characteristics for Round 1 and Round 2 Usability Testing Interviews

Characteristic	Secondary Criteria			
	Round 1		Round 2	
	Total	Goal	Total	Goal
Sex				
Male	29	At least 30	16	–
Race/Ethnicity				
Non-white non-Hispanic	16	At least 12	11	–
Hispanic	13	At least 12	7	–
Geography				
Northeast	16	At least 12	7	–
Midwest	19	At least 12	11	–
West	20	At least 12	11	–
South	25	At least 12	18	–
Education				
Less than college	36	At least 15	20	–
College graduate	26	At least 20	16	–
Post-graduate	18	At least 15	11	–
Age				
18–35	21	At least 15	12	–
36–50	28	At least 20	17	–
50+	31	At least 15	18	–

2.3 Usability Testing Methods

2.3.1 Overview

Usability testing consists of one-on-one interviews and is often employed to assess the functionality of web-administered questionnaires and surveys. For this effort, we employed usability testing methods to test an internet self-response survey of the CPS Core questionnaire, programmed in the Census Bureau's production environment. The focus of this testing was to determine whether there are any issues with usability that would result in errors or confusion or would otherwise hinder respondents from accurately completing the revised CPS Core instrument. The interviews used a protocol that included both observing the participants as they interacted with the website and survey as well as using retrospective pre-scripted probes (as described in **Section 2.3.2**). Spontaneous probes were used as needed to better understand usability issues not addressed by scripted probes.

2.3.2 Protocol and Procedures

All interviews were (1) conducted virtually using Microsoft Teams' videoconference capabilities, (2) conducted within the Census Bureau's Virtual Desktop Infrastructure (VDI) environment or on a Census Bureau-provided laptop, (3) audio-recorded or video- and audio-recorded, and (4) approximately 60 minutes long. Participants were asked to complete the interview using either a desktop/laptop computer or a smartphone. Participants received a \$50 digital gift card incentive during Round 1 and a \$60 digital gift card incentive during Round 2.

Census Bureau provided the RTI/RSS Team with the usability testing protocol to be used for data collection (see **Appendix B-1** for the Round 1 protocol and **Appendix B-2** for the Round 2 protocol). The interviews used a think aloud method and included additional retrospective scripted probing and spontaneous probing. To standardize the overall implementation of each test case, the test was carried out in the following sequence:

1. Obtain the participant's consent (see **Appendix C**).
2. Start video and audio recording using Census Bureau-approved software and a backup digital recorder.
3. Ask the participant to share their screen and log in to the survey (the login steps are detailed in **Section 3.2.1** and **Section 3.2.5**).
4. Ask the participant to answer the survey questions in the web instrument while thinking out loud. During this step, the interviewer observes and makes note about any issues.
5. (*Round 1 only*): Share their screen and open a satisfaction questionnaire programmed in Qualtrics (see **Appendix B-1**). The participant then told the interviewer how they would answer each question, and the interviewer filled this out for them.

6. Ask retrospective probes after the main interview (both scripted and spontaneous) while the interviewer shared their screen with screenshots of the survey for reference.
7. Complete the payment voucher.
8. Save the recording locally within Census Bureau's secure network environment.
9. Indicate on a tracking sheet the time on the recording that the interview began and ended.
10. Complete the summary template provided by Census Bureau following each interview on a flow basis and no more than 5 business days after each interview. These summaries contained exact words/phrases/sentences (when this information was important for the study goals) and included quotations that may be useful in illustrating a finding along with spontaneous verbalizations from the participants.

3. Findings

3.1 Introduction

This section summarizes the findings from both rounds of CPS Core usability testing. These findings are first presented by topic (i.e., the sections of the CPS survey that were of most interest in the testing protocol). Within each section, findings are presented separately for Round 1 and Round 2. Miscellaneous usability and cognitive findings are presented last. During usability testing, programming errors were found, since an early version of the instrument was still in development. These findings are not included in this report. All screenshots included in this report are test images and do not represent any participant information.

3.2 Survey Invitation Letter and Login Process

3.2.1 Round 1 Login process

During Round 1, the login process included the following steps. Once the participant reaches the survey website, they must enter information at three different screens (screenshots below) to log into the survey.

1. Access the survey:

Desktop/laptop: Interviewers sent the survey invitation letter (a PDF document) to the participant via email as an attachment (see **Appendix D**). This letter included the web address to access the survey and the participant's unique user ID. Sending the PDF helped to replicate the information respondents would receive via a postage mailing and/or email the first time they are invited to complete the CPS on the internet. Interviewers asked participants to access and log in to the survey using steps in this invitation letter as a guide.

Smartphones: Because reading a PDF document is difficult on the smaller smartphone screen and switching between the PDF and the survey login screen can be challenging on smartphones, these participants were not sent the survey invitation letter. Instead, interviewers gave the participants the web address for the survey either verbally or in the chat on Microsoft Teams. As a result, the study did not evaluate the usability of accessing the website on smartphones.

If the participant struggled, the interviewer asked what they would do if the interviewer was not there; the interviewer only provided instructions if the participant was unable to access the survey or log in.

As described in **Section 2.2.4**, in Round 1, participants generally chose whether to use a desktop/laptop or a smartphone to complete the interview. As we neared the end of the interview period, interviewers asked participants if they were able to complete the interview on a specific device to meet recruitment goals.

2. Verification code:

Once the participant accessed the web instrument, both desktop/laptop and smartphone participants needed to enter their email address into the text box on the first screen (**Figure 3.1**) to receive a verification code via email (**Figure 3.3** displays an example of the email participants receive with the verification code). Note, households in CPS data collection will be able to receive a verification code by text message, but this feature was unavailable in usability testing. Participants then accessed their email to get the verification code and entered this code into the text box on the second screen (**Figure 3.2**).

Figure 3.1. Round 1 First Login Screen Requesting Email

The screenshot displays the 'Current Population Survey' login page. The header includes the 'United States Census Bureau' logo and the title 'Current Population Survey' with an 'FAQ' link. The main content area is split into two columns. The left column, titled 'Welcome to the Current Population Survey', contains instructions for logging in, an email input field, a 'Continue' button, and a link for 'Need help logging in?'. It also includes a session expiration warning and a privacy notice. The right column shows a preview of an email invitation from the Director of the U.S. Census Bureau, addressed to a resident, detailing the survey's purpose and providing a link to respond.

Left Column (Login Screen):

United States Census Bureau
Current Population Survey
FAQ

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

Please log in using your email address. We use your email address to verify and provide access to your survey. If you are a returning interview, please use the same email you previously provided.

You will receive a one-time verification code in your email.

Email

[Need help logging in?](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning
You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/notices/privacy/privacy-policy.html>.
Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

Right Column (Email Invitation Preview):

If you were selected to participate in this survey, you would have received an invitation, like the one below.

U.S. Census Bureau
Washington, DC 20540-0001
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR

A Message from the Director of the U.S. Census Bureau:

Dear Resident,

Your address has been selected to participate in the **Current Population Survey**. This monthly survey is the source of the Nation's unemployment rate that you may hear about in the news. The U.S. Census Bureau conducts this survey in partnership with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

We are inviting you to respond to the Current Population Survey online.

Log into the website below using your email address and your User ID. Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.

Respond this week at: access.census.gov/cps

User ID: XXXXXXXXXX

Respond online by the end of this week. After that, a Census Bureau interviewer will contact you to complete the survey.

The success of this survey depends on your participation. We cannot substitute another address for yours. Your address is part of a scientifically selected sample of addresses chosen throughout the country. Your answers represent hundreds of other households like yours.

Answers to frequently asked questions are on the back of this letter. If you have other questions, please visit census.gov/cps or call 1-800-424-6974, #53939

Thank you in advance for participating in this important survey.

The first login screen for the CPS instrument, with the email input on the left and an image of the survey invitation on the right.

 An official website of the United States government [Here's how you know](#)

United States[®]
Census
Bureau

Current Po

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

Please log in using your email address. We use your email address to verify and provide access to your survey. If you are a returning interview, please use the same email you previously provided.

You will receive a one-time verification code in your email.

Email

Continue

[Need help logging in?](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/policies/privacy/privacy-policy.html>. Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

A zoomed in version of the left side of the first login screen, showing the instructions for entering the participant's email.

Figure 3.2. Round 1 Second Login Screen Requesting Verification Code

The screenshot shows the 'Current Population Survey' login page. The left side has a 'Welcome to the Current Population Survey' header, followed by instructions to enter a verification code from an email. There is a text input field for the code, a 'Verify' button, and a 'Resend email' link. Below this is a session expiration warning and a disclaimer about browser usage. The right side is a simulated email titled 'Your Census Bureau Verification Code' with the code 'XXXX-XXXX' displayed prominently. The email also includes a warning not to share the code and a footer stating the message was sent to the user's email address.

United States Census Bureau

Current Population Survey

FAQ

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

An email has been sent with your one-time verification code. Enter that code below.

Verification code

XXXX-XXXX

Verify

[Resend email](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/notice/privacy/privacy-policy.html>

Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

Check your email for the 8-digit verification code.

United States Census Bureau

Your Census Bureau Verification Code

Here is your one-time Census Bureau Verification Code:

XXXX-XXXX

Do not share this code with anyone. This code can only be used once, and will expire in 15 minutes. If you did not request a verification code, or if you have already signed into your survey, simply ignore this message and nothing will be changed.

This message was sent to you because someone attempted to access a Census Bureau survey with your email address. This email notification is generated by a computer; please DO NOT REPLY.

About the Census Bureau

The second login screen for the CPS instrument, with the verification code input on the left and an image of the email containing the verification code on the right.

An official website of the United States government [here's how you know](#)

United States[™]
Census
Bureau

Current P

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

An email has been sent with your one-time verification code. Enter that code below.

Verification code

Verify

[Resend email](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

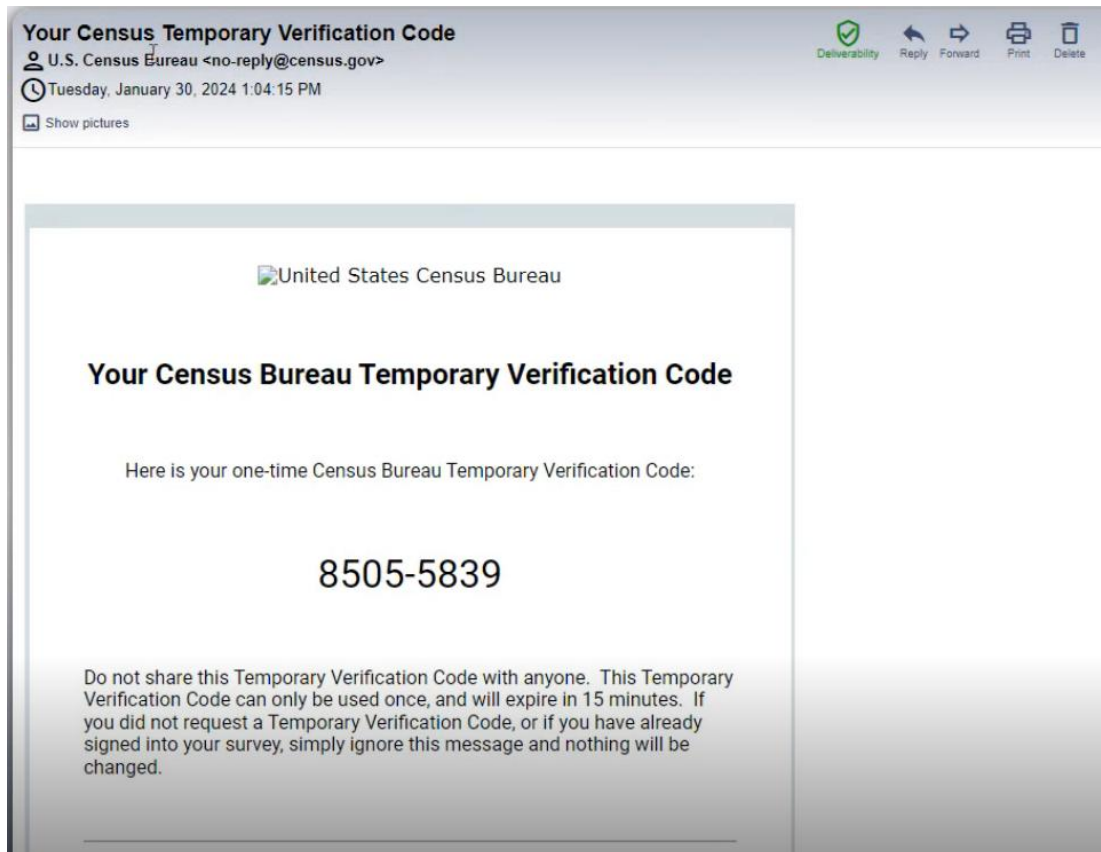
U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/policies/privacy/privacy-policy.html>

Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

A zoomed in version of the left side of the second login screen, showing the instructions for entering the verification code.

Figure 3.3. Round 1 Email Containing Verification Code



3. User ID:

The third screen (**Figure 3.4**) asked the participant to enter their unique user ID. This was included in the survey invitation letter that desktop/laptop participants received. The interviewer gave this user ID to smartphone participants either verbally or in the chat on Microsoft Teams.

Figure 3.4. Round 1 Third Login Screen Requesting User ID

An official website of the United States government [Here's how you know](#)

United States Census Bureau **Current Population Survey** **FAQ**

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

It looks like you are a first time user. Please enter the 12-digit User ID that can be found in the survey invitation you were sent.

Log in

[Not a first time user? Try another email.](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning
 You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/policies/privacy/notice.html>. Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

Census ID

U.S. Census Bureau
 Washington, DC 20540-0001
 OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR

A Message from the Director of the U.S. Census Bureau:

Dear Resident,

Your address has been selected to participate in the **Current Population Survey**. This monthly survey is the source of the Nation's unemployment rate that you may hear about in the news. The U.S. Census Bureau conducts this survey in partnership with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

We are inviting you to respond to the Current Population Survey online.

Log into the website below using your email address and your User ID. Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.

Respond this week at: [census.gov/ipeds](https://www.census.gov/ipeds)

User ID: XXXXXXXXXXXX

Respond online by the end of this week. After that, a Census Bureau interviewer will contact you to complete the survey.

The success of this survey depends on your participation. We cannot substitute another address for yours. Your address is part of a scientifically selected sample of addresses chosen throughout the country. Your answers represent hundreds of other households like yours.

Answers to frequently asked questions are on the back of this letter. If you have other questions, please visit [census.gov/ipeds](https://www.census.gov/ipeds) or call 1-800-424-6974, #53939.

Thank you in advance for participating in this important survey.

The third login screen for the CPS instrument, with the user ID input on the left and an image of the survey invitation on the right.

An official website of the United States government [Here's how you know](#)

United States[®]
Census
Bureau

Current P

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

It looks like you are a first time user. Please enter the 12-digit User ID that can be found in the survey invitation you were sent.

Log in

[Not a first time user? Try another email.](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/policies/privacy/privacy-policy.html>.

Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

A zoomed in version of the left side of the third login screen, showing the instructions for entering the user ID.

3.2.2 Round 1 Accessing the Survey and Survey Invitation Letter Findings

When asked about the survey invitation letter, most participants thought that the letter was easy to understand and said that they could easily find the information that they needed. For example, one participant said, "It was very informative. And the content of the letter was everything that I needed to know about the study" (P1328, computer). Similarly, another participant said, "It is pretty standard, pretty easy. It has text in bold, 'Current Population Survey', 'end of the week', that's clear. It has questions that are labeled on the second page. It highlights the important information well" (P1429, computer). However, one participant (P1977, computer) said that if they were reading the letter on their own, they would have stopped reading at the FAQ portion because it looked very "wordy" but

continued to read this section for the interview; this participant also noted that they did not understand what the legal/Office of Management and Budget information meant.

Several participants specifically mentioned that the look of the letter conveyed to them that this was a legitimate survey request. For example, one participant described the letter as “Official sounding. Your typical official usual official government sounding letter” (P1383, computer). However, one participant thought that the letter was not trustworthy: “If I got this unsolicited, I would think it’s kind of like a spam... I wouldn’t expect to receive something like this” (P1470, computer). This participant also thought that the font of the letter was too casual and seemed like a “college student put it together.”

A few participants had trouble finding the web address for the survey, likely because it does not start with “www.” The interviewer had to guide one of these participants (P1800 computer) on where to find the web address because they were not able to find it on their own. Another participant suggested during probing, “Just to make the website link stand out more I think so older people know ‘go to this website’, make that very clear because I was scanning it a few times and I was not clear on it” (P1666, computer).

Although they did not view the letter during testing, a few smartphone participants mentioned the use of a QR code rather than a web address to access the CPS from the letter (P1398, smartphone; P1591, smartphone; P2055, smartphone; P1980, smartphone).

“If I received it in a letter, I would’ve gone onto the website or maybe there’d be a QR code that I can scan with my phone camera and went to the website from there” (P1398, smartphone).

“I think it’s too much of a process so people might not want to type in certain things. I think if they got more up to date with what people do now, which is a QR code, that would get them better there and it would be a personalized QR code for that particular person” (P1591, smartphone).

“Usually I have, other websites, they have a QR code where you just take a picture of the QR code and it pops up instead of you having to enter it in manually” (P2055, smartphone).

3.2.3 Round 1 Login Process Findings

Overall, there were 54 participants who had no usability issues with the login process and were successfully able to log in to the survey, 20 participants who had minor issues but were easily able to navigate these issues on their own, and 5 participants who had major issues and required the interviewer’s assistance to log in. Additionally, one participant (P2141, computer) was unfamiliar with navigating to the web address and using their email. This participant had to be assisted by their spouse to log in. However, once logged in, the participant was able to complete the survey on their own.

Confusing the User ID and Verification Code

Some participants who completed their interview on the computer and were sent the survey invitation letter attempted to enter the User ID into the verification code field. Ten of these participants (all computer) were able to figure out the difference on their own (P1839, computer; P1327, computer; P1364, computer; P1450, computer; P1540, computer; P1644, computer; P1658, computer; P1977, computer; P2169, computer; P1883 computer), but five of these participants (4 computer, 1 smartphone) had to be guided through this process by the interviewer (P1804, computer; P1919, computer; P1696, computer; P2138, computer; P2133, smartphone). In addition, some of these participants desired advanced notice of the verification code in the survey invitation letter.

"It was pretty straightforward. At first I noticed the code to the website [User ID] so I had that confused at first, but once I realized they emailed me the verification code, I was able to cut and paste that easily and enter the other code that was given" (P1839, computer).

"It wasn't all inclusive. It asks me to log in and then it asks for a code that is not in the original letter. Does not inform you that there is another letter to look out for. A separate 'email' would be more clear" (P1919, computer).

"In the letter it doesn't say anything about a code, it just says, 'you're gonna need your email address and you're gonna need your user ID.' All of a sudden, when I go to the website, now I need a verification code. It would have been nice if it would have been included in the letter so it can be crystal clear" (P1364, computer).

"Me getting to this screen, going back to the email, maybe if I had known that there would be a second email with a verification code, but I was assuming it was going to the first ID [User ID]. I didn't know a verification code was going to need to be completed. Maybe the instructions in the letter should mention 'once you go to the website you will be asked to input a code', I feel like if that had been in the letter I wouldn't have been jumping around as much" (P1883, computer).

For some of these participants, the confusion was exacerbated by the fact that the survey invitation letter was emailed to these participants and the verification code was also sent via email; some of these participants did not understand that these were sent in two separate emails. This could potentially cause similar confusion for respondents in CPS production if the survey invitation letter will also be sent over email.

In addition, three participants who completed the interview on a smartphone were confused when the login screen asked for a User ID and did not know where it came from (P1294, smartphone; P1721, smartphone; P1330, smartphone). This was provided to them by the interviewer during the interview for testing and will not be the case in production; thus, this is not an issue that will be replicated.

Entering the Web Address, Verification Code, and User ID

Two participants had issues navigating to the web address. The first user (P1324, computer) copied the web URL for the survey from the PDF invitation letter but included several characters before the URL. This resulted in the participant being directed to a populated Google search rather than being directed to the proper website. This brought the participant to <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/cps.html>, which was the first result listed. This participant clicked on that result, and the website included some general information about the CPS. This participant scrolled on this web page to look for the survey but then the interviewer intervened to ask them to try the URL again. The second participant (P2029, computer) opened Google Chrome and typed "ACCESS.CENSUS.GOV/cps." However, this brought them to <https://access.census.gov/cps>, which says "Can't find your survey? Try one of those:" and lists a link to the Current Population Survey. The interviewer asked the participant to try on a different web browser. The participant used Microsoft Edge to open the web address and was able to open the survey successfully.

In addition, some participants had some trouble copying and pasting or entering the verification code (P1394, smartphone; P1614 smartphone; P2100 smartphone; P1733 smartphone; P1957 computer; P2205, smartphone; P1617 smartphone; P2055 smartphone) or the User ID (P1760 computer; P2029 computer). For issues relating to copying and pasting the verification code from the email, participants received the error message "Make sure your verification code is 8 digits"; this was usually caused by the fact that the dashes were copied and pasted into the text box. Finally, because the survey invitation letter for testing was sent to participants over email as an attached PDF, participants were unable to copy and paste the User ID. In CPS production, the email would be designed to contain this information in the text of the email instead of a PDF, which should limit this issue in production. However, participants who incorrectly entered the User ID did not receive an error message; rather, the screen just refreshed to the same screen. Note, this was planned for data collection but it was not programmed yet in time for usability testing. Some participants were able to navigate these issues with the verification code and the User ID by writing down the code/ID or memorizing the numbers before manually typing them into the text boxes.

Verification Code Findings

Sixteen participants used another device during the login process (11 participants using a computer to complete the survey and 5 participant using a smartphone to complete the survey); specifically, to access their email to get the verification code (P1328, computer; P1429, computer; P1563, computer; P1666, computer; P1760, computer; P1549, smartphone; P1618, smartphone; P1725, smartphone; P1283, computer; P1486, computer; P2019, computer; P1716, smartphone; P1440, smartphone; P1977, computer; P1415, computer; P1540, computer). Many of these participants said that they did this so that they

could keep the CPS login screen open in their browser and not have to go to another window/tab to check their email.

Eight participants (3 computer, 5 smartphone) mentioned that they did not mind getting the verification code over email but wanted the option to receive it via text, which will be an option in production (P1760, computer; P1578, smartphone; P1393, computer; P1498, smartphone; P1716, smartphone; P1876, smartphone; P2158, smartphone; P1957, computer).

[The interviewer asked if they would have preferred getting a text rather than an email] "I feel yes because then, if possible, it would have had that capability to pop up, where I didn't have to manually type it in." (P1760, computer). This participant has a Mac and an iPhone; iPhones offer a feature where verification codes received by text 'popup' to be filled into the fields with one click.

"Not much to think about. It would be nice to use my phone number and get it from there. On an iPhone, you don't have to go back and forth." (P1578, smartphone).

"Personally, I prefer a phone number because that way it just shows up with the code instead of having to go to my email and retrieve it, but it's simple enough." (P1498, smartphone).

Overall Login Process Findings

Many participants thought that the login screens were clear and felt that they understood what to do on each page. Participants also thought that the email containing the verification code was clear and appreciated that the verification code was displayed in large font. Furthermore, some participants commented that they were expecting or used to a two-step verification login process, which is used on many other websites and apps.

"Most of the sites and log ins that I have require two-factor identification to make sure that it isn't being used inappropriately or illegally or by inappropriate persons." (P2133, smartphone).

"So I think it was pretty easy. ... It was, I would say it's similar. I feel like a lot of places right now want two forms of verification anyways when logging in. So I guess I can definitely say it was pretty easy" (P1450, computer).

"I would expect to see that because that's what you get on every other website" (P1716, smartphone).

"I would say it's pretty comparable to other sites. I would say quite often, more than half, maybe at least 60%, a lot of sites send a confirmation code to your email or they send you a verification to your email, so I would say that's very common." (P1977, computer).

"Very similar, in the sense that most of these surveys or things where you're accessing information, you're getting that additional verification step, whether it's sending a text to your phone or an email to your inbox. It seems very standard I guess is what I would say for how we are accessing to verify you are who you are these days. Right on point to what I'm used to doing" (P2158, smartphone).

However, eight participants commented that either the verification code or the User ID was longer than what they were expecting or what they were used to (P1549, smartphone; P1568, smartphone; P1754, smartphone; P1294, smartphone; P1568, smartphone; P1576, smartphone; P1644, computer; P1696, computer). They noted this made it more difficult to enter the code.

"It's longer than the usual code. A little bit longer than the usual codes. I think they're usually like five digit or so. But you know, longer is safer" (P1549, smartphone).

"The code is a little long, if you're trying to remember it off the top of your head, you're not gonna be able to and that's something that would be really useful in the use of a verification code, is something you can remember real quick and transfer the info" (P1754, smartphone).

"The only thing is, with the code, it's a 12-digit code with letters and numbers, which, I mean, it's big. It would be nice if there was just a 4-digit code so you can... look at your email and put in the 4-digit code. But a 12-digit code, you have to go back and forth and I had to write it down" (P1294, smartphone).

"So this is the email with the actual code. Yeah I think it's fine. The code is kind of long. Eight digits. Typically they're like four-to-six. Maybe it's a little harder to like remember and bring over to where I'd like to enter it" (P1568, smartphone).

"I was annoyed that it had to be like more than seven digits. So it had to be hard to remember. And then I couldn't find something to write with. I don't know why they had to use eight digits" (P1576, smartphone).

Furthermore, 16 participants (9 computer, 7 smartphone) thought that the login process was burdensome because it had more steps than what they were expecting (P1563, computer; P1666, computer; P1800, computer; P1395, smartphone; P1549, smartphone; P1568, smartphone; P1576, smartphone; P1283, computer; P1330, smartphone; P1364, computer; P1434, computer; P1658, computer; P1591, smartphone; P1977, computer; P2129, smartphone; P1644, computer).

"It almost seems like a double login. Not double login. I'm trying to think. So the flow with this that you would go to the link on the letter and then you would type in your email, then you get an emailed code, you paste that code in there and then you

get this screen and you have to enter in a user ID. I guess what I'm used to is either you normally log in with a user ID or an email only. But I also understand that since this is the Census maybe you guys don't equate user IDs and emails in the same way that most websites do. When you log in, it's usually username and password or email and password" (P1563, computer).

"It was like three steps instead of like 'do you have a user ID from the letter' instead of saying what's your email [on the first screen] just say what's the user ID" (P1666, computer).

"I feel like it's unnecessary, because I received a physical letter, that's already something that's gonna be hard to spoof... I have a 16-digit code and at the end it asked for email address again, so it seems like why do I have to step away from this flow to go to my email to grab a number to come back to it? Maybe there's a good reason, I don't know, I'm not a security person" (P1800, computer).

"The user ID piece feels a little unexpected. I would think like once I kind of created my account and got the verification it should be able to like use my email I guess as like my ID if I need to come back in the future" (P1568, smartphone).

"Well here's my question. You know how they sent me the four digit, um, the eight-digit code and then you had to read me the 13-digit code? Is that always going to be the case? Are they going to make people do two different keys like that? That's a lot! I understand getting sent one through email. That's fine. People are trained for that. But getting two? That's a lot" (P1576, smartphone).

"This can get kind of confusing, like having multiple tabs open. Like I have a letter tab PDF open, and then I have my email open with the verification code, and then I'm going back to the letter, and then I'm on the website. I feel like it's a lot of back and forth. If there was a way to make it more streamlined and more easier [sic] it might be a little bit more smoothly, but I think you have to do that to verify someone's identity before they do the survey so I get it from that perspective" (P1330, smartphone).

"Well this one that we did, and I don't know if it's because of this that we're doing, but it felt like there was three steps to do, because I had to do the website, and then I had to do the User ID, and then had to put in that other number. ... This felt a little clutzy" (P1658, computer).

"It was a basic standard screen, but I think with seeing four screens within the first couple of getting into something, I think that's a bit much. 'Cause I've seen four different screens so far before I even started" (P2129, smartphone).

3.2.4 Round 1 Recommendations

The recommendations that follow could potentially make the login process clearer to participants because some were not expecting the multiple steps required to log in. The recommendations could also make the login process easier for participants, as some thought that the process was burdensome.

- Consider making the web address more prominent on the survey invitation. When sent to participants over email, consider making this a hyperlink. Also consider ensuring that participants can copy and paste their User ID from the invitation when it is sent through email.
- Because of the study limitations, we did not evaluate the usability of accessing the website on smartphones. More usability testing of accessing the survey on smartphones should be done before conclusions can be made.
- Consider adding a QR code that links to the CPS web address if the invitation is sent in the mail.
- Consider describing the three steps of the login process in the survey invitation.

- Recommendation for survey invitation wording for email:

Please respond by the end of this week.

Follow these steps to login to the survey:

1. **Click** here to log in: [**access.census.gov/cps**](https://access.census.gov/cps)
2. Enter your **email address** and check your email to get the **verification code**. *Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.*
3. Enter your **User ID**: XXX-XXX-XXXX

- Recommendation for survey invitation wording sent in mail:

Please respond by the end of this week.

Follow these steps to login to the survey:

1. Enter this **web address** into your browser: [**access.census.gov/cps**](https://access.census.gov/cps)
OR scan this QR code: [IMAGE]
2. Enter your **email address** and check your email to get the **verification code**. *Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.*
3. Enter your **User ID**: XXX-XXX-XXXX

- On the login screen, consider labeling the User ID text box with "User ID," similar to how the email box and verification code box are labeled.

3.2.5 Round 2 Login Process

When a respondent is a returning user to the Census Bureau's survey site, the login process is only two steps. Once they arrive at the website, they must enter the same email they

used to log into the website originally. Next, an 8-character verification code is sent to that email, and they must enter the verification code to enter their survey. They are not asked for their User ID as a returning user.

These login screens were modified due to feedback received in Round 1 that the User ID and verification code were confused with one another. On the first screen requesting the user's email address, "8-digit" was added as a descriptor of the verification code in the instructions: "You will receive an 8-digit verification code in your email" (see **Figure 3.5**). On the second screen where users are asked to enter the verification code, the introduction text was revised to: "Please enter the 8-digit verification code sent to you by email. This is not the same as the User ID in your survey invitation." The label for the write-in box was modified to "Verification Code (8-digit)" (see **Figure 3.6**).

During Round 2 of the usability testing, participants were not given a survey invitation letter regardless of the device they were using (as described in **Section 2.2.4**, we asked participants to use the same device that they had used in Round 1, that is, either a smartphone or a computer/desktop). Interviewers gave all participants the web address to access the survey either verbally or in the chat on Microsoft Teams. Once accessed, participants would enter their email address, receive an email with the verification code, and enter the verification code on the next screen. Like in Round 1, if the participant struggled, the interviewer asked what they would do if the interviewer was not there; the interviewer only provided instructions if the participant was unable to access the survey or log in.

Figure 3.5. Round 2 First Login Screen Requesting Email

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

Please log in using your email address. We use your email address to verify and provide access to your survey. If you are returning to the survey, please use the same email you previously provided.

You will receive an 8-digit verification code in your email.

Email

Continue

[Need help logging in?](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Figure 3.6. Round 2 Second Login Screen Requesting Verification Code

Current Population Survey

Please enter the 8-digit verification code sent to you by email. This is not the same as the User ID in your survey invitation.

Verification code (8-digit)

Verify

[Resend email](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close) because they will take you to the wrong page.

United States Census Bureau

Your Census Bureau Verification Code

Here is your one-time Census Bureau Verification Code:

XXXX-XXXX

Do not share this code with anyone. This code can only be used once, and will expire in 15 minutes. If you did not request a verification code or if you have already signed into your survey, simply ignore this message and nothing will be changed.

This message was sent to you because someone attempted to access a Census Bureau survey with your email address. This email notification is generated by a computer please do not reply.

About the Census Bureau

We serve as the nation's leading provider of quality data about its people and economy. The Census Bureau is the federal government's largest statistical agency. As the world's premier statistical agency, we are dedicated to making our nation a better place. Policy-makers, businesses, and the public use our data to make informed decisions.

3.2.6 Round 2 Login Process Findings

Overall, participants had fewer usability issues with the login process in Round 2 than in Round 1. As this was the second time that participants were logging into the survey, this could be due to familiarity with the process and learning that took place during the first login. Of the five participants who experienced major issues with logging into the survey in Round 1 and required assistance from the interviewer, three participated in a Round 2 interview. Only one of these participants experienced major issues with logging into the survey in Round 2, indicating that these participants' familiarity with the login process and assistance from the interviewer in Round 1 could have contributed to experiencing fewer issues in Round 2. Across all of the Round 2 participants, 39 participants had no usability issues with the login process and were successfully able to log in to the survey, 7 participants had minor issues but were easily able to navigate these issues on their own, and 2 participants who had major issues and required the interviewer's assistance to log in.

Most participants who did not have any usability issues logging into the survey thought that the process was easy.

"This looks really similar to a lot of the pages that I have encountered that asks for a code. It seems like everyone is doing a two-step verification now so it has a place to enter in a code that was sent to my email and then click submit so it looks really standard from things I've seen on other sites or logins that ask for a verification code" (P1429, computer).

"This is pretty easy. I feel like a lot of websites have done this kind of thing before where they send a code to my email and I plug it in for security. This is, you know, the usual what I expect" (P1470, computer).

However, some participants encountered a few minor usability issues, as described below.

A few participants were unsure about some steps of the login process and asked the interviewer if they would give them the verification code or if they should check their email (P1294, smartphone; P1839, computer; P1658, computer). This seems to be an artifact of the interview, where interviewers gave some participants a User ID to log in during Round 1 and these participants seemed to remember that interviewers needed to give them a code during Round 1. However, once the interviewers clarified about the verification code, participants understood that they needed to check their email to get the verification code. One of these participants wanted the instructions on the verification code screen to be clearer: "I think you could be clearer here by saying an email was sent to you, please check for the code or something...I think it could be clearer because it says please enter what was sent to you, it should say, in my opinion, a verification code was sent to you, please enter it" (P1658, computer).

A few participants were unsure about which email address to use because they had multiple email addresses, and they did not remember which one they entered before (P1440, smartphone; P1716, smartphone). One participant initially entered a different email from Round 1 but was instructed to use the correct email by the interviewer and were able to log in (P1549, smartphone).

"I had some technical [issues], but it wasn't that bad...It's probably easier for people who have one email, but I have two emails, because I have the iPad and the iPhone" (P1440, smartphone).

"Oh, by the way, I didn't know what my email address was. I have multiple email addresses so I don't know if I would have known what the email address would have been" (P1716, smartphone).

Some participants said that they would have preferred to receive the verification code over text than email because it is easier to provide verification codes that come through text message (P2158, smartphone; P1760, computer; P1726, smartphone; P1716 smartphone):

"I probably get the option to auto populate from text more than email... often times when I receive a text message with a code, my phone, once I tap that box, it will allow me to just like 'boop', it pulls that number, and then I don't have to copy and paste. With notifications from a text, they automatically will come through on my phone right away without me having to pull up another application, like my email, and go in my email, and make sure it's refreshed. Not a huge issue but I do feel when something like this comes up, text message is what I would pick, as far as if it gives me the option like do you want this via text or via email, 10 times out of 10 I'm probably picking send it to me by text" (P2158, smartphone).

"The one suggestion I'd make is maybe offer instead of email, phone numbers, that might be easier. I've noticed from my experience when it's something where it has to be emailed... I'm lucky if I'm on my computer and I can just click to another tab and go to my email. But if I'm on my phone, then I have to leave the Internet browser to go to my Gmail app and sometimes I can't copy and paste it... it's 2 more seconds I have to use, but it can be a bit confusing, for older people, far more confusing, especially not tech savvy people. I've noticed when it's the cell phone, I like how for me, that number kind of attaches so if I'm on that website and I put my cell phone and I get the ding and I can automatically fill it and it just doesn't take me from the task at hand" (P1760, computer).

"Yeah, you basically put in your email, get your digit and go on from there. Very simple, very easy. I would rather prefer to get a text because I'm doing it on my phone, and on my phone, if I'm doing it on my phone a text can be brought up, I can just copy and paste. If it's the email, I have to [inaudible] go back to the email, so I'd rather get a text" (P1726, smartphone).

"Yeah the text message is a lot easier because the phone remembers what that is. Although, you know, then you might have my email, my telephone number but it's faster" (P1716, smartphone).

Alternatively, one participant noted that the lack of autofill made the verification seem "real": "Usually, sometimes it saves on my email and I don't have to like remember the numbers but I, I like the fact that you have to remember the numbers from this one just so you know it's, it's real" (P2055, smartphone).

One participant (P1754, smartphone) had difficulty navigating on their smartphone between the web browser and their email app. This seemed to be a user error and not a usability issue with the website. This is an example of the difficulties transitioning between apps that those preferring a text message verification described.

One participant had some difficulty with copying and pasting the verification code but was able to manually type it in (P1395, smartphone). Another received an error message when they pasted the code because of an extra space at the end of the code but quickly resolved this by clicking into the verification box and deleting the extra space (P1591, smartphone). One other participant mentioned that they did not try to copy and paste because they said that verification codes with a dash sometimes do not copy/paste well (P1616, smartphone).

"Once I cut and paste the, the digit, I guess I didn't realize that you had to press 'Enter' on the digit itself or it's going to make it seem like it didn't give you, you didn't put the eight digits...Going back to it and just seeing maybe if I made a mistake. Or sometimes if you add an extra space, it won't take it, so when I went

back in there and kind of got to the end of it, then it put the, the, the sign or the warning away" (P1591, smartphone).

For one participant (P1919, computer using Safari), the email containing the verification code took an unusually long amount of time to send. After a few minutes of waiting, the participant wanted to enter their email again. On the screen asking for the verification code, they clicked the back button in their browser, but when they tried to enter their email address again, the screen just refreshed without moving forward. They checked their email again, saw that they received the email, went back to the login page, and clicked the forward button in their browser. From here, they were able to enter the verification code and log in successfully. During probing, the interviewer asked them if they saw the "Resend email" button, and the participant said that they did not: "I didn't notice it, but I should have assumed it was there and looked for it. That's my bad, I shouldn't have been quick to use the browser to go back to the previous page. That's interesting if it's a glitch if someone does click back on their browser, it might cause the continue button not to work."

3.2.7 Round 2 Recommendations

The few usability issues that participants experienced during the login process were minor, so no major changes are recommended. However, a few recommendations, described below, could potentially make the process easier for participants.

- Consider making the "Resend email" button larger to make it more visible to participants.
- If participants attempt to use the back button in the browser on this screen, a message such as the following could appear: "Confirm form resubmission."

3.3 Household Roster

3.3.1 Round 1 Household Roster Functionality

During Round 1, participants were asked to list everyone that lived in their household (see **Figure 3.7**). To ensure that the CPS instrument did not take up too much time during the usability interview, interviewers asked participants to only add up to three individuals to the household roster (if applicable) and to list individuals who were age 15 years old and older (if there were children younger than 15 years old in the household). Participants could add children under 15 years old if there were not three people in the household ages 15 years old or older.

Figure 3.7. Round 1 Household Roster Screen

What are the names of all persons living or staying here? Start with the name of the person, or one of the persons, who owns or rents this home.

Enter one person on each line. Enter names until you have listed everyone who lives or stays here, then click next.

First name Last name

  Remove

[+ Add another person](#)

[Back](#) [Next](#)

After participants finished listing all household members, the instrument asks them to confirm the list, with options to add or remove individuals (**Figure 3.8**).

Figure 3.8. Round 1 Household Roster Confirmation Screen

Please review all of the people we have listed living or staying here. When you are finished making updates, press the Continue button.

Joe Poe  Remove

Liz Poe  Remove

[+ Add another person](#)

[Continue](#)

3.3.2 Round 1 Findings

Overall, most participants did not have any usability issues with the household roster screens and thought that the process of adding household members was easy. When asked what they thought of this process, some explained:

“Well it was pretty easy. You just put the first person's name and the person's last name and then you press 'add another person' if you want to add more than that” (P1324, computer).

“I think it was easy, it just asks for first name and last name, and then you just click the button to add an extra person. It was self-explanatory” (P1327, computer).

“I thought it was very easy. Obviously first and last name and could add another person or remove them. The buttons were clear, the fields were clear and easy to understand” (P1451, computer).

"Absolutely... whoever designed this was really thinking clearly because the remove button is obvious and the 'add another person' is obvious... it's very clear" (P1804, computer).

"I thought it was very easy. ... Yeah it was clear what it was asking and it made it easy like if I needed to remove any or add another one it was, it was easy to do" (P1880, smartphone).

However, two participants thought that the household roster confirmation screen (**Figure 3.8**) was unclear. While filling out the survey, one participant (P1800 computer) seemed a little confused about this screen at first and re-read the instructions before they realized what it was asking: "Oh, like if I missed someone. After all those questions about if you missed someone, it's asking me [again]."

The second participant (P1754, smartphone) thought that this screen was asking for information about when each person moved into the household. "Okay this is asking me for the dates or which day they started living here, I guess? It's sort of unclear." [The interviewer asked if it was clear what they needed to do on this screen.] "No. What are we supposed to do with this screen?...Are we supposed to like touch the name and then add the dates or something? It's not letting you know what to do." [The interviewer asked if the interviewer was not there, what would they do?] "I would just continue without filling anything in."

In addition, it was unclear to some participants that they needed to add themselves to the household roster. Seven participants asked the interviewer to confirm that they should add themselves on the initial household roster screen (P1328, computer; P1617, smartphone; P1618, smartphone; P1760, computer; P1883, computer; P2158, smartphone; P1297, smartphone). Five other participants did not add themselves to the household roster until the interviewer instructed them to do so (P1395, smartphone; P1533, computer; P1754, smartphone; P1885, smartphone; P2138, computer). If participants were instructed to add themselves to the roster, they had no issues completing this.

"So, I think I was trying to, I was kind of zipping through, which I usually do on most things that I do. I was zipping through without really fully reading it and that's where I missed adding myself" (P1395, smartphone).

[The interviewer asked the participant what we could do to make it clearer that they should include themselves] "Just maybe say... put the first person as the person who's filling this Census out, the first person, make yourself... If I would have known I would have put myself first" (P1754, smartphone).

"I thought that was pretty simple. The only note that I had is I would suggest—I put my name cause I just assumed you wanted everyone who lives there including myself, but some people might think you want the people living in my house other

than myself. So I would suggest maybe making it say like please include yourself in this list, just in case some people don't get that" (P1760, computer).

It should also be noted that some participants did not list themselves first because of the instruction on the page, "Start with the name of the person, or one of the persons, who owns or rents this home."

Finally, a few participants had some trouble deciding who they should include in the household roster.

One participant (P1957, computer) expressed some confusion about the order in which to list their household roster and shared that their dad and husband live in the residence. This participant decided to list the roster order as themselves, their husband, and then their dad. This participant also expressed confusion about whether to add their kids to the roster, even though their kids are both currently in college and do not live at the residence most of the year. The interviewer then instructed them to only include up to three household members for the purpose of the interview. This participant suggested that it would be helpful to have a help icon on the roster screen that participants can click on to learn who should be included in the provided roster: "... I would have... something you could click here that could further explain 'include this, don't include this' ...to help clarify that [who should be included in the household roster].... There might be specific situations where people have questions and since this is online, I am guessing that no one would want to call in to ask...."

Another participant (P1303, computer) was unsure how to answer the question about main residence for their children because they live at both their residence and their second parent's residence: "This I'm not sure because I'm divorced and my kids spend half the week at their dad's house so I mean, she has two residences. ... There's nowhere for me to specify that so I'm still going to click 'yes'."

Another participant (P1733, smartphone) said they were unsure how to handle ambiguous situations, although this did not affect how they answered the CPS instrument for their current situation: "My dad used to come and stay with me for like a month. So, like, I would assume I would put that down. But if I did put down like his name and then the questions after were 'does he live there' or does he stay there' or is he staying there right now'. I don't have that situation right now, but I guess if someone lived here or was staying here. I have two daughters. One of them is in-between apartments so she'll stay here for a week or two. Right now I don't have that situation but I did." As the participant explained, they did not list their dad or their daughters as members of their current household on the CPS survey, but wondered how they would answer these questions if these family members were temporarily staying with them.

3.3.3 Round 1 Recommendations

CPS respondents including themselves in the household roster is a major data quality issue. Therefore, we recommend making it clearer that respondents should add themselves to the household roster.

- Recommendation for wording on the household roster screen:

What are the names of all persons living or staying here?

Enter one person on each line. Enter names until you have listed everyone who lives or stays here, then click next.

Please start by entering your name.

Furthermore, because some participants were unsure whether to include some individuals in the household roster with ambiguous living arrangements, BLS and the Census Bureau could consider providing a “Help” page with more instructions about who to include in the household roster.

3.3.4 Round 2 Household Roster Functionality

During Round 2, participants were shown the list of household members that they entered during Round 1, with the sex and age of each person (**Figure 3.9**). Participants had the option to edit the information of the household members listed, remove individuals from the household roster (except for the first person listed), and add additional people.

Figure 3.9. Round 2 Household Roster Screen

Previously, it was reported that the following people were living or staying at this address.

Please list everyone who is living or staying at this address. Remove anyone who is no longer living or staying there. When you have finished listing the names of everyone who lives or stays there, press “Continue”.

Select “Edit” to update or correct information about a person in the household.

Mario Martinez Male; 39 years old	Edit
Suzi Martinez Female; 37 years old	Remove Edit

+ Add another person

Back Continue

When participants arrived at this screen, interviewers adhered to the following protocol, gathering data on the usability of the feature to add and remove people from the household roster:

- Wait to see if the participant adds or removes anyone spontaneously.
- Ask the participant to remove someone under the age of 15, if applicable.
- Ask the participant to add a fake person and then remove that fake person from the household roster.

If a household member is removed, participants see a pop-up message (**Figure 3.10**).

Figure 3.10. Round 2 Remove Household Member Confirmation Pop-up Message



After the participant clicks “Yes,” they are then asked to indicate why they are removing this person (**Figure 3.11**).

Figure 3.11. Round 2 Remove Household Member Reason Question

What is the reason for removing this person?

☐ Person deceased

☐ Person moved out

☐ Person left - usual residence elsewhere last month

☐ Delete person - to correct previous mistake

☐ Person has a usual residence elsewhere this month

Continue

If participants click the “Edit” button (shown in **Figure 3.9**), they are routed to a new screen (**Figure 3.12**) where they can edit the demographic characteristics for that individual.

Figure 3.12. Round 2 Household Member Edit Screen

Please review the data for each household member and select edit if needed to make updates.

- RICK MARTINEZ		
Question	Answer	Issue
Sex	Male	No issues found!
Age	45	No issues found!
Ever serve on active duty in U.S. Armed Forces	No	No issues found!
Education	HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATE- high school DIPLOMA or the equivalent (For example: GED)	No issues found!
Race		No issues found!

Each row in the table has an "Edit" button to its right.

Once participants enter one of these demographic questions to edit the information (e.g., date of birth and age), they are given the option to either “Return to Review,” which would take them back to the edit screen, or click “Next” to go to the next demographic question to edit, as shown in **Figure 3.13**.

Figure 3.13. Round 2 Household Member Edit Demographic Information

What is Rachel Stenger's date of birth?

Please fill Rachel Stenger's birth Month, Day and Year. [Help](#)

Month Day Year

-Select- -Select- -Select-

Verify or enter correct age as of February 25, 2025. For babies less than 1 year old, do not enter the age in months. Enter 0 as the age.

Age

30 Years old

Return to Review

Back Next

3.3.5 Round 2 Findings

As described in **Section 3.3.2**, some participants did not enter themselves in the household roster and had to be instructed to do so by the interviewer during Round 1; other participants did not list themselves first. We note that the Round 1 instructions asked users to start with the person who owns or rents the home, which could have caused some participants to not enter themselves first. Some participants also did not realize they needed to enter themselves at all. In cases where the interviewer instructed them to do so, they were listed last in the household roster.

In the Round 2 instrument, on the household roster screen, Person 1 was programmed to be the participant; therefore, there is no “Remove” button (see **Figure 3.9** above). This caused some routing and fill issues later in the survey during usability testing where some questions were directed toward “you” but were referring to Person 1, a different member of the household. This has been revised in the CPS instrument and any issues found in testing due to this error have not been included here.

Adding and Removing Household Members

Overall, most participants did not have any major usability issues adding or removing individuals from the household roster (**Figure 3.9**).

Only three participants spontaneously added or removed people from their household roster without instruction from the interviewer to do so (P1616, smartphone; P1804, computer; P1980, smartphone).

A few participants were unsure if they needed to add individuals to their household roster. One participant (P1733, smartphone) shared that they started renting a room in their house to a tenant and asked if they should be added to the household. When the interviewer asked what they would do on their own, the participant said, “I would probably be inclined to not to add him just because a) it's easier for me and then b) because I don't know his birthday off the top of my head so I would have to... look up what his birthday is and so it's obviously a lot easier to skip it and not add him. Especially if I know he is just here temporarily.” Later in the interview, this participant also mentioned that their daughter occasionally lived with them and if this interview had happened during that time, they would add their daughter to the household roster. Similarly, another participant noted that a definition of “living with you” would be helpful:

“It's very easy. You just click on Add another person. One thing that you might add to the screen that I don't know if it matters is what's your definition of someone that's living with you. Are they staying there a week? That's their only home? Are they staying there at least a month? That might need to be cleared up a little bit. If somebody is staying with me, they could be here for two weeks on vacation, do I add them? I don't think I do because

they're not resident, but if somebody lost their place to live and they need to stay with me until their new apartment is available, that I might consider them living with me" (P1658, computer).

Whether they did it spontaneously or because they were instructed by the interviewer, most participants did not have any usability issues with adding or removing participants.

"It was pretty easy, it shows what to do, it shows 'add another person' and a plus sign so that's pretty self-explanatory and then it asks the basic questions that it did initially for me and the other person in my household so that was easy" (P1429, computer).

"Yes, it was either confirm that, that it is, that's who is in the household or if you had to remove them, it has that 'Remove' button. Or if needed to add someone it had, did have the 'Add' button. So it was basic, very clear" (P1591, smartphone).

Remove Person Confirmation Pop-Up

Most participants said that they appreciated this pop-up asking them to confirm (**Figure 3.10**).

"Well I think it's good because they want to make sure that you're aware that you're about to remove someone. So that's just a reminder. Are you sure you want to remove this person? Yeah, that was pretty cool" (P1328, computer).

"I like that because if you made a mistake the person would be gone and this is asking if you are sure and you can say no and change your mind, so those things are pretty important," (P1721, smartphone).

"I like the pop up. I like that it does ask you, are you sure you want to do this, because sometimes you can accidentally click on something, I've experienced that, where I didn't want to click that and then I have to click all the way back and put it in. So knowing that this is something where you have to do some work before deleting it, just to be sure" (P1760, computer).

"I always like a confirmation though, so I was glad it was there. It makes me feel better, if you're doing something permanent on a thing, that it does make you double check" (P2158, smartphone).

"I like that it gives you that little warning to make sure that you actually are deleting it, or not, or not wanting to delete it. So it's just like a little reminder like 'are you sure you're doing it?" (P1450, computer).

"That's good because sometimes people rush through things and at least, at least they're confirming that, 'yes, what I'm doing is correct" (P1591, smartphone).

However, there were a few participants who had minor issues with the pop-up message.

One participant (P1568, smartphone) thought that the pop-up message showed up too high on the screen: "I clicked the remove and it looks like it's kind of popping up a little high on the screen, which maybe could be better but I see it and I guess I'll just click yes."

One participant noted that the order of Yes/No in the pop-up was inconsistent with previous pop ups they encountered: "I thought it was easy to follow. 'Yes' is in bold. The only thing maybe that might be confusing is usually 'yes' comes before 'no', so maybe switching it to yes and no, and having yes on the left might be easier, but [that would] only [affect them] if someone is rushing" (P2034, computer).

One participant found the pop-up unnecessary: "I thought it was, just a double check, making sure you want to actually remove it before removing it... It might have been like an unnecessary step. I don't—I hate that, because lots of different apps and stuff, it makes you double check. Some is good, you want to do a double check, and some of it it's just like ehh ok I wanted to remove it, I wanted to do whatever I wanted to do... Yeah, cause I wanted to remove, that should be sufficient enough that I wanted to remove the first time without the pop up" (P1712, smartphone).

Reason why the Person is Removed

As described in **Section 3.3.4**, if participants did not do this spontaneously, interviewers instructed participants to add and then remove a fake household member, in order to gather data on the usability of this adding and removing process. Once participants arrived at the question asking why they removed this person from their household (**Figure 3.11**), interviewers asked participants to provide feedback on this question wording and asked if anything was unclear or confusing, while acknowledging that this question may not apply to their current household situation (i.e., if they were removing a fake household member). Only one participant spontaneously removed a real household member from the household roster without instruction from the interviewer (P1980, smartphone).

Many participants said that some of the response options were confusing or unclear and thought that some of the response options were overlapping (P1294, smartphone; P1563, computer; P1568, smartphone; P1616, smartphone; P1618, smartphone; P1733, smartphone; P1800, computer; P1875, computer; P1919, computer; P1980, smartphone; P2140, smartphone; P2158, smartphone; P1658, computer; P1716, smartphone; P2019, computer; P2133, smartphone). Specifically, participants had trouble with differentiating between the options "Person moved out," "Person left – usual residence elsewhere last month," and "Person has a usual residence elsewhere this month" (**Figure 3.11**).

"Typically I would see this worded differently... By worded differently I think the question is fine. [Person deceased] is fine, 'moved out' is fine. I think [Person left - usual residence elsewhere last month] is a little confusing. Person left, person has a

usual residence elsewhere this month. Elsewhere last month. Typically I'm used to just seeing this as 'person has a usual residence elsewhere'. I guess these questions are fine. It's just the inconsistency that these two options are presented. So 'person has a usual residence elsewhere this month' - I think that's fine... Basically what I'm saying is the way it's phrased it makes me want to read it twice to grasp it. I'm trying to think of another way it could be phrased. 'Person is living in a different residence this month'? I would only expect to see this option ['person has a usual residence elsewhere this month'] if it was listed previously. I don't know" (P1563, computer).

"Maybe it would make more sense to say their usual residence was elsewhere last month. I guess person left, is that a permanent thing, it's not totally clear what that means to me. I think the last option makes a little more sense, like okay they're not here because this month maybe they're somewhere else. But if I'm taking the survey now, is that basically saying they left last month and they haven't come back? And I don't know how different that is from moving out, maybe it's up to interpretation. But then I guess I would put the third and the fifth option together and put delete at the bottom, because it feels like not an actual reason that this person moved out, it's just a mistake. But yeah, it's hard to understand what the third one should be, maybe because it doesn't apply to me" (P1568, smartphone).

"Ok died, that is valid, moved out - ok bye, person left - usual residence elsewhere last month" [Interviewer asked: Does that seem odd to you?] "A little bit - so they left because they were previously somewhere else before so it seems they just go month to month maybe. Is that what it is telling me?..." (P1618, smartphone).

"That's another thing too, what's the difference between 'moved out' and 'left'--left presuming they're coming back and move out being more permanent? Yeah, I think I would be a little confused, if somebody left my house, I'm questioning which one would be--maybe one is more, like I said, permanent, like left is presuming they're coming back maybe?" (P2158, smartphone).

"I think they should put deceased at the end or something, I don't know, deceased is kind of...I don't like it at the beginning...I don't get Person left-usual residence elsewhere last month, Person has a usual residence elsewhere this month. That's a little bit confusing...It means that person stayed someplace else more of the month last month...They left. They didn't stay with me last month. And then this one means I declared the person here at my house last month but now they're someplace else this following month" (P1658, computer).

"Does this mean person left for their usual residence elsewhere last month? Usual residence elsewhere last month, that's what I think it would mean. Delete person to correct previous mistake. Mistake is what? That I maybe typed the information

wrong? Person has usual residence elsewhere this month. Ok well, I mean, I don't have a lot of situations where I have people moving in and out, but these are probably interesting questions that you would have to think through. From my personal side, it would be like they went to college or they moved out, even though there's probably a lot of different reasons why he moved out. I don't know if that's helpful for you to understand. But obviously, you know, deceased makes sense" (P1716, smartphone).

"Well I don't know how much you guys care about this but the use of the verbs is different. So this should probably be person died if you're going to say person moved out. Person left usual residence last month? I don't even understand what that means. I really don't know what that means. Delete person to correct previous mistake so that should just say entered by mistake" (P2019, computer).

"Well 'usual residence' it just it, I thought that it would be like permanent residence or, or like, or if I was like subletting or anything, like that type of nature. So it's like if somebody's just visiting, like maybe from like out of town and they stay with me for about a month or so, would that count? Because their usual residence would be out of, would be somewhere else" (P2133, smartphone).

Household Roster Edit Screen

During testing, a programming error was found (and has since been fixed) where the age of participants was not being calculated from today's date and the person's birthdate; Eight participants noticed they needed to edit the age of household members who had had a birthday since Round 1 (P1328, computer; P1511, smartphone; P1283, computer; P1297, smartphone; P1440, smartphone; P1450, computer; P1716, smartphone; P2019, computer). However, once on this edit screen, these participants did not have any issues making this edit (**Figure 3.12**).

"It was easy. And I understood that it hadn't been updated because I haven't been back in the survey to update that information. So it was easy and I was glad I was able to make that correction" (P1328, computer).

"So the editing I did see that, you know, our ages weren't up to date so I clicked 'Edit,' and to go and change the age was very simple. It was just an easy process" (P1297, smartphone).

After making this edit, participants did not have any issues getting back to the household roster confirmation screen. Three of these participants clicked on the "Return to review" button after editing (see **Figure 3.13**). The remaining five participants initially clicked on the "Next" button after editing, but once they realized they were being asked questions that they have already answered about the person, clicked the "Return to review" button. One of these participants commented that they did not expect this to happen and said, "Because I

clicked edit on just one question, it's a little confusing that now I'm being taken here, to review this question that I didn't want to edit necessarily" (P1568 smartphone).

Seven participants noted that the formatting of the edit screen was confusing (P1283, computer; P1383, computer; P1440, smartphone; P1450, computer; P1712, smartphone; P1716, smartphone; P1568 smartphone); see **Figure 3.12**.

"You know what - they're a little bit off. I mean you can tell the top one goes to the top but they're not lined up" (P1383, computer).

"Yeah so I did it for my birthday. You know, the only thing is the 'Edit' buttons don't necessarily line up like directly across from them, but I counted so for example, I felt like the 'edit' button for your sex should have been maybe like pushed up, and then little bit more, and so, where it says 'Age,' that 'Edit' button you would know directly next to it that, that that's the one you would do. I felt like I did just kind of have to count so I was like, 'one, two,' and there's the second one so it must be the second one down here, but it just didn't line up maybe as much as I wanted it to" (P1450, computer).

While editing their age from 48 to 49, one participant mentioned that the textbox did not clear when they clicked on it: "I just didn't know which button to hit...It didn't erase it or anything right away...I didn't know whether to type it in and it was 494. It didn't work properly right away," (P1440, smartphone).

"At first, I got a little confused, but that's because I didn't see the age 34 was next to the edit button and then the sex was next to the edit button, so all I had to do was pick the right edit button. I thought it was a little confusing at first when I was doing it, but in hindsight it was simple" (P1712, smartphone).

"Well it says 'question answer issue' at the top, that's clear. Then it says 'no issues found, no issues found, no, no issues found.' So there's some, some strange text in there. And then there was kind of a box that was saying there was some missing information, I think. So yeah, this screen definitely has problems" (P1716, smartphone).

One participant (P1568, smartphone) clicked on "Edit" to edit a household member's age and found that the birthdate was entered incorrectly in Round 1. This participant was on a smartphone and commented that they thought that the edit screen was "squished," and they did not know what "No issues found!" meant (see **Figure 3.14**). Additionally, after editing the household member's age and clicking next, they were confused why it took them to the next question rather than back to the edit or household roster screen: "Because I clicked edit on just one question, it's a little confusing that now I'm being taken here, to review this question that I didn't want to edit necessarily." They decided to click "Return to

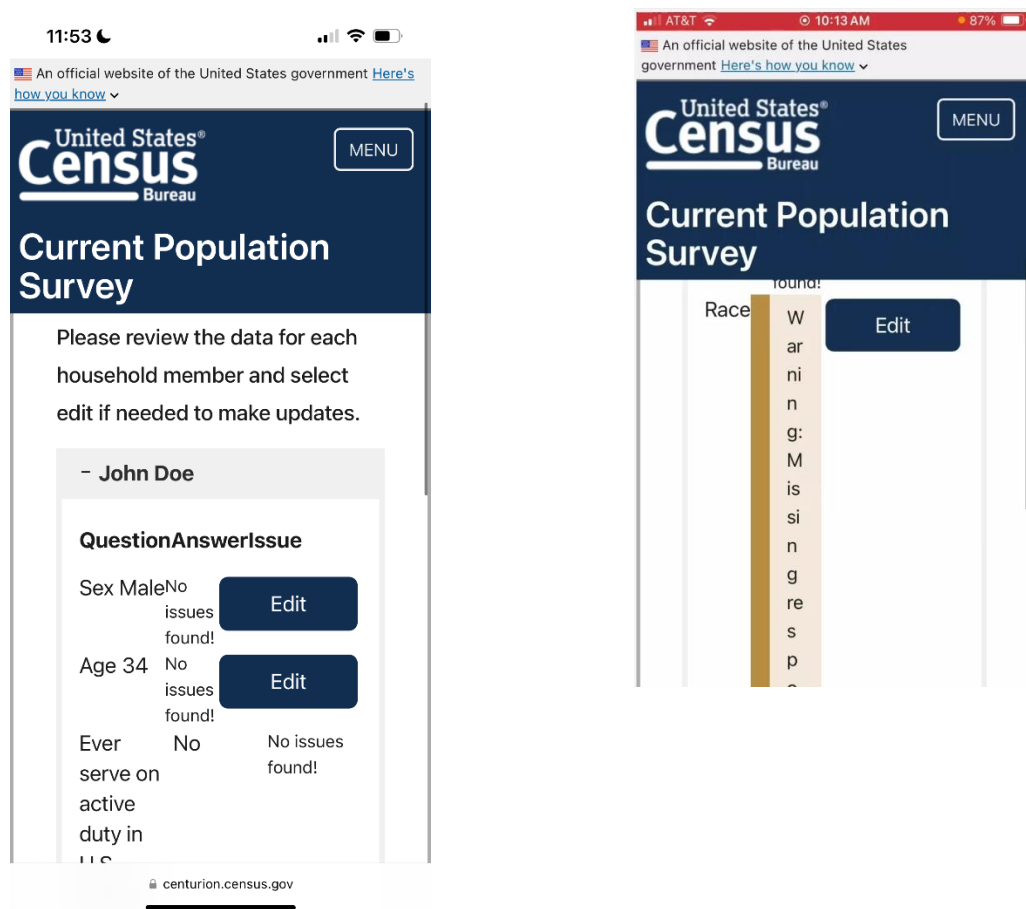
review” instead of “Next” so they could return to the edit screen and make sure everything else looked okay.

One participant was unable to edit their name that they had misspelled in Round 1. They wanted to do it but the system does not allow names to be edited across rounds (P1712, smartphone).

3.3.6 Round 2 Recommendations

Because participants did not have any major usability issues with the adding/removing process itself, no changes are recommended. However, the recommendations below could potentially reduce the usability issues that participants experienced with other aspects of the household roster section.

- Consider rewording the response options on the question that asks why a household member is being removed to better differentiate between “Person moved out,” “Person left – usual residence elsewhere last month,” and “Person has a usual residence elsewhere this month.” Due to sensitivity, consider moving the option where the household member died as the last option.
- Consider realigning the edit buttons to match the categories on the same line and removing or reducing the size of the “No Issues Found” column, as this may crowd the screen (see **Figure 3.14**, left). For one participant (P1716) who had a warning message in the issues column, the warning message was nearly unreadable and made the edit screen very difficult to navigate (see **Figure 3.14**, right). Although few smartphone participants accessed the “Edit” screen, consider reformatting this so that it is easier to read on mobile devices.

Figure 3.14. Round 2 Household Member Edit Screen on Smartphone

- Consider including the ability to edit a name to allow respondents to correct potential typos or misspellings.

3.4 Demographics

During Round 1, participants were asked to enter the date of birth and confirm the age of each household member (**Figure 3.15**).

Figure 3.15. Round 1 Household Member Date of Birth and Age

What is Rachel Stenger's date of birth?

Please fill Rachel Stenger's birth Month, Day and Year. [Help](#)

Month Day Year

-Select- -Select- -Select-

Verify or enter correct age as of August 24, 2024. For babies less than 1 year old, do not enter the age in months. Enter 0 as the age.

Age

years

Participants were also asked several other demographic questions about each household member; however, findings from Round 1 will focus on the date of birth, as the interviewer observations and the probes focused on this.

3.4.1 Round 1 Findings

Many participants commented that they liked the format of entering month, day, and year as separate dropdowns, especially preferring this method over a calendar method (P1324, computer; P1429, computer; P1328, computer; P1563, computer; P1666, computer; P1760, computer; P1294, smartphone; P1511, smartphone; P1578, smartphone; P1616, smartphone; P1725, smartphone; P1754, smartphone; P1303, computer; P1434, computer; P1450, computer; P1658, computer; P2034, computer; P1960, smartphone; P1330, smartphone; P1440, smartphone; P1726, smartphone; P2055, smartphone); see

Figure 3.15.

"I liked it. This is the preferred way I would like to do it. It's easy to just select 'month', 'day', and 'year' versus other methods where there's like a whole calendar and the calendar opens on today's date and you have to scroll back and find your birthday. I think this probably the best format to do it and I did like where it shows the age in years at the bottom just to confirm that you are that age" (P1563, computer).

"I like either this or just the blanks, the 2, 2, and 4 [referring to 2-digit month, 2-digit day, and 4-digit year] but I don't like seeing a calendar with crazy, like today's date and make it work for 69 years ago. I hate that. But either one of those works fine [either the dropdowns or the separate boxes to enter digits, not the calendar]" (P1725, smartphone).

"This is by far one of the easier ways, when they bring up the calendar and they make you go back, I hate that. It takes forever and it's not helpful because

sometimes you get it wrong and you have to go start all over, so this is a lot more simple, just bringing down the day, the month, and the year" (P1754, smartphone).

"I think this is probably the most accurate. I think you have to give people narrow choices otherwise they might spell a month wrong or pick like February 30th or something. I think it makes sense to make them choose something off the list" (P1960, smartphone).

"I prefer to do this than like a calendar where you have to go back 41 years" (P1451, computer).

However, other participants noted that although the dropdowns were easy to use, being able to type into the dropdowns would have been faster (P1283, computer; P1327, computer; P1383, computer; P1361, computer; P1393, computer; P1451, computer; P1486, computer; P1658, computer; P2019, computer; P1398, smartphone; P1712, smartphone).

"So I guess it could be a little bit annoying just because you have to go through the extra process of scrolling to find the month and the year. Nothing super crazy but it would be nice if it had the same option as [the nativity country question] where you could type and then click on it faster [from a dropdown]" (P1486, computer).

"I thought it was easy just because there was a dropdown. But to make it easier, maybe they could have given a dropdown where they allow you to type as well" (P1398, smartphone).

Seven participants were unsure of some household members' complete birthdays and were unsure what to do next (P1367, smartphone; P1754, smartphone; P1875, computer; P1885, smartphone; P1383, computer; P1393, computer; P1540, computer). Some participants asked the person if they were present (i.e., in another room, in the household at the time) and some participants made their best guess. Only one of these participants clicked on the "Help" link but could not figure out what to do; this participant entered an age for each person but not date of birth.

One participant did not want to give the full date of birth for each member of her household and preferred to only state their ages (P1800, computer). This participant explained, "For US Census Bureau, yeah, I'm like why do you need my date of birth? Can I just give my age? I don't mind giving ages, but I do mind giving date of birth, cause it's a little too close. Cause you're gonna have my first name and my last name and my date of birth, already you can go pretty far. Not you, it's not like I don't trust the Census Bureau, I don't trust Census Bureau security. And I would be wondering why the Census Bureau needs my date of birth, why isn't my age good enough?" This participant did not click on the "Help" link, and it was not clear to them that only entering an age for each person was an option. During probing, this participant said, "I didn't click on the Help, so I don't know what [it

says]. I probably should have clicked on the Help, maybe it would have told me it's optional."

3.4.2 Round 1 Recommendations

Many participants said that they liked the method of entering month, day, and year into separate dropdowns; therefore, we do not recommend changing the format of entering date of birth. However, BLS and the Census Bureau could consider using dropdown menus that allow text input to make this process easier for some participants.

However, because some participants did not know the date of birth for some household members and one participant did not want to enter the date of birth for any household members because of the sensitivity, we do have several recommendations to improve the Help functionality on this page (described below). The text included in the "Help" pop-up used during Round 1 testing is shown in **Figure 3.16**.

- Instead of the link text "Help," consider changing this to "Don't know this person's date of birth? Click here."
- Consider making the Help text more succinct. Because participants do not receive an error message if they leave only date of birth blank, consider removing this text from the Help screen. For example, this Help text could include the following:

This question consists of two parts: the person's date of birth and the person's age.

I do not know the person's date of birth:

- If you know only part of the date of birth (month, day, and/or year), enter as much as you know. Then confirm or enter the person's age.
 - If you don't know any of the date of birth, leave the date of birth blank. Then enter the person's age.
 - It is okay to estimate the person's age, but please do not estimate the month, day, or year.
- Consider making the "How is date of birth data used?" section of the Help text a separate pop-up. Instead of "Help," the text for the link could read "How is date of birth data used?" This could be placed after "What is [NAME]'s date of birth?" at the bottom of the screen, or next to the date of birth entries.

Figure 3.16. Round 1 Household Member Date of Birth and Age Help Text

The figure shows two side-by-side help text boxes. The left box is titled 'Help' and contains instructions for the 'Date of Birth' question. It explains that the question has two parts: the date of birth and the age of the person. It provides three sections of guidance: 'I know this information:', 'I know only part of this information:', and 'I do not know any of this information:'. The right box is titled 'Age' and provides instructions for the 'Age' question. It includes a list of bullet points for how to enter the age and a section titled 'How is date of birth data used?' which explains the importance of age-related statistics for funding and planning decisions. Both boxes have a 'Close' button at the bottom right.

Help

This question consists of two parts: the first part asks for the date of birth, and the second part asks about the age of the person.

Date of Birth

I know this information:

- If you know the date of birth, enter it by selecting the month, day, and year of birth. The person's age as of will be automatically calculated for you to confirm or correct.

I know only part of this information:

- If you know only part of the date of birth (month, day, and/or year), enter as much as you know, then confirm or enter the person's age as of . It is okay to estimate the person's age, but please do not estimate the month, day, or year.
- If you leave any part of the date of birth blank, you may receive an error message. Follow the instruction above, then select 'next' again to continue to the next screen.

I do not know any of this information:

- If you do not know the date of birth at all, leave month, day, and year blank, then if possible, enter the person's age as of . It is okay to estimate the person's age, but please do not estimate the month, day, or year of birth.
- If you leave the date of birth blank, you will receive an error message. Follow the instruction above, then select 'next' again to continue to the next screen.

Age

- If age has been calculated from date of birth, please verify the age as presented in the text box. Otherwise, enter the person's age as of .
- Do not round up the age if the person was or will be close to having a birthday on .
- If you do not know the exact age, please estimate.
- For babies who were or will be not yet one year old on , enter "0" as the age.

How is date of birth data used?

Many funding and planning decisions are based on age-related statistics and trends. For example, the federal government uses them to decide how to allocate education funds and to project the health care needs of the older population and veterans. State and local governments use them to determine age-related needs, such as a need to increase school system resources due to a growing population of school-aged children.

By law, the Census Bureau can only use your responses to produce statistics. The Census Bureau is required by law to protect your information (Title 13, U.S. Code, Section 9). The Census Bureau is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you or your household. Your answers cannot be used against you by any government agency or court.

Close

- Consider making the error message clearer if participants leave both date of birth and age blank because many participants did not click on the "Help" link. The error message programmed during Round 1 testing is shown in **Figure 3.17**.
 - Recommendation of wording: "You have not entered a date of birth or an age. If you do not know the date of birth, please enter the person's age below and leave the date of birth blank."

Figure 3.17. Round 1 Error Message if Both Date of Birth and Age are Left Blank

Please answer this important question.

What is Rachel Stenger's date of birth?

Please fill Rachel Stenger's birth Month, Day and Year. [Help](#)

Month Day Year

-Select- -Select- -Select-

Verify or enter correct age as of August 24, 2024. *For babies less than 1 year old, do not enter the age in months. Enter 0 as the age.*

Age

 years

3.4.3 Round 2 Findings

Demographics are only asked in an MIS-2 interview about another person added to the household roster or if the participant selected to edit any information about an existing household member. The CPS asks respondents to update or confirm educational attainment information for each household member during interviews in February, July, and October or if the case is a MIS-5 interview. This item presents a prefilled response based on what they reported previously. While some participants edited other demographic information, this section focuses primarily on the dependent interviewing for the educational attainment question.

During Round 2, participants were asked to confirm or update the highest level of education completed for each household member; this screen was prefilled with the response that they provided in Round 1 (**Figure 3.18**). Participants who completed an interview in November did not receive the educational attainment question by design. Interviewers showed them a screenshot of an example question and asked the probes.

Figure 3.18. Round 2 Household Member Education Confirmation

Occasionally, we re-ask certain questions in case anything has changed. Please confirm or update the following schooling or certificate information for RICK MARTINEZ.

What is the highest level of school RICK MARTINEZ has completed or the highest degree RICK MARTINEZ has received?

- ☐ Less than 1st grade
- ☐ 1st, 2nd, 3rd or 4th grade
- ☐ 5th or 6th grade
- ☐ 7th or 8th grade
- ☐ 9th grade
- ☐ 10th grade
- ☐ 11th grade
- ☐ 12th grade NO DIPLOMA
- ☒ HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATE- high school DIPLOMA or the equivalent (For example: GED)
- ☐ Some college but no degree
- ☐ Associate degree in college - Occupational/vocational program
- ☐ Associate degree in college -- Academic program
- ☐ Bachelor's degree (For example: BA, AB, BS)
- ☐ Master's degree (For example: MA, MS, MEng, MEd, MSW, MBA)
- ☐ Professional School Degree (For example: MD, DDS, DVM, LLB, JD)
- ☐ Doctorate degree (For example: PhD, EdD)

Most participants did not have any issues on this screen, whether they received this screen during the CPS instrument (i.e., were interviewed in October) or were shown this question in probing (i.e., were interviewed in November).

"I think that was good to ask that again because, again, that could change, you know. In a lot of households, you know, some people just discuss, you know, things change. They may try to go to school or like might have graduated or something like that, so it's good to have that option." (P1297, smartphone).

Nine participants noted that they appreciated having the education question prefilled (P1283, computer; P1297, smartphone; P1327, computer; P1364, computer; P1383, computer; P1450, computer; P1498, smartphone; P1591, smartphone; P2034, computer).

"I didn't have a problem with them asking questions, especially since they were logged in, my previous information was already inputted. And I didn't have to re-

input everything. So, all I was doing was confirming that everything was the same, and all I had to do was just click next" (P1364, computer).

"Well it's good that its prefilled because it will likely decrease the chance of me making an error with the slip of the mouse and changing it" (P1383, computer).

One participant (P1328, computer) changed their answer to this question, but then re-read the instructions and changed the response back to the original answer. During probing, they said that they did not realize at first that the question was prefilled with their answer from last time. However, it was unclear why they initially wanted to change their answer.

Similarly, another participant did not realize the question was prefilled: "Ok so I guess, you know what, because I did it really fast, I think I didn't realize that the, the button was already selected at the bottom. Like I was ready to check off eleventh grade because she didn't finish [inaudible] grade. ... I think it confused me a little bit looking at it now, so" (P1303, computer).

One participant noted that education would likely not change on a monthly basis: "It seems fine. Just verifying like if I had graduated or gotten any other type of certificates maybe or any other degrees or anything of that nature, I presume. But just, but on a monthly basis, if I was doing this every month, I'm sure that it would normally be the same unless I was getting a continuing education" (P2133, smartphone). However, the education confirmation question will not be asked every month during CPS production.

A few participants mentioned during probing that they thought the number of response options was excessive (P1283, computer; P2129, smartphone; P1563, computer).

"I think they're fine but I think it's really interesting that they have so many choices, like does it matter whether he finished ninth grade or tenth grade?" (P1283, computer).

"It was kind of long, extended. I don't think you necessarily need to ... I think it would be best to maybe just put 'grade school' because most people have graduated high school but I just think this is a little bit extended to go grade by grade. I think you do like maybe primary school, secondary school, high school, something like that but not just write down all of those" (P2129, smartphone).

"Other than the really long wording of the question itself, no, not really. If the grades are split up that way because you really want to capture the granularity of that, then that's fine. I would just say what I'm used to seeing is probably like more of a range. Right now the response options are very specific, but then you suddenly have a range of 1st grade, 2nd, 3rd, or 4th, so that captures a range. Then you have a smaller range of 5th or 6th and then it starts getting more specific.... As you get further down you'd probably want to be more specific like high school degree, high school graduate, 12th grade with no diploma. But then for the earlier ones the

ranges seem a little odd. But that could just be as part of this survey, just chosen arbitrarily” (P1563, computer).

Lastly, two participants had minor comments on the question wording. One participant thought the instructions could be shortened: “I just think it could maybe just say 'please confirm the information' because I, I get it that they say occasionally they re-ask certain questions but I think it could just say 'just confirm' you know, just reconfirm the information that was previously given” (P2129, smartphone). One participant thought the word “re-ask” was grammatically incorrect (P1716, smartphone).

3.4.4 Round 2 Recommendations

Because participants did not have any major usability or cognitive issues that prevented them from answering this question, no changes are recommended. Although some participants noted that they were expecting the response options to be more collapsed, these participants did not have any issues with being able to answer the question. The list of response options for this education question could be reduced, if desired.

3.5 Usual and Actual Hours (both single and multiple jobs)

3.5.1 Round 1 Findings

In Round 1, participants were asked about the number of hours they usually work (**Figure 3.19**) followed by the exact number of hours worked in the previous week. The latter consisted of three questions: one asking about any hours taken off (**Figure 3.20**), any extra hours worked (**Figure 3.21**), and the total number of hours actually worked (**Figure 3.22**). For those reporting for their own or a household member’s multiple jobs, the usual hours (and later, the actual hours) worked were asked for the main job and for the other job on the same screen. All participants were asked about hours lost or extra hours worked for the main job, followed by the total actual hours worked.

Figure 3.19. Round 1 Usual Hours Questions

How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your main job? By main job we mean the one at which you usually work the most hours.	
	Hours per week
How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your other job?	
	Hours per week

Figure 3.20. Round 1 Actual Hours Questions: Lose or Take Off Hours

Next are some questions about the exact number of hours you worked LAST WEEK.

LAST WEEK, did you lose or take off any hours from your **MAIN** job, for **ANY** reason such as illness, lack of work, vacation, or holiday?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Figure 3.21. Round 1 Actual Hours Questions: Overtime Hours

LAST WEEK, did you work any overtime or extra hours at your **MAIN** job that you do not usually work?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Figure 3.22. Round 1 Actual Hours Questions: Actual Hours Last Week

So, for LAST WEEK, how many hours did you ACTUALLY work at your MAIN job?

	Hours
--	-------

LAST WEEK, how many hours did you ACTUALLY work at your other job?

	Hours
--	-------

Sixty-two participants (30 smartphone, 32 computer) answered these questions, either about themselves or about others in the household. There were no noticeable differences between the smartphone and computer participants.

As had been the case in cognitive testing, some participants objected about being asked both usual and actual hours because they work the same number of hours every week and are not allowed to work more hours. Others thought the question may need to be answered with the number of hours they get paid for, regardless of how many hours they actually work.

"I think the only part that I kind of questioned was like working overtime, I didn't know if that meant extra hours meaning like you're getting paid for those extra

hours because, I mean, I work overtime and I don't get paid for it so I didn't know if it meant like you getting paid for those extra hours or you're just working any type of extra hours" (P1450, computer).

Finally, others felt the usual and actual hours questions were asking the same:

"I bet it's probably around 30. I think you already asked me that question. ... I think this is a redundant question, so I'll put in the same information twice" (P1716, smartphone).

"When I saw that again, these types of questions about working last week, it's like I felt like I was just repeating the same questions but in different forms kind of like just asking it in a different way. ... Just one of the questions about how many hours did I actually work at your job, so that was already asked but in a different way" (P1297, smartphone).

Five participants found the term "usual hours" confusing because their work hours vary depending on the season, as the following illustrates:

"If we had a full-time job or part-time job... my mother and sister have a full-time job, but are they working? No... because the school system is currently on break" (P1364, computer).

"Ok by the way, I'm a teacher right now so I'm not actually working but I'm going to pretend I'm teaching right now and I'm going to say '40'" (P1450, computer).

Sixteen participants who reported multiple jobs for themselves or a household member were probed on their preference about seeing the usual hours questions (and later about the actual hours questions) for the main and other job on the same page or across different pages. All but one of the 16 participants preferred reporting them on the same page.

"Yeah, that's simple. That's logical because if you're asking about the jobs and you have multiple, you could put them on one screen and just, like I did, was place the hours and move on" (P2169, computer).

"This was actually convenient. This is where I came across 'by main job...' I think that was clear and some people might need that definition. [I liked] the capitalization of 'usually' and 'main' job. It was pretty simple" (P1614, smartphone).

"It makes sense, especially if you have more than one job" (P1498, smartphone).

One person thought it would be best to split the questions across different screens:

"Yeah, I think it probably makes sense to split them up because they both have 'usually' in all bold letters, it makes it look the same. So, it seems like it's asking,

'how many do you do?' and then 'how many do you usually do?' even though it's asking the two separate jobs" (P1876, smartphone).

A single-job participant indicated they would have preferred reporting their *usual* and *actual* hours on the same screen:

"That's actually the best way to do it because I would hate to continue going with the same series of questions, like a series of different pages..." (P2055, smartphone).

Survey designers had wondered if the labels for "hours" or "hours per week" were understood to be labels rather than clickable buttons. None of the participants tried to click on a label, and all understood what the labels were for.

3.5.2 Round 1 Recommendations

Based on findings from Round 1, we recommended providing instructions to respondents for the usual hours worked question to make it easier for them to respond if their hours were not always consistent. We recommended using the instructions that were tested in the second round of CPS cognitive testing as follows:

Figure 3.23. Usual Hours Question Recommendation (as used in Cognitive Testing Round 2)

HRUSL1_1: **How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your <MAIN> job? <By main job we mean the one at which you USUALLY work the most hours.>**

- Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked
- If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week
- If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess

[numeric entry]

3.5.3 Round 2 Findings

In Round 2, to assess participants' actual hours worked last week, they were again asked to provide their usual working hours along with the number of hours taken off and any overtime worked during that period, as well as the total actual hours worked. However, as recommended after Round 1, the usual hours question was tested with instructions included, as had been used in the second round of cognitive testing. The actual hours question included text about how many hours the respondent reported being away from work or reported working extra time.

The full sequence of questions appears below, as follows (**Figures 3.24 to 3.27**):

Figure 3.24. Round 2 Usual Hours Questions

How many hours per week does Jane Doe USUALLY work at her main job? By main job we mean the one at which she usually works the most hours.

- Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked
- Consider the LAST 4 MONTHS
- If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week
- If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess

	Hours per week
--	----------------

How many hours per week does she USUALLY work at her other job?

- Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked
- Consider the LAST 4 MONTHS
- If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week
- If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess

	Hours per week
--	----------------

Figure 3.25. Round 2 Actual Hours Questions: Lose or Take Off Hours

Next are some questions about the exact number of hours you worked LAST WEEK.

LAST WEEK, did you lose or take off any hours from work, for ANY reason such as illness, lack of work, vacation, or holiday?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Figure 3.26. Round 2 Actual Hours Questions: Overtime Hours

LAST WEEK, did you work any overtime or extra hours that you do not usually work?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Figure 3.27. Round 2 Actual Hours Questions: Actual Hours Last Week

So, for LAST WEEK, how many hours did she ACTUALLY work at her MAIN job?

You reported she lost or took off 1 hours.
You reported she worked 2 extra hours.

	Hours
--	-------

LAST WEEK, how many hours did she ACTUALLY work at her other job?

	Hours
--	-------

In Round 2, 30 participants answered the hours worked question sequence.

As had been the case in Round 1, some participants appeared unhappy or impatient about having to report both usual and actual hours, and a few mentioned that these questions seemed repetitive to them (P1716, smartphone; P1395, smartphone; P1733, smartphone) or that level of detail did not seem necessary to collect:

"If I have to go and actually collect real hours, it would take a while...I mean if you truly need both then, then ask it twice. But I can imagine a lot of people would just put the same number of hours in because they don't want to go and check, right?" (P1716, smartphone).

"It just asked me this question: last week, how many hours did you actually work?" When probed if the question felt repetitive, the participant answered "very" (P1395, smartphone).

Proxy reporting was difficult for some participants. One participant (P1754 smartphone) said that they were guessing or estimating the usual and actual hours worked for several household members, noting that there is not a way to indicate "Don't know" or "Not sure." Another one said, "With my son I would have to ask him so that would be a little frustrating ...it's going to take me time to go and check and ask my son." (P1716 smartphone). Because of this, the participant said they would likely end up reporting the usual hours as actual hours.

Despite restating the reported hours taken off and overtime, a few participants still reported inconsistent actual hours. Some seemed to interpret usual hours as contractual versus actual hours reflecting the true amount of work one did. For instance, two participants that did not report any hours off or overtime the previous week, said the following:

"When it was saying how many hours did I work and then it asked how many hours did you actually work so I'm assuming that took out like my one hour lunch break that I have so since I'm like scheduled for 40 hours I work 35 because I have an hour break everyday which would be 35" (P1470, computer).

"So I'm salary, so I just, I work a lot, actually more than 40 hours, but I kind of went by like what my contract is." ... "Yeah, so 52 hours last week, yes. Because I had, like, conferences with parents. So yeah, so it was outside my work schedule. Yeah went by my contract, yeah, and then when it said, 'how many hours did you actually work last week?' I took in consideration because we, we worked like a 13-hour day one day but it's like outside our contract time and not like our school day, if that makes sense. So, I just added it in, the time that I spent actually at work." ... "You know, I put in my regular hours as 40 and then, the 12 hours I put in for how long I stayed after school. It was two days so, six and six..." (P1450, computer).

This person reported they usually work 40 hours and reported 52 actual hours worked last week.

Another participant reported 30 usual hours and no time off or overtime but only 20 actual hours. As we saw in the cognitive testing study, this participant was thinking about effective use of the work hours, "Oh, because I just thought about how I actually did something versus just sitting and waiting" (P1498, smartphone, single job).

In probing, we collected participants' reactions to the instructions added to the usual hours question: to estimate the usual and not actual hours, to consider the previous 4 months, to report on a typical week if hours varied, and to give best guess if not known. Although some participants had no issue with this set of instructions, others yielded mixed results.

"I don't remember it saying, 'consider the last four months.' Is that different? That, that, that's, that comes out to me as being different, I don't remember, I don't remember that wording from before... Yeah, the last four months, that didn't, that doesn't stick out to me. So, I just kind of went off of what is currently going on, like I'm currently working 'X' number of hours at this job and 'X' number of hours at that job. That's kind of how I framed that question in my head..." (P1303 computer)

"I thought it was easy because it asks how many hours per week did I work usually at my main job and also [my] fiancée at his [her] main job, so I knew like the last four months at my main job I worked 30 hours a week, so I put 30 there. And... so I put 15 hours because that's the average I worked in the last four months" (P1327, computer).

"I guess because I work part time, so it varies so just guessed. I would have to look at a timecard actually if I didn't" (P1658, computer).

"It sounded like this section is supposed to just think about last week, but maybe that just applied to the first question of the business or farm. Because now it's kind of asking me to think about usual hours for the last 4 months. So I think it's fine, it's just like okay, why did it tell me to think about the last week?" (P1568, smartphone).

After responding, as they went to the actual hours section, they noticed that now it switched back to "last week."

One participant seemed to ignore the instruction about the last 4 months and only considered the previous week.

"Yes, so, for the first question, I was just thinking how many hours did she work at her main job, you know, the job that she does every week. So, that was clear. And I estimated she worked approximately 40 hours, and then the next one was how much does she usually work at her other job, and I think this question was referring to the previous week, so I said 40, I mean 20, for her other job" (P1364, computer)

One participant commented on the capitalized words in the instructions and suggested extending that formatting to other key points in the description:

"I like that it has capital, you know, 'usual months'; 'typical week', maybe that should be capital there. And then maybe 'best guess' is capital as well in the last one. But it would, because of the capital, I could read it thorough with just kind of scan" (P1716, smartphone).

In terms of the consistency of input methods for participants, one person (P1568, smartphone) noticed that in the actual hours' question, the number keyboard came up instead of the full keyboard when they clicked in the textbox, and they liked that feature. However, they noticed that the usual hours question came up with the full keyboard.

3.5.4 Round 2 Recommendations

For consistency of response input method, consider making sure that all numeric entry text boxes use the numeric keyboard, rather than the full keyboard, on smartphones.

Although the instructions added to the usual hours' question appeared to work well, the instruction to 'consider the past 4 months' was confusing to some participants. This finding was also seen after Round 1 of cognitive testing and this instruction was removed from the question for cognitive testing in Round 2, where it tested well. We recommend to continue using this version (i.e., the version used in Round 2 cognitive testing) of the question (**Figure 3.28**). Any further changes to this question wording or to the wording of the instructions should be cognitively tested.

Figure 3.28. Usual Hours Question Recommendation

- Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked
- If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week
- If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess

3.6 Questions for Those Who Are Self-Employed

Testing for self-employed participants involved two successive questions, both asking about the number of paid employees. The first question asked whether the participant has any paid employees (**Figure 3.29**) and the second specifies how many paid employees the business has, excluding the owners (**Figure 3.30**). This testing was limited to Round 1; the Round 2 protocol did not specifically test questions for self-employed participants.

Figure 3.29. Round 1 Self-Employed Questions: Paid Employees

Do you usually have any paid employees?

☐ Yes

☐ No

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Figure 3.30. Round 1 Self-Employed Questions: Number of Paid Employees

Excluding all owners, how many paid employees does your business usually have?

Paid employees

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3.6.1 Round 1 Findings

Seventeen participants (7 smartphone, 10 computer) answered the self-employed questions in Round 1. There were no significant differences seen between the smartphone and computer participants.

The first question (**Figure 3.29**) was generally well-understood. As one participant explained their response, “I was just thinking of all the people that my parents provide salaries for, and I know the number is around 15-12 so that’s pretty much what I put.” (P1486 computer). Another participant noted, “Yeah ‘paid employee’ is really simple, you know, straight question. How much you, how, how [sic] many people you pay for them, like, for working for you. That’s my understanding” (P2029, computer). As one participant simply stated, “I don’t have any employees. I think it’s a simple question” (P1973, smartphone).

3.6.2 Round 1 Recommendations

Because there were no cognitive or usability issues, there were no recommendations at this time.

3.7 Industry and Occupation

In Round 1, participants provided information about their company, industry, and occupation through text-entry questions (shown in **Figures 3.31 to 3.34**). During Round 2, these entries were prefilled in follow-up questions that prompted participants to confirm or update their industry and occupation details. Testing of dependent data during Round 2 was prioritized; therefore, findings and recommendations are focused on Round 2.

Figure 3.31. Round 1 Industry and Occupation: Company Name

What is the name of the company for which you work ?

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Figure 3.32. Round 1 Industry and Occupation: Business or Industry

What kind of business or industry is this?

Include the main activity, product or service provided where employed.

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Figure 3.33. Round 1 Industry and Occupation: Occupation

What kind of work do you do, that is, what is your occupation?

For example: 4th grade teacher, plumber.

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Figure 3.34. Round 1 Industry and Occupation: Usual Activities or Duties

Describe your usual activities or duties at this job?

For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe section and review building plans for work details.

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Participants saw the following questions in Round 2 with dependent data from Round 1 (Figures 3.35 to 3.37).

Figure 3.35. Round 2 Industry and Occupation: Company Name Confirmation (IO1DP1)

Last month, it was reported that Mario Martinez worked for Acme Inc.. Does he still work for Acme Inc. ?

☐ Yes

☒ No

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Figure 3.36. Round 2 Industry and Occupation: Usual Activities and Duties Confirmation (IO1DP2)

Have the usual activities and duties of his job changed since last month?

☐ Yes

☐ No

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Figure 3.37. Round 2 Industry and Occupation: Occupation and Activities Confirmation (IO1DP3)

Last month Mario Martinez was reported as (a/an) manager and his usual activities were working sales register . Is this an accurate description of his current job?

☐ Yes

☐ No

If participants answered “No” to any of the previous questions (**Figures 3.35 to 3.37**), they were routed to questions that gave them the opportunity to update the name of their organization, the industry, their occupation, and their usual work activities questions. The industry, occupation, and their usual work activities questions contained a preamble with prefilled information the participant provided in Round 1 (see **Figures 3.38 to 3.40** below).

Participants who were not working during Round 1 and had since become employed during Round 2 bypassed questions IO1DP1, IO1DP2, and IO1DP3 (**Figures 3.35 to 3.37**). They did not have any industry and occupation data to report in Round 1, therefore they had nothing to confirm in questions IO1DP1, IO1DP2, and IO1DP3 (**Figures 3.35 to 3.37**). Instead, these participants saw questions IO1IND, IO1OCC, and IO1DT1 (**Figures 3.38 to 3.40**) with the bold question text with empty textboxes because they were entering the information for the first time

A known programming error in Round 2 also led participants who reported working less than 35 hours (i.e., part-time workers) to see the series of questions below with the preamble text. Some of those participants were full time workers during Round 1 but had since reduced their hours to part time; therefore, the textboxes were prefilled with their Round 1 responses. These participants should have seen the series above (**Figures 3.35 to 3.37**) before potentially being routed to the text input series (**Figures 3.38 to 3.40**).

Figure 3.38. Round 2 Industry and Occupation: Business or Industry Confirmation (IO1IND)

What kind of business or industry is this?

Include the main activity, product or service provided where employed.

Big Box Store

Figure 3.39. Round 2 Industry and Occupation: Occupation Confirmation (IO1OCC)

Previously it was reported that Mario Martinez was doing the kind of work shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct.

What kind of work does Mario Martinez do, that is, what is his occupation?

For example: 4th grade teacher, plumber.

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Figure 3.40. Round 2 Industry and Occupation: Usual Activities or Duties Confirmation (IO1DT1)

Previously it was reported Mario Martinez did the following usual activities or duties at their job as shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct.

Describe his usual activities or duties at this job.

For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe section and review building plans for work details.

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3.7.1 Round 2 Findings

All participants who saw questions IO1DP1, IO1DP2, and IO1DP3 (**Figures 3.35 to 3.37**) understood that the textboxes were prefilled with their responses from Round 1 and generally did not struggle to confirm or update the information as needed. Seven participants (2 computer, 5 smartphone) specifically stated that they appreciated the use of the dependent data because it made the response process more efficient (P2034, computer; P1658, computer; P2133, smartphone; P2055, smartphone; P1591, smartphone; P1754, smartphone; P2158, smartphone). As one participant described:

"I liked that [the prefilled response], especially if this is, if I'm going to have to look at this survey multiple times. I would rather not have to be asked to re-enter things that I've already stated, so for me it was nice to see it, verify it, or certainly if something had changed, to give you the opportunity to do that. But I appreciated for ease of use, it was already there, like next, next, to move quicker, more efficiently" (P2158, smartphone).

Another participant noted, "That [the prefilled response] was nice, that was definitely convenient" (P1754, smartphone). Although participants noticed that the questions were prefilled with Round 1 responses, it is unclear whether they thoroughly re-read their responses before confirming whether changes had occurred. Some participants moved through the questions quickly and commented that nothing had changed. One participant noted, "I probably didn't [update it]. It started looking redundant. I probably should've taken more time" (P1361, computer). When asked whether they read the instructions and descriptions of each confirmation question, another participant said:

"I, I fill out so many things online like for everything else in my life, like my own personal administrative things that I just kind of like, I tend to breeze through a lot of it and I only kind of like keep a look out if like something is different and I know it's going to ask me if something is different" (P1303, computer).

Similarly, at least three smartphone participants (P1398, smartphone; P1591, smartphone; P2129, smartphone) did not view the entirety of the prefilled text in the textbox because of the lack of text wrapping. In other words, longer responses did not render in paragraph format on their screen. Instead, these participants only saw the first few words of the prefilled text and did not click into the textbox to view the complete description before confirming that no changes had been made. There were no reports of this happening in the computer cases and there were otherwise no major differences between the experience of answering the questions on either device.

Some participants needed to update information, and they were able to do so without major issues. For example, two participants (P1283, computer; P1754, smartphone) had household members who remained in the restaurant industry but were working at different businesses. One participant (P1283, computer) answered "No" to IO1DP1 (**Figure 3.35**), kept the prefilled "Restaurant" input in IO1IND (**Figure 3.38**), and then updated the prefilled information in IO1OCC and IO1DT1 (**Figure 3.39** and **Figure 3.40**, respectively) because the household member's position and duties had changed. The other participant (P1754, smartphone) also answered "No" to IO1DP1 (**Figure 3.35**) but kept the prefilled response information for questions IO1IND, IO1OCC, and IO1DT1 (**Figures 3.38 to 3.40**) because the household member still worked in the same position and had the same duties, just at a different restaurant.

A few participants made substantial changes to their prefilled data, like one participant (P1364, computer) who worked at the same company but updated their position (IO1OCC, **Figure 3.39**) from "tester" to "consultant" and their duties (IO1DT1, **Figure 3.40**) from "test new technology" to "promote research study and recruit future participants." However, a couple participants made slight adjustments to the prefilled responses that may not have reflected significant change. For example, one participant (P1726, smartphone) updated their prefilled response to IO1IND (**Figure 3.38**) from "Cleaning" to "Cleaning Homes."

Another participant (P2034, computer) updated their response to IO1OCC (**Figure 3.39**) from "Pharmacy technician" to "Pharmacy intern."

Overall, participants generally felt that the sequence was easy to answer and was geared towards people who might have been promoted or changed jobs since the last interview (P1303, computer; P1327, computer; P1383, computer; P2034, computer; P1568, smartphone). One participant summarized their thinking of the sequence as, "I guess because one is so much more detailed. I interpreted the first one [IO1DP1, **Figure 3.35**] as generally if I'm still in the same industry, in the same company, probably I'm in the same role. But maybe it [the second one, IO1DP2, **Figure 3.36**] reminds that I got a promotion or I'm now a manager or something, so this gives me a chance to update the specifics" (P1568, smartphone).

There were a couple of participants, however, who found the questions confusing and redundant. One participant noted that they had not thought about the possibility of changing jobs based on how the questions were asked:

"I don't know, I'm curious like how many people have that, where their duties do change while they're at their job. I don't know, kind of seemed like a weird thing to ask." When the interviewer explained that people may have changed jobs entirely the participant said, "That, okay so that then that, like I wouldn't have gotten that from it. That it could be like you changed your job. I was just thinking of things that you do at work, or your [inaudible] roles changed" (P1450, computer).

Another participant noticed that question IO1DP2 ("Have the usual activities and duties changed since last month?"; **Figure 3.36**) did not account for someone forgetting what activities and duties they reported during the previous interview. They explained, "I don't think I saw the question on the top [IO1DP2, **Figure 3.36**]. If it was phrased like that, I probably would have forgotten what I listed, and I wouldn't be able to know, to say yes or no" (P2034, computer).

A few participants found the question sequence longwinded and thought it would be better to confirm whether any changes occurred rather than reviewing the prefilled detailed descriptions. Most of those who commented this were participants who reported working less than 35 hours (i.e., part-time workers) who saw prefilled responses to questions IO1IND, IO1OCC, and IO1DT1 (**Figures 3.38 to 3.40**) instead of the confirmation series (IO1DP1, IO1DP2, IO1DP3) (**Figures 3.35 to 3.37**). One participant noted:

"I think maybe even with this screen it could be more of a confirmation to where just to confirm the information and not then to edit it if there's been any change." The participant clarified, "Without asking, you know, each little bit of detail about their activities. I think you could just say, just confirm, has there been any changes since, you know, the last interview?" (P2129, smartphone).

Regarding IO1DP2 and IO1DP3 (**Figure 3.36** and **Figure 3.37**, respectively), another participant commented, “It made sense. I think that second sentence in the question might just be a bit wordy. I think it could just be phrased as ‘is this still accurate?’” (P1563, computer). This participant also mentioned that they would have preferred to confirm all three aspects (i.e., industry, occupation, and duties) on one screen to reduce redundancy.

3.7.2 Round 2 Recommendations

Though participants understood the industry and occupation sequence, some thought it was longwinded and redundant. To help with this, we recommend combining the three questions into one item (**Figure 3.41**). Instead of three separate confirmation questions (“did your position change?”; “did your activities change?”; and “these were your activities, is this accurate?”), participants could review the three aspects and confirm whether anything has changed in one step.

Figure 3.41. Round 2 Industry and Occupation Questions Recommendation

• Last month NAME was reported as (a/an): POSITION • [His/Her] usual activities were: ACTIVITIES Is this an accurate description of NAME’s current job? ☐ Yes ☐ No If the participants selects ‘No’: path to text input question (IO1IND, IO1OCC, IO1DT1)
--

For smartphone participants, we also recommend implementing textbox wrapping so they can review the entire entry without having to click into the textbox and scroll.

3.8 Questions for Those Who Are Not Working

Household members who were not working during the prior week received a series of questions depending on their situation, including questions about being absent from work (i.e., if they report not working during the prior week but have a job), being laid off, looking for work, and about details about when they last worked.

3.8.1 Round 1 Findings

There were no major usability issues found during Round 1 for any of the “not working” series of questions.

However, there were some cognitive issues related to the question that asked how long the household member had been looking for work (**Figure 3.42**).

Figure 3.42. Round 1 How Long Looking for Work

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?
Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years from the dropdown.

-Select- ▾

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A few participants were confused about the wording of this question, specifically because the question specified “As of the end of LAST WEEK.” For example, one participant (P1919, computer) said, “This was confusing because of the way it is worded and what they want. I am not sure why it is... so we have to think of the end of LAST week. Then you have to select weeks or months or years. So what I did is select weeks first and then typed 4. It just made more sense to me.” As this participant explained, they selected the unit of time first and then typed the number into the text box; several other participants also used this strategy to provide their answer to this question in Round 2 (see **Section 3.8.3**).

In addition, another participant (P1754, smartphone) entered in the number and did not select the unit of time from the dropdown. When they clicked next, they got the error message displayed below in **Figure 3.43**.

Figure 3.43. Round 1 How Long Looking for Work: Error Messages

Please enter a number in the box below.

Please select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?
Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years from the dropdown.

-Select- ▾

After this participant saw this message, they were easily able to understand that they needed to select “Weeks” from the dropdown. They were able to fix this error and continue with the survey. During probing, the participant said, “I didn’t even notice the dropdown select to say in months or years, I thought it just meant in the last week, in the last few weeks... I was a little unsure.” When the interviewer asked about the error message, the participant said, “I was glad it [the error message] came ‘cause I didn’t know I did anything

wrong.” This shows that the error message was helpful for this participant in being able to correct their error and enter the data needed to move on to the next question.

Further, there were five participants who owned businesses but did not work in the business in the prior week. Therefore, the survey took them down the path of being absent from work, which was very confusing to them. These participants’ experiences with the CPS survey are described below.

One participant (P1800, computer) and their spouse own a business, but neither of them were working in the business at the moment. Because the participant answered that they have a business but were not working last week, the survey took them down the path of being absent from work, which the participant found very confusing. Later in probing, the interviewer explained to the participant that the survey thought they were absent from work because they said they had a business but also said they were not working. The interviewer asked if there was anything we could do to make this more clear. “If I was presented with a question like, are you actively working in this business? Or anything pointing to, are you working in this business right now or is this just something you own? That would have been enough to then skip out of those questions. And then if you have multiple people owning the same business, then the answers would be the same for everything, except for the number of hours worked and stuff like that, but what is the name of the business, what type of business is it, all that could just be asked once.”

One participant (P1540, computer) who reported owning a business but did not work for pay during the prior week received the screen of reasons for being absent from work, which was confusing for them because they never indicated they were absent from work or working at all. They had indicated having a business but were very confused about this screen. The participant selected “Other” as a reason and wrote in “unemployed.” Next, they were asked what was the main reason they were working part time instead of full time, and they said, “I’m really not working... so.. I’m on unemployment right now.” The participant clicked “other” and wrote “unemployment.” Then they received the question, “Were you employed by the government, by a private company...” They said, “See, this is where it gets kind of tricky in my case, because I had a full-time job and I lost my job and I’m on unemployment. But I have my real estate license, but I’m not really selling real estate right now, but I am self-employed. If someone call me tomorrow, I wanna buy a house, I could do that, but I’m not actively selling houses right now... I guess self-employed but I’m on unemployment.” They answered self-employed even though the job they lost was a private company, and their self-employment had not been active for a while.

One participant (P1977, computer) had difficulty reporting the employment situation for their mother, as the mother receives monthly payments from the family business but does not do much active work in the business. The participant decided to report that the mother did not work for pay in the prior week because she did not receive her monthly payment

during that week. The participant also struggled to answer whether the mother currently has a job or not, as the mother is listed on taxes as an employee of the business but was not sure what the survey meant by “job.” The participant ultimately decided to answer “Yes.”

One participant (P2140, smartphone) explained during the interview that they own a business but was not working in the business during the prior week because they are in the process of retiring and also taking time to care for family. When they received questions about being absent from work, they were confused about why they were receiving this question, as they did not perceive themselves from being absent from work. The participant ultimately answered “caring for family” as the reason they were absent from work, as they explained that this was the main reason why they started the process of retiring and why they had not been working for the past several months.

Finally, one participant (P2158, smartphone) owns a business but is not actively working in the business and was confused about being taken down the “absent from work” path of questions, saying, “I’m saying that I don’t work, I didn’t have work. So it’s a little confusing to me to think how do I answer this, because I don’t currently have a job that I’m missing.” They ultimately decided to answer “Other” and wrote in “not currently employed” as the reason for being absent from work. This participant also thought it was confusing to be asked about usual and actual hours worked in the prior week; the participant answered “0” for both.

3.8.2 Round 1 Recommendations

As there were minor usability issues with the questions in the “not working” section that participants were easily able to navigate, no changes are recommended. Further, although one participant initially did not enter a unit of time in the dropdown, once they encountered the error message, they were easily able to fix their error, indicating that the error message was helpful to them.

Further, as there were 5 participants who were confused about being taken down the path of being absent from work if they reported owning a business but not working in that business in the prior week, we recommend considering this unique employment situation to identify if there are ways to remediate this confusion.

3.8.3 Round 2 Findings

Although there were no major usability issues for any of the questions in the “not working” section, a few participants had minor issues with the question that asked how long they had been looking for work (**Figure 3.42**).

During Round 2, three participants saw this question for a member of the household and had a different process for entering their response. Although these participants (described

below) had minor usability issues, they were easily able to navigate these issues and ultimately able to enter a response.

One participant (P1919, computer) selected “months” in the unit dropdown before entering the number 12 into the text box. This participant explained during probing, “I had to scroll first [in the dropdown] before I went back to here to enter the amount [in the numeric entry box]. I wasn't sure what was going to show up here [in the dropdown], even though it said it.” During probing, they added, “I found it slightly clunky because normally, you want to go left to right and I assumed that when I did the dropdown, it would say weeks, months, or years, but for some reason I felt more comfortable going right to left and first clicking what I was defining and then putting the amount of it. So I wanted to say months and then 12, as opposed to entering 12 and then clicking the amount of months, for some reason.” Although the presentation of the entry fields was not what they expected, this participant was able to enter their answer without issue.

Another participant (P1549, smartphone) selected “years” from the unit dropdown first, then entered the number in the text box. They wanted to enter 1.5, but when they realized that they were not able to enter decimals, they entered 2. During probing, they commented, “The only thing I didn't like was that it wasn't allowing decimals, so like me I have been looking for a job for a year and a half but I couldn't put 'point 5'. Or you could separate the years and the months. That way if some people want to give a more accurate answer they could. Like for me I wanted to put a year and a half but I could only put 1 or 2 years.”

The last participant (P2019, computer) entered the number 8 into the text box first and then selected weeks from the dropdown. During probing, this participant commented that the dropdown selection for the unit of time was confusing: “It's kind of funny to select weeks months or years. Perhaps it could just be 'what is the duration?' because now I have to ask myself, 'oh my god do I need to do some math here?' Do they want eight weeks or two months?' That's the same answer. I think it's confusing, and when I get confused about things like that, I just tend to be like ah whatever.”

Overall, although these participants had minor issues with the steps taken to enter their response, they were ultimately able to enter their answers.

A few participants had some issues with determining responses to questions in this “not working” section and potentially received questions that they perceived did not apply to their situation.

One participant (P1800, computer) reported that they own a business but are not currently working in the business and received questions about being absent from work, which was very confusing for them: “This question is also making an assumption that if you have a business, it is the same thing as if you are employed... there is something to be absent

from and there's got to be one main reason you are not doing it. But when you own your own business, and you're putting other things first... it's not really a source of income, it's just something that you have... it's a gray area that the survey is not made to handle with nuance."

Another participant (P1760, computer) was not currently working because they are enrolled in school. On the question that asked, "Did you actually work at a job or business?" this participant had a lot of trouble answering because they were not sure if the survey was asking about gigs/temporary work/inconsistent income or more permanent jobs/consistent income. The participant indicated that they have worked gigs/temporary jobs in the past year but not permanent jobs/consistent income in the past year; they ultimately decided to select no and not include gigs/temporary work in their answer. Similarly, on the question that asked, "When did you last work?" this participant answered, "More than 12 months ago" and did not include gigs/temporary work in their answer.

Another participant (P1754, smartphone) was unsure if they should include looking for surveys in their answer for "Have you been doing anything to find work during the last 4 weeks?"; they ultimately decided to say "Yes" and count them because they get paid for them.

3.8.4 Round 2 Recommendations

Because there were no major usability issues with the functionality of these questions, no changes are recommended. Although some participants answered the question asking how long they had been looking for work (**Figure 3.42**) by reporting the unit of time first and then entering a number into the text box, this did not cause major usability issues for these participants and they were able to enter a response.

3.9 Disability Questions

Participants saw six questions about the disability status of their household. Each question asked if any members in the household had a certain disability (e.g., **Figure 3.44**), and if the participant selected "Yes," they were prompted to indicate which household member had the condition (**Figure 3.45**).

Figure 3.44. Round 1 Disability Question (Example)

Is anyone deaf or does anyone have serious difficulty hearing?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Figure 3.45. Round 1 Disability Question: If Yes, Select All That Apply

Who is that?

Select all that apply.

☐ Joe Poe

In production, the disability series is only asked during MIS-1 and MIS-5 or when a new person is added to the household roster. Since some participants added household members to the roster in Round 2, they were routed to update the disability questions. Participants routed to the disability questions in Round 2 were asked to update their information from Round 1. The initial Yes/No question is prefilled with their selection in the previous interview (e.g., **Figure 3.46**) and if they selected “Yes” the page shows the list of household members with the selection of who they selected in the previous interview (**Figure 3.47**). Both questions can be revised by the participant as needed.

Figure 3.46. Round 2 Disability Question (Example)

Previously you answered the following question as shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select “Next” if this information is still correct.

Is anyone deaf or does anyone have serious difficulty hearing?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Figure 3.47. Round 2 Disability Question: If Yes, Select All That Apply

Who is that?

Select all that apply.

☐ Joe Poe

3.9.1 Round 1 Findings

There were no major usability issues for the disability section during Round 1, nor any major differences between the smartphone and computer cases. Participants felt that the questions were generally easy to answer, and a few found the format of the question

particularly effective (P1957, computer; P1760, computer; P1367, smartphone; P1726, smartphone; P1451, computer). For example, one participant noted, "I think they are just trying to see if anybody has a disability preventing them maybe from working, so I went through and answered yes or no to all the questions. It was very easy to click on the little circles to make my selection" (P1957, computer) and another explained, "Yeah, all of this makes sense to me. And it's very simple because you can just click on the person's name" (P1726, smartphone).

Four participants (3 smartphone, 1 computer) found the sequence longwinded (P1880, smartphone; P1303, computer; P1716, smartphone; P2129, smartphone). One participant noted that they were not used to seeing disability questions in this format but understood why they were asked in a series:

"These aren't the normal types of questions that I'm used to being asked... Usually in surveys that I've taken it's worded as 'do you or anyone in your household have one of the following disabilities?' and then it would probably be like 'difficulty hearing'. That would be like one of the options. And then there'd usually be a series of check boxes. But I also acknowledge that there may be a reason why these questions are phrased one at a time in the way they are" (P1880, smartphone).

Another participant agreed that they would have preferred to see all disability questions on one continuous page, "These were all clear, and it would have been really nice to have them all on one page. This is nice [referring to the screenshot used during probing], because they're all in the same vein" (P1303, computer).

Four participants assumed these questions were work-related and asked to assess a person's ability to work (P1450, computer; P1451, computer; P1820, computer; P1980, smartphone). Although some did not take issue with this, others found the questions particularly invasive (P1820, computer; P1804, computer; P1616, smartphone; P1725, smartphone; P1303, computer; P1644, computer; P1498, smartphone). One participant explained their concerns:

"My first question was, 'why do they need to know it?' My second thought is well, they're probably thinking about it related to employment. Are there people who maybe would work if they could, but they can't, and these are the reasons why? It might have been nice to be told that, to explain what this is used for, because, again, particularly the one that's touched on mental conditions, I would never say yes to any of those things [due to confidentiality concerns]" (P1880, smartphone).

Another participant explained, "I think this is really good to try to get this data. I don't know how people respond. But it's pretty invasive information, like identity, so maybe it's helpful [to explain] why it's important" (P1725, smartphone, computer).

3.9.2 Round 1 Recommendations

We recommend adding a “Help” or “More information” button to address privacy concerns

3.9.3 Round 2 Findings

Almost all participants found the prefilled disability questions in Round 2 easy to confirm and answer. There were two cases that did not see the disability sequence, and it is unclear why (P1800, computer; P1980, smartphone), but otherwise there were no major usability issues.

A few participants found the prefilled data helpful to clarify changes that had occurred between rounds (P1398, smartphone; P1591, smartphone; P2055, smartphone). For example, P1398 smartphone (smartphone) answered “Yes” to the question about difficulty walking or climbing stairs for themselves during Round 1 because of a foot surgery. Their injury had since healed at the time of the Round 2 interview. When answering the question they noted, “And now I’m going to say ‘no’ for myself because my foot surgery is healed.” Later, they mentioned that updating the question was, “Easy because for the most part everything probably stayed the same but then something may have changed. And actually, it did for me” (P1398, smartphone).

Despite the ease of answering the questions, five participants mentioned that they found the sequence annoying and unnecessary (P2138, computer; P1364, computer; P1450, computer; P1328, computer; P1395, smartphone). One participant noted, “So again, it’s asking me a little bit of the same question. Asking me if anyone is deaf or, you know, anyone with an impairment that to me has nothing to do with if I selected ‘no.’ It’s not a question that I feel should be re-asked.” This participant continued and said, “If I had answered ‘yes’ to having a disability then the questions would seem quite natural. But because I had indicated that I had no disability in the prior interview, and to ask me seven more additional questions pertaining to a question I had initially said no to, I could see that as being problematic” (P1395, smartphone).

“I guess I was just kind of wondering like why it matters, especially because I had already answered the employment questions at this point, so it’s clearly not tied to ability to work or anything. But, yeah, maybe that makes me a little more hesitant to answer yes for any of these because I don’t really know what it’s gathering. I think people are sensitive about answering health information, so the safer option in a lot of cases might be just to say no. So maybe just knowing why it was being asked would reassure me” (P1568, smartphone).

Some participants were also confused about who the question was asking about (P1568, smartphone; P2158, smartphone). One participant expressed, “This is minor, but I assume

that they're asking about the people that I've listed on my survey? But it says does anyone, like, does anyone in the world? Does anyone in my household? Does anyone in my family?" (P2158, smartphone).

3.9.4 Round 2 Recommendations

Given that some participants found the Round 2 disability questions redundant and burdensome, consider whether it is possible to identify changes in disability status more efficiently or through fewer questions. Alternatively, consider editing the introductory text to emphasize that the purpose of the question is to capture any changes in their household for when this series is on path. For example, consider the language "Previously you answered the following questions as shown below. Please update the information below if these household characteristics have changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct."

3.10 Nativity Dropdown

In Round 1 all participants were asked about their country of birth, their parents' countries of birth, and any household members' and their parents' countries of birth (e.g., **Figure 3.48**). Participants used an interactive dropdown list of countries meaning they could either type in partial/full countries and then select the desired option from the dropdown menu or they could scroll through the list of countries and select their response.

In Round 2, the nativity section was only shown to participants who either had missing data from Round 1 or had newly added household members. The questions had prefilled responses for pre-existing household members and items that had previously been answered and prompted participants to enter the nativity information for new household members.

Figure 3.48. Round 1 Nativity Dropdown

A screenshot of a web form titled "In what country were you born?". Below the title is a label "Country" followed by a text input field and a dropdown arrow icon. The entire form is enclosed in a black rectangular border.

In what country were you born?

Country

▼

3.10.1 Round 1 Findings

The interactive dropdown list of countries was generally well-received, with almost all participants using a combination of typing and selecting the country from the predictive dropdown list or selecting the pinned option, United States, from the top of the dropdown. There were no participants who scrolled through the entire list in search for their desired country. One participant (P2055, smartphone) initially scrolled through and sarcastically commented, "Yay, I love trying to find countries." About halfway through the dropdown, this

participant abandoned their effort and typed the first couple of letters of their country and then selected the response. Later they expressed, "I forget sometimes to just type it in and it'll just show up but it's simple. I always start scrolling anyways, just repeat what I did" (P2055, smartphone).

The placement of "United States" as the first option on the list was appreciated among several participants. One participant explained, "I like how it shows United States first, that way I don't have to scroll through. I fill out a lot of things and I have to scroll all the way down alphabetically until I find the letter U and it's really annoying, so I like that that was at the top" (P1303, computer). Another participant expressed:

"Yeah, I actually did have a specific thought with that. In doing all those other surveys, normally is alphabeticalized [sic] so when you click the country, the drop down, you have to scroll way way, it's a pain in the butt. I like how this one was structure. How you have the United States is right across the top of the tab. Obviously not done in alphabetical, but it made it very easy and quick to pick as opposed to scroll way way way down" (P1617 smartphone)

Fourteen participants also noted that the ability to type partial countries and select from the predictive dropdown was helpful (P1885, smartphone; P1716, smartphone; P1511, smartphone; P1973, smartphone; P1960, smartphone; P1880, smartphone; P1820, computer; P1712, smartphone; P1666, computer; P1578, smartphone; P1498, smartphone; P1470, computer; P1451, computer; P1398, smartphone). As one participant explained, "That was extremely helpful, because you don't have to waste time typing the whole country." (P1885 smartphone). Another participant explained, "That was easy. I figured it out. You just put U and United States just comes up automatically because at first it was a little frustrating. I was like, oh my god, I'm going to have to type" (P1712 smartphone).

Although many participants found it helpful to type in partial responses before selecting the country from the dropdown, five participants were unsure how to interact with the textbox (P1760, computer; P2141, computer; P2140, smartphone; P2055, smartphone; P1944, computer). One participant mentioned:

"That was the only thing, was [sic] the time I didn't know if I was supposed to click on the arrow. Maybe if it was a little bit more prominent or had a different color so it can direct you more because I just assumed click on it and when it took a while, I didn't know if I had done something wrong. It was a learning process." (P1760 computer)

This participant (P1760, computer) and a couple other computer participants (P1533, computer; P1429, computer) experienced some delays when they clicked on the dropdown, and that contributed to their confusion. "I noticed there was a bit of a lag upon clicking that

dropdown box and it was about three seconds before the options popped up" (P1429, computer).

Other issues stemmed from participants entering things like "USA" or "US" into the textbox which made it appear as an accepted value. However, the instrument was designed with the intention that the participants would select the "United States" option from the dropdown. As a result, participants who entered answers like "USA" or "US" were administered follow-up questions that are only asked to people who report birth countries other than the United States. This led seven participants to answer additional questions about their citizenship status, which caused confusion (P1800, computer; P1754, smartphone; P1696, computer; P1367, smartphone; P1883, computer; P1644, computer; P1395 smartphone). One participant who selected "US" as their response noted:

"I didn't come to live [in the United States], I was born here. ... It's confusing because if a person is born in the United States, then the question says, 'what year did you come to the United States?' To me, that's confusing. That's worded in a way that's a little bit confusing. But I am simply going to click on the year I was born, because I'm assuming that's what they want" (P1644, computer).

A few participants searched for countries that had several names listed (P2029, computer; P1568, smartphone; P1563, computer). See an example of the response options listed when "China" is entered into the textbox, shown in **Figure 3.49**.

Figure 3.49. Round 1 Nativity Dropdown: China Example



The screenshot shows a web form titled "In what country were you born?". Below the title is a label "Country" and a text input field containing the word "china" with a red squiggly underline. A dropdown menu is open, displaying a list of search results: "CHINA", "CHINA HONG KONG", "MAINLAND CHINA", "PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF CHINA", "RED CHINA", and "REPUBLIC OF CHINA". A vertical scrollbar is visible on the right side of the list. At the bottom of the form, there is a dark blue footer bar with the text "OMB No. 0607-0725".

This caused confusion as explained by one participant, “So I think generally it was okay. I know I had feedback on those like different variations of like the same country. And I don't know what is the best option to pick so I kind of just picked one of them. But if I really wanted to be accurate it would be nice to know like what the recommendation is on which one to pick. Current country names or maybe historical names or if it doesn't make a difference” (P1568, smartphone).

Nine participants also found the sequence redundant and bothersome (P2129, smartphone; P1658, computer; P1470, computer; P1364, computer; P1450, computer; P1616, smartphone), particularly among three of these participants who had biological children listed as household members (P1303, computer; P1330, smartphone; P1716, smartphone). One participant commented:

“So, I guess you're asking me all these questions redundantly because you don't know if I'm like an adopted parent. But if you asked me if these are the biological children, then I wouldn't have to answer these questions again. So, this is really redundant for me” (P1716, smartphone).

Another participant mentioned that they would have preferred reporting the household nativity on one screen instead of going through a sequence: “Same old, same old. I think these could be eliminated and just, the whole family pretty much is going to be about the same. Like it just ask about maybe the family background versus the entire makeup” (P2129, smartphone). This participant later clarified: “...I think you should, maybe you could ask 'Is everyone in the household of the same ethnic background?' versus each person because the more lengthier a survey is, the less often a person is willing to finish it” (P2129, smartphone).

The dropdown menu also presented a couple of unique usability problems for some participants. For example, two smartphone participants (P1395, smartphone; P1576, smartphone) and one tablet participant (P1328) had issues with the keyboard overlapping the dropdown menu when they clicked into the textbox. This made it difficult for them to select an option from the dropdown menu, although two of the three were eventually able to do so successfully. A couple of computer participants (P1324, computer; P1919, computer) also had issues clicking on response options and the down arrow to scroll through the dropdown list.

3.10.2 Round 1 Recommendations

It is noted that some of the participants who experienced delays when they clicked on the dropdown menu had bandwidth or internet connection issues; however, consider updating the load time of the country list if possible.

Given usability issues seen in a few cases, consider revising the formatting such that the keyboard does not overlap the dropdown menu arrows, particularly when viewed on a mobile device.

Consider updating the predictive text within the dropdown menu so that entries like "US" or "USA" allow for the "United States" option to appear in the dropdown. Currently, "United States" only appears if "U" is typed into the textbox and disappears if further letters other than "n" are entered. If possible, allow entries like "US" and "USA" to be accepted as "United States" so that participants do not get routed through questions about their citizenship status.

If possible, review the list of countries for duplicate or similar country names so that it is clear which one participants should select (e.g., response options listed when "China" is typed into the textbox).

3.10.3 Round 2 Findings

The dropdown list for Round 2 was modified to reduce the issue identified in Round 1 where participants entered "US" or "USA." Responses were only captured if the participant selected an item from the dropdown, therefore preventing custom typed-in answers. However, only five participants (P1294, computer; P1395, smartphone; P1721, smartphone; P2133, smartphone; P1754, smartphone) saw the nativity sequence in Round 2 because it was only asked of participants who either had missing data from Round 1 or added new household members during Round 2. Of those who saw the questions, most did not have prefilled data due to unrecognized responses (e.g., participants who entered "USA" instead of selecting "United States" from the dropdown menu). All but one of the respondents who saw the nativity sequence in Round 2 clicked on the dropdown menu and selected the first option (United States) with ease. One participant (P1294, computer) first attempted to type their non-United States response, but quickly noticed it would not have been accepted as a typed in response. They instead entered the first letter of their country and then scrolled and selected the desired response from the dropdown. They did not make any comments on whether this hindered their experience, but it seemed that they did not struggle with this method.

Of those who saw the questions, all recognized that the data were prefilled from Round 1 responses and noted that they were satisfied with the sequence. Regarding the prefilled responses, one participant noted, "I think they're great. I think they're fine. And I think it helps speed the process along instead of having to re-answer those questions your answers are prefilled. I think that's fine. If it needs to be altered, you have the option to edit your answer" (P1395, smartphone).

Otherwise, there were no major usability issues observed.

3.10.4 Round 2 Recommendations

We recommend continued testing on the new dropdown menu given that there were only five cases that interacted with it, particularly among those whose nativity is outside the United States.

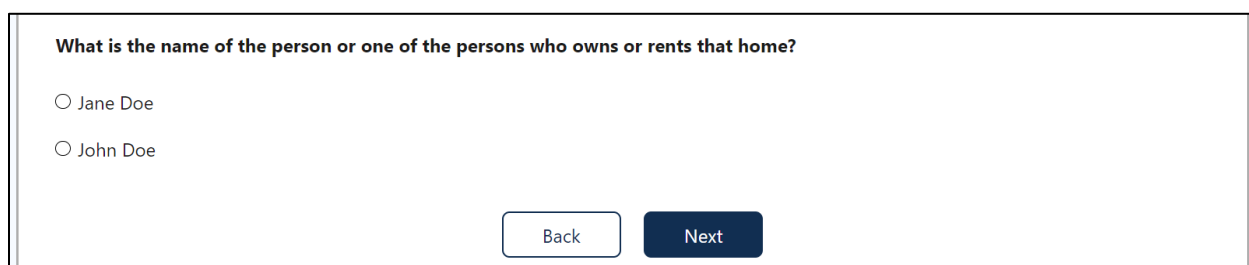
3.11 Miscellaneous Usability Issues

3.11.1 Who Owns or Rents This Home?

Findings

In Round 1, participants were asked which of the persons listed by the participant owned or rented the home where the household lives (**Figure 3.50**).

Figure 3.50. Round 1 Who Owns or Rents the Home?



What is the name of the person or one of the persons who owns or rents that home?

☐ Jane Doe

☐ John Doe

Back Next

This question was set up to accept a single answer, but ten participants mentioned they did not understand why the question only allowed one response and attempted to select more than one (P1294, smartphone; P1804, computer; P1839, computer; P1364, computer; P1451, computer; P1540, computer; P1658, computer; P1398, smartphone; P1876, smartphone; P1960, smartphone).

"We both do, so... [tries to select both]. Oh. [re-reads the question] That was a little confusing because we both own the home and you can't click both, so it's just odd." (P1294, smartphone).

"This one where it says what is the name of the person or one of the persons who owns or rents a home... Ok, so it only wants you pick one, even though both of us own it. That's kind of weird" (P1658, computer).

"Why is there no option to click, why can't we all rent a home at the same time?" (P1364, computer).

Recommendations

Consider allowing for multiple responses in this question.

3.11.2 Visual Design (Font Size/Response Option Size)

Findings

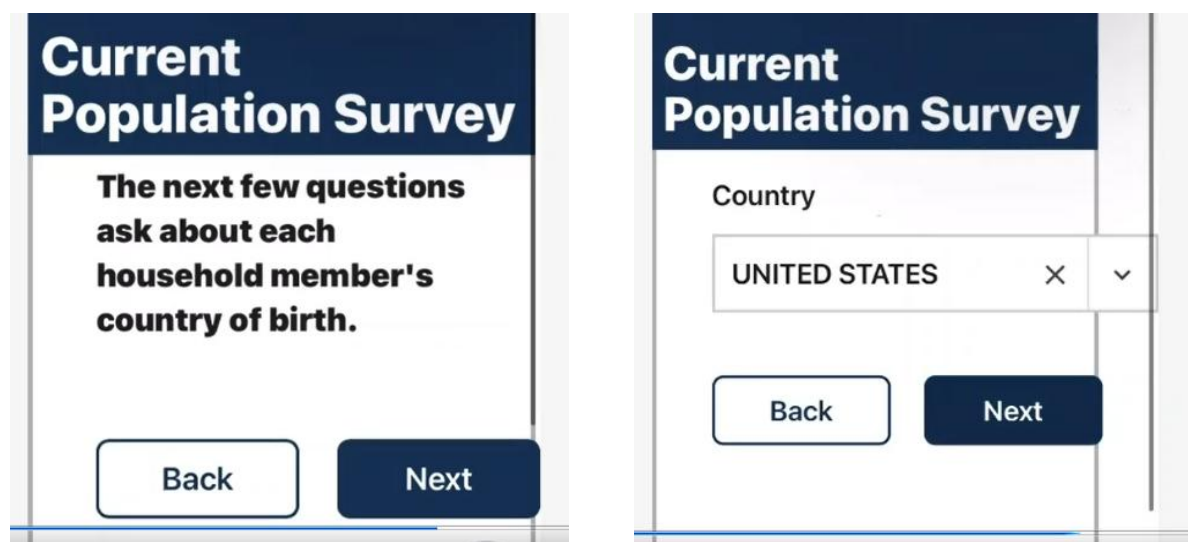
In Round 1 some participants, across different devices, commented that the font size could be bigger and/or the buttons could be larger (P1328, computer tablet; P1760, computer; P1800, computer; P1725, smartphone).

"I would probably say if you have older individuals, maybe a little bit bigger on the font, otherwise, pretty good" (P1760, computer).

"Yeah, I'm managing. I don't have the best vision, so I don't know that I would be the best judge of that... I would say in that sense, I guess... then it might be, could be a little bit more bolder, larger font. But you might have to reformat the whole thing. But for someone with vision difficulties, it's not great on a phone. It would be fine for me on a computer or a tablet" (P1725, smartphone).

As a way of making the font more legible, this same participant had her browser zoomed in. However, this affected the design of some screens. On the nativity dropdown, this caused the text box and in some other screens it caused the "Next" buttons to be extended off the edge of her screen (**Figure 3.51**). However, this did not affect the usability of the dropdown or the Next buttons.

Figure 3.51. Example Screens of Mobile Participant who had Zoomed into the Browser



Another participant (P1800, computer) felt that the distance between the response option bubbles, and the Next button was large, they were far away from each other because the screen was so wide but said that it was not a serious issue. This participant also asked if the

buttons for selecting response options could be larger and could have more area for clickable space.

Participants also had mixed reactions to the visual design of the survey in Round 2. Some participants said that they liked the visual design of the survey and that it made it easy to respond:

"I thought it was easy, I mean, it was easy to read, it was easy to see, it was big enough, like I didn't have any problems" (P1327, computer).

"Super easy, very [well] laid out, not too many words on the page, which I liked. I was able to understand everything that it was asking, and it just was easily written, and you could just like understand every question. I didn't have to think too much about anything" (P1450, computer).

"No, it was so easy. So, I just liked how there's not a lot of words on the page and you don't have to read too much, so. It's fast, it gets to the point" (P1450, computer).

"No, they were all easy, straightforward, easy to read. Anything I needed to change was right there" (P2055, smartphone).

However, other participants had suggestions for improvements:

"It was fine and easy. You know what I had to say and I don't know if this has to do with my mouse, but this blue header on top of survey] made me have to scroll a lot. I like to see everything on one page" (P1238, computer).

One participant said that the font could be slightly darker to contrast more with the white background (P1383, computer).

One participant (P1935, computer) commented on the Yes/No radio button questions early in the survey and the gray bar that appears when the cursor is over one of the response options: "So for selecting the options I feel like maybe, um, I don't know. I'm just wondering, so there's this gray bar that's included with each of the options and I feel like it would be easier to use if the gray bar was slightly more visible."

Figure 3.52 below shows an example of what these comments refer to, where the "Current Population Survey" banner takes up much of the screen real estate on a laptop screen (as mentioned by P1238, computer). Furthermore, it shows that when the mouse is hovering over a response option, the gray highlighting could have further contrast with the white background (as mentioned by P1935). However, we do note that the gray and white contrast issue could potentially have 508 compliance implications.

Figure 3.52. Example Screen on a Laptop

An official website of the United States government [here's how you know](#)

FAQ Español Save and Log out

United States Census Bureau Current Population Survey

☐ Some college but no degree

☐ Associate degree in college - Occupational/vocational program

☐ Associate degree in college -- Academic program

☐ Bachelor's degree (For example: BA, AB, BS)

☒ Master's degree (For example: MA, MS, MEng, MEd, MSW, MBA)

☐ Professional School Degree (For example: MD, DDS, DVM, LLB, JD)

☐ Doctorate degree (For example: PhD, EdD)

Return to Review

Back Next

OMB No. 0607-0725
OMB Expiration Date 12/31/2025

Accessibility Privacy Security Contact Us

Recommendations

Although some participants had some suggestions for improvements of the visual design of the survey, there were no major usability issues related to the visual design. Therefore, there are no recommended changes. However, we urge that designers consider the participant views presented here when they design a final version for implementation, including any 508 compliance implications.

3.11.3 Error Messages

Findings

In Round 1, a few participants received error messages that seemed to indicate an issue with the server. However, they were able to refresh the page and continue with the survey without issue.

One participant (P1429, computer) received an error message when they reached the screen asking for telephone number. The message stated, "Your current session has gotten out of sync with the server, this is most likely due to another user working on the same thing you are. We need to reset your session to the last known good state." The participant clicked "Ok" and the page refreshed, taking them back to the previous question that asked about phones in the household. This participant did not have any further reaction to this error message.

Another participant (P1754, smartphone) received two error messages while completing the survey. A first error message popped up when the person was responding to employment questions about the first person in the household, but the participant clicked okay too quickly and the interviewer could not see it. It did not show on the recording because the

Teams icon was covering it, but the screen refreshed and the participant was able to continue without any problems. The second error message appeared while the participant was answering the disability questions. It said "Something went wrong! We were unable to save your latest data. We need to reset your session to the last known good state." It was unclear why they received this error. They clicked "OK," the page refreshed, and they were able to continue with no problems. During the debriefing probes, this participant mentioned these error messages when asked how the CPS survey compared to other surveys they have completed, saying, "I kept getting an error." Otherwise, this participant did not have any other reactions to these messages, as they were able to refresh the page and continue on with the survey each time.

Finally, one participant (P1578, smartphone) received a "Session out of sync with the server" error that occurred at the level of the education screen for Person 1. The participant had to re-enter the date of birth questions. This participant did not have any further reaction to this error message.

Recommendations

Receiving these error messages did not cause any usability issues for these participants. Without being sure about the reason for the errors, we have no recommendation to make.

3.11.4 FAQ/Progress Bar

Findings

About a dozen participants across rounds wished the survey had a progress bar to know how much more they had ahead, along the lines of the following quotes:

"...Oh, by the way, it would have been nice to have some sort of progress bar. I know it's hard because some questions are skipped... that would be really nice because they know I'm making progress" (P1800, computer).

"...There wasn't even a progress bar that kind of showed that you're X percentage of the way through or you're on this section and there are five sections total. So I guess if someone didn't have a lot of time and they thought it was going to be quick and then they got part-way through it and they're like, 'well, I've got to go do something' they don't have any idea if it's going to save" (P1563, computer).

"What I did like is that many surveys it tells you that you are at question 11 out of 80, 12 out of 80, it tells you how many screens you've done and how many you have left, I didn't see that on yours and I like that. It doesn't make me think that I have 15 more pages, 20 more pages, I just do it until I am done" (P1721, smartphone).

"I mean my overall thoughts it's a little cumbersome. It's like a lot of short questions and also I kind of wish, going on, that I knew how many more questions there were going to be like a little tracker bar" (P2019, computer).

While answering the satisfaction survey, one participant mentioned that there was no hover-over text for additional information on any of the questions to give more information in case the respondent needed help answering a question, including knowing if a partial survey could be saved.

"So, I guess if someone didn't have a lot of time and they thought it was going to be quick and then they got part-way through it and they're like, 'well, I've got to go do something' they don't have any idea if it's going to save" (P1563, computer).

Recommendations

Participants' comments showed that they did not know some basic information about the survey (such as approximate burden) or where to go if they had questions. We did not observe any participant click or comment on the FAQ button or the Save and Log out button. The current position of the FAQ and the Save and Log out buttons can be seen in **Figure 3.53**.

Figure 3.53. Current Location of the FAQ/Save and Log Out Buttons

The screenshot displays the top navigation bar of the United States Census Bureau Current Population Survey. The bar is dark blue with white text. On the left, the 'United States Census Bureau' logo is visible, followed by the text 'Current Population Survey'. On the right, there are two buttons: 'FAQ' and 'Save and Log out'. Both buttons are highlighted with a red rectangular border. Below the navigation bar, the main content area is white. It contains a question: 'What is the name of the person or one of the persons who owns or rents that home?'. Below the question are two radio button options: 'Jane Doe' and 'John Doe'. At the bottom of the main content area, there are two buttons: 'Back' and 'Next'. The 'Back' button is white with a blue border, and the 'Next' button is solid blue with white text. At the very bottom of the page, there is a dark blue footer bar. On the left, it contains the text 'OMB No. 0607-0725' and 'OMB Expiration Date 12/31/2025'. On the right, it contains the text 'Accessibility', 'Privacy', 'Security', and 'Contact Us', each followed by a small icon.

The survey methods literature generally does not recommend including a progress bar, and programming one would be nearly impossible given the varied skip patterns. Nonetheless, making it more evident for participants where to get answers to their questions would be useful, particularly in production to reduce possible breakoffs. We recommend looking for a

way to make these buttons more visible, to make them stand out. For example, the buttons could have labels in blue font inside white frames in that same upper-right corner of the screen.

3.11.5 Accidentally Exiting Out of the Survey

Findings

In Round 2, a few participants exited out of the survey by mistake. These were people answering the survey on smartphones, where they accidentally used the back button on their phone (i.e., clicked back in the browser). This logged them out of the survey, and they had to login again. They were pleasantly surprised to see that the survey had saved their previous answers and took them back to where they had left off.

For example, after the interviewer asked one participant to return to the household roster screen, the participant (P1616, smartphone) hit the browser back button on their phone instead of the back button in the programmed instrument. This took them out of the survey and back to login page where they were asked to enter their email. The participant then had to complete the login process again before getting back to the survey.

Another participant (P1754, smartphone) had a similar situation. When they were logged out of the survey they said: "I can't believe you can't go back one, that's not good... that's not helpful." During probing, the interviewer asked the participant what made it easy to complete this survey on their smartphone, and they said, "Definitely going back to where you were if you got bumped off, that was a lot of help, because if I had to do it over and over again, I would have been very frustrated and I might not have gone through with it... I think that was a good failsafe for them to put in."

Recommendations

The recommendation provided in **Section 3.2.7** could also be applicable here, to discourage respondents from using the back button in the browser. If participants attempt to use this back button in the browser rather than the back button on screen in the CPS survey, a message such as the following could appear: "Confirm form resubmission."

3.11.6 Submit Page

Findings

In Round 2, a few participants commented on the fact that they cannot review or edit their answers once they get to the submit page, unless they click the back button.

"The only thing that really did make me feel if anything uncomfortable, it's not like these questions are doctor's questions, where it's like life or death, but like I said, at the end where I click the last page and suddenly I can't go back anymore and I'm told once I hit submit, that's it and you can't go back anymore, I'm being told this,

but I don't really have a way to review what I've said. So the way it's worded... it's like oh, should I really review what I just wrote?... Especially if you might be conversing with these people in the future. If you're going to show the survey and what I answered before is going to pop up, I'm already going to trust you that what I answered before is already there. But if I wasn't going to go back, I'd get nervous... so especially if you're going to be talking to these people for a long time, more than once, maybe make sure that the first answers are the right answers. That's definitely something that I would see as a red flag in getting the right data" (P1760, computer).

While reviewing the submit screen, one participant (P2158, smartphone) said that they were assuming that once they submitted, they would be shown a confirmation page, noting that it says you cannot change anything. This person said that they wanted to be able to see their answers without having to back through the whole survey. However, they were not sure what to do if they wanted to review something and change something. There were a few additional comments about the submit page:

"...And also the submit, the last couple of screens was, you were, I wasn't submitting at that point. Other than that, there, you know, it seemed pretty easy" (P1716, smartphone).

"No everything was pretty much straightforward and other than, you know, it said 'you are almost completed' until you had to keep clicking on 'next' to get to the end, the confirmation" (P2133, smartphone).

"The last, on the very last page, when we finish, it would have been nice to see like 'thank you' written in like big bold letters and just a really brief summary from like one to four sentences of the importance of filling out the survey, so that people will leave with, knowing, feeling that they've contributed to the US Census" (P1364, computer).

Recommendations

Implement a feature that would allow respondents to review their answers before submitting.

3.12 Miscellaneous Cognitive Issues

3.12.1 Don't Know/Unsure Option

Findings

Although already discussed in the usual/actual hours worked section, it is worth mentioning that some participants were vocal about needing an option to indicate they did not know certain information for other household members. They were looking for a "Don't know" or

“Unsure” response option for many questions. Some examples include the following situations.

One participant (P1367, smartphone) rented rooms to others in their home and reported them as household members, but they did not know many of the answers to the questions asked about the renters. This participant explained their frustration with not having any options to indicate “Don’t know” on any of the questions.

Another participant (P1568, smartphone) was filling out the certification/license question for the second household member and said they would not be sure how to proceed if they did not know the answer for the other household member. “Questions like this I’m kind of like, what if I don’t know? Is there an option to, like, skip and come back to it? That would be nice.” This participant also said they weren’t sure about the number of hours that their household members worked: “Yeah, again, this is like, because I’m answering on behalf of someone maybe it’s a best guess.”

Another participant (P1754, smartphone) wrote in “IDK” in answer to the question asking for usual activities or duties at a household member’s job.

Recommendations

Consider if any questions could include a “Don’t know” response option, particularly when asked about other household members. We understand the risk of giving respondents an easy way to avoid estimating (or feeling they are providing information about others without their permission) in proxy responses, but there may be some items where missing data for proxy responses is a well-known occurrence and a “Don’t know” answer might be more useful than a blank.

3.12.2 Unique Employment Situations

Findings

Some participants had unique employment situations and went down a survey path that they thought did not necessarily match their situation.

One participant (P1549, smartphone) was not working but currently looking for work. They answered “yes” to the question asking if they had done any work for pay last week, thus routing down the “single job” display logic. The participant indicated that in the week prior they had participated in a research study and received an incentive for doing so but they were not employed. When they saw the question asking about the usual number of hours worked, they were confused: “Umm, how would I answer this? Would I just put '0' if I am currently unemployed?” ... “Yeah, I mean, I did a research study. I participated in a research study which, I mean, I consider work for pay because they did pay me” (P1549, smartphone).

One participant (P1297, smartphone) used the back button in the Looking for Work section. They were actively looking for work while already employed, but they were asked why they had stopped working. They used the back button to see the previous question but did not change anything and then returned to the reason for stopping work question. They had not stopped working but chose Temporary Job Ended: "I was looking for something part time as I'm working. ... I don't know about this one. I'll just say 'temporary job ended'."

Last, another participant (P2141, computer) indicated during the interview that their wife is retired but does small jobs/gig work for extra money. Therefore, they indicated that their wife worked for pay in the prior week, but when asked how many hours she usually works, the participant responded "0" because their wife is retired. Because of this combination of responses, the participant was taken down a path that was very confusing to them and indicated that there was no way to report that their wife is retired but does small jobs for extra money.

Furthermore, there were five participants who owned businesses but did not work in the business in the prior week. Therefore, the survey took them down the path of being absent from work, which was very confusing to them. These participants' experiences with the CPS survey are described in **Section 3.8.1**.

Recommendations

Consider these situations and their likely prevalence in the overall survey population. Depending on the potential impact of these, there may be a need to make design changes in the survey.

3.12.3 Miscellaneous Additional Cognitive Issues

One participant made an interesting suggestion that may be useful to respondents in general. They said that they wanted the introduction to the employment section ("These questions ask about work-related activities last week") to include a specific range of dates for the week in question: "Maybe it would be clearer to put actual dates on it, depending on when the person is taking the survey, because thinking back, I'm like okay what day is it today, like what does last week count as? Is it Sunday through Thursday? Or is it Sunday through Saturday of last week? What are the actual boundaries I should be thinking about?" (P1568, smartphone). However, this was intentionally programmed in this manner (i.e., without specific dates) for usability testing, as interviews continued on a rolling basis throughout two months. This will not be the case in CPS production.

One participant (P1328, computer) wanted more information about why the survey was asking questions about their work history: "Certain portions of it I was, didn't see the necessity of the questions as far as income and if we're working and I didn't like that part. I didn't think it had any relevance but that's just my opinion."

One participant (P1563, computer) had some difficulty reporting whether they and another household member (Person 2) were working during the previous week; both had been away on vacation together. To the question "LAST WEEK, did you do ANY work for either pay or profit?" the participant answered Yes for themselves, but No for Person 2. Neither reported any hours worked the previous week. This impacted the follow-up questions that were displayed for Person 1 because they were shown questions about being absent from work (they selected "vacation or personal time off"). However, they did report 0 actual hours worked for both household members. It is unclear why this participant answered differently for each person.

Although most participants probed about this had no issue, one participant remarked on how repetitive it seemed to have a similar introduction for several questions where participants are told they will be asked questions to verify the information the survey has already gathered. "The fact that it was already filled in? So, that made it easy. I think the only negative that I would have is the, the top part where it says, you know, 'We constantly question,' you know, 'going to give you these questions,' and, I mean, it becomes redundant after each one. It would probably go faster if we just had the question itself because the first time it was mentioned, that's fine, but each. I found myself, after awhile, not wanting to read that part because I already knew what it was" (P1591, smartphone).

Recommendations

No recommendations at this time.

4. Conclusion

4.1 Round 1

In summary, the major findings after Round 1 usability testing include the following. For each section, the usability issues are listed in order of relative severity, with any other observations (including findings of functionality that worked well) listed last.

Survey invitation letter:

- Minor issues with the letter included the following: (1) a few participants had trouble finding the web address for the survey, likely because it does not start with “www”; and (2) although they did not view the letter during testing, a few smartphone participants mentioned the use of a QR code rather than a web address to access the CPS survey.
- When asked about the survey invitation letter, most participants thought that the letter was easy to understand and said that they could easily find the information that they needed.

Login process:

- Some participants who completed their interview on the computer and were sent the survey invitation letter attempted to enter the User ID into the verification code field. Ten of these participants (all computer) were able to figure out the difference on their own, but five of these participants (4 computer, 1 smartphone) had to be guided through this process by the interviewer.
- Two participants had issues with navigating to the web address. Some participants had some trouble with copying and pasting or entering the verification code or the User ID.
- Sixteen participants (9 computer, 7 smartphone) thought that the login process was burdensome because it had more steps than what they were expecting.
- Eight participants commented that either the verification code or the User ID was longer than what they were expecting or what they were used to.
- The recommendations listed in **Section 3.2.4** could potentially make the login process clearer to participants, because some were not expecting the multiple steps required to log in. The recommendations could also make the login process easier for participants, as some thought that the process was burdensome.
- The following findings indicate further observations (i.e., not usability issues) of the login process:

- Sixteen participants used another device during the login process, specifically, to access their email to get the verification code. Many of these participants said that they did this so that they could keep the CPS login screen open in their browser and not have to go to another window/tab to check their email.
- Eight participants mentioned that they did not mind getting the verification code over email but wanted the option to receive it via text.
- Many participants thought that the login screens were clear and felt that they understood what to do on each page. Participants also thought that the email containing the verification code was clear and appreciated that the verification code was displayed in large font. Furthermore, some participants commented that they were expecting or used to a two-step verification login process, which is used on many other websites and apps.

Household roster:

- The major usability/cognitive issues with the household roster include:
 - It was unclear to some participants that they needed to add themselves to the household roster. Some participants asked the interviewer to confirm that they should add themselves on the initial household roster screen, and other participants did not add themselves to the household roster until the interviewer instructed them to do so. If participants were instructed to add themselves to the roster, they had no issues completing this. It should also be noted that some participants did not list themselves first because of the instruction on the page, "Start with the name of the person, or one of the persons, who owns or rents this home." The recommendation listed in **Section 3.3.3** could make it clearer to respondents that they should add themselves to the household roster.
 - A few participants had some trouble deciding who they should include in the household roster.
- Overall, most participants did not have any usability issues with the household roster screens and thought that the process of adding household members was easy.

Demographics (date of birth):

- A few participants were unsure of some household members' complete birthdays and were unsure what to do next. Some participants asked the person if they were present (i.e., in another room, in the household at the time) and some participants made their best guess. Only one of these participants clicked on the "Help" link but could not figure out what to do; this participant entered an age for each person but

not date of birth. One participant did not want to give the full date of birth for each member of her household and preferred to only state their ages.

- Because some participants did not know the date of birth for some household members and one participant did not want to enter the date of birth for any household members because of the sensitivity, the recommendations listed in **Section 3.4.2** could improve the Help functionality on this page.
- Many participants commented that they liked the format of entering month, day, and year as separate dropdowns, especially preferring this method over a calendar method. However, other participants noted that the dropdowns were easy to use, but being able to type into the dropdowns would have been faster.

Usual and actual hours:

- As had been the case in cognitive testing, some participants objected about being asked both usual and actual hours, because they work the same number of hours every week and are not allowed to work more hours. Others thought the question may need to be answered with the number of hours they get paid for, regardless of how many hours they actually work.
- We recommended using the instructions that were tested in the second round of CPS cognitive testing, as described in **Section 3.5.2**.
- Sixteen participants who reported multiple jobs for themselves or a household member were probed on their preference about seeing the usual hours questions (and later about the actual hours questions) for the main and other job on the same page or across different pages. All but one of the 16 participants preferred reporting them on the same page.
- Survey designers had wondered if the labels for “hours” or “hours per week” were understood to be labels rather than clickable buttons. None of the participants tried to click on a label, and all understood what the labels were for.

Questions for those who are self-employed:

- No recommended changes at this time.

Questions for those who are not working:

- As there were 5 participants who were confused about being taken down the path of being absent from work if they reported owning a business but not working in that business in the prior week, we recommend considering this unique employment situation.

- There were no major usability issues found during Round 1 for any of the “not working” series of questions.
- However, when answering the question that asked how long they had been looking for work (**Figure 3.42**), one participant (P1754, smartphone) entered in the number and did not select the unit of time from the dropdown. When they clicked next, they got the error message (**Figure 3.43**). After this participant saw this message, they were easily able to understand that they needed to select “Weeks” from the dropdown. They were able to fix this error and continue with the survey, indicating that the error message was helpful to them.
- Because there were no usability issues with the questions in the “not working” section, no changes are recommended.
- Last, a few participants were confused about the wording of the question that asked how long they had been looking for work, specifically because the question specified “As of the end of LAST WEEK” (**Figure 3.42**).

Disability questions:

- There were no major usability issues for the disability section during Round 1, nor any major differences between the smartphone and computer cases. Participants felt that the questions were generally easy to answer, and a few found the format of the question particularly effective.
- We recommend adding a “Help” or “More information” button to address privacy concerns (listed in **Section 3.9.2**).

Nativity dropdown:

- Although many participants found it helpful to type in partial responses before selecting the country from the dropdown, some were unsure how to interact with the textbox. Some participants experiencing delays when they clicked on the dropdown, which caused confusion. Other issues stemmed from participants entering things like “USA” or “US” into the textbox without selecting the “United States” option from the dropdown. This led some participants to answer additional questions about their citizenship status, which caused confusion.
- A few participants searched for countries that had several names listed (e.g., China).
- Some participants also found the sequence redundant and bothersome because the sequence asked about each individual and each individual’s mother and father.
- The recommendations listed in **Section 3.10.2** could improve the functionality of this dropdown.

- The interactive dropdown list of countries was generally well-received, with almost all participants using a combination of typing and selecting the country from the predictive dropdown list or selecting the pinned option, United States, from the top of the dropdown. No participants scrolled through the entire list in search for their desired country. The placement of “United States” as the first option on the list was appreciated among several participants.

Miscellaneous usability issues:

- A few participants received error messages that seemed to indicate an issue with the server. However, they were able to refresh the page and continue with the survey without issue.
- About a dozen participants across rounds wished the survey had a progress bar to know how much more of the survey they had left to answer. Participants’ comments showed that they did not know some basic information about the survey (such as approximate burden) or where to go if they had questions. We did not observe any participant click or comment on the FAQ button or the Save and Log out button. The survey methods literature generally does not recommend including a progress bar, and programming one would be nearly impossible given the varied skip patterns. Nonetheless, making it more evident for participants where to get answers to their questions would be useful, particularly in production to reduce possible breakoffs.
- Some participants, across different equipment, commented that the font size could be bigger or the buttons could be larger.
- Participants were asked which of the persons listed by the participant owned or rented the home where the household lives. This question was set up to accept a single answer, but some participants did not understand why the question only allowed one response so some attempted to select more than one.

Miscellaneous cognitive issues:

- Some participants wanted a “don’t know” or “unsure” response option in many sections, as proxy reporting was difficult for these participants.
- Some participants had unique employment situations and went down a survey path that they perceived to not necessarily match their situation (details listed in **Section 3.12.2**).

4.2 Round 2

In summary, the major findings after Round 2 usability testing include the following. Overall, participants were easily able to answer the questions and had no major usability issues with the visual design of the survey. For each section, the usability issues are listed

in order of relative severity, with any other observations (including findings of functionality that worked well) listed last.

Login process:

- One participant did not see the “Resend email” button on the login screen and clicked “Back” in the web browser to enter their email again. This caused confusion for them when the screen refreshed to the same page, and they were unable to enter their email a second time.
- The recommendations listed in **Section 3.2.7** could potentially make the process easier for participants, although the few issues that participants experienced were minor.
- Participants did not have any major usability issues with the login process. However, (similar to Round 1) some participants wanted the ability to receive the verification code over text because this would have been easier for them.

Household roster:

- On the question that asked the reason why the person is removed (**Figure 3.11**), many participants said that some of the response options were confusing or unclear and thought that some of the response options were overlapping. Specifically, participants had trouble with differentiating between the options “Person moved out,” “Person left – usual residence elsewhere last month,” and “Person has a usual residence elsewhere this month.”
- Some participants accessed the household roster edit screen to edit the age of individual household members. Once on this edit screen, these participants did not have any issues making this edit. However, some participants noted that the formatting of the edit screen was confusing.
- The recommendations listed in **Section 3.3.6** could potentially reduce the usability issues described above.
- Overall, most participants did not have any major usability issues with adding or removing individuals from the household roster. Whether they did it spontaneously or because they were instructed by the interviewer, most participants did not have any usability issues with adding or removing participants.
- Most participants said that they appreciated the pop-up asking them to confirm that they wanted to remove an individual from the roster.

Demographics (education):

- Most participants did not have any issues on this screen, whether they received this screen during the CPS instrument or were shown this question in probing.
- Several participants noted that they appreciated having the education question prefilled with dependent data.
- A few participants mentioned during probing that they thought the number of response options was excessive (see **Figure 3.18**).
- Because participants did not have any major usability or cognitive issues that prevented them from answering this question, no changes are recommended. However, the list of response options for this education question could be reduced, if desired.

Usual and actual hours:

- As had been the case in Round 1, some participants appeared unhappy or impatient about having to report both usual and actual hours, and a few mentioned that these questions seemed repetitive to them. In addition, proxy reporting was difficult for some participants.
- In probing, we collected participants' reactions to the instructions added to the usual hours' question: to estimate the usual and not actual hours, to consider the previous 4 months, to report on a typical week if hours varied, and to give best guess if not known. Although some participants had no issue with this set of instructions, with others it yielded mixed results. Although the instructions added to the usual hours' question appeared to work well, the instruction to "consider the past 4 months" was confusing to some participants. During Round 1 cognitive testing of this instrument, this instruction to "consider the last 4 months" was confusing to participants and was removed for Round 2 cognitive testing, where it tested well. We recommend to remove this instruction and use the below version of the question (i.e., the version used in Round 2 cognitive testing):

How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your job?

- *Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked*
- *If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week*
- *If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess*

Industry and occupation:

- The recommendation listed in **Section 3.7.2** could reduce the burden required to answer several confirmation questions. For smartphone participants, we also recommend implementing textbox wrapping so they can review the entire entry without having to click into the textbox and scroll.

- All participants who saw questions IO1DP1 (**Figure 3.35**), IO1DP2 (**Figure 3.36**), and IO1DP3 (**Figure 3.37**) (see **Section 3.7.1**) understood that the textboxes were prefilled with their responses from Round 1 and generally did not struggle to confirm or update the information as needed. Some participants specifically appreciated the use of the dependent data because it made the response process more efficient.
- Some participants needed to update information, and they were able to do so without major issues.
- Overall, participants generally felt that the sequence was easy to answer and geared towards people who might have been promoted or changed jobs since the last interview.

Questions for those who are not working:

- A few participants had some issues with determining responses to questions in this section and they thought they potentially received questions that did not apply to their situation).
- Because there were no major usability issues with the functionality of these questions, no changes are recommended.

Disability questions:

- The recommendations from Round 1 were not applied during Round 2 of testing; however, almost all participants found the prefilled disability questions in Round 2 easy to confirm and answer.
- Despite the ease of answering the questions, a few participants found the sequence annoying and unnecessary.
- There are no additional recommendations aside from those in Round 1. However, as some participants found these questions to be redundant and burdensome, consider whether it is possible to identify changes in disability status more efficiently or through fewer questions.

Nativity dropdown:

- Very few participants saw the nativity sequence in Round 2 because it was only asked of participants who either had missing data from Round 1 or added new household members during Round 2. Of those who saw the questions, all recognized that the data were prefilled from Round 1 responses and noted that they were satisfied with the sequence.
- There are no additional recommendations aside from those in Round 1.

Miscellaneous usability issues:

- A few participants exited out of the survey without intending to. These were people answering the survey on smartphones, where they accidentally used the back button on their phone (i.e., clicked back in the browser). This logged them out of the survey, and they had to log in again. They were pleasantly surprised to see that the survey had saved their previous answers and took them back to where they had left off.
- A few participants commented on the fact that they cannot review or edit their answers once they get to the submit page, unless they click the back button. Census Bureau and BLS could consider implementing a feature that would allow respondents to review their answers before submitting.
- Some participants had mixed reactions to the visual design of the survey. Some participants said that they liked the visual design of the survey and that it made it easy to respond, while other participants had suggestions for improvements.

Appendix A: CO11 Recruitment Materials

A-1. Craigslist Advertisement

Recruitment Advertisement

Get paid for sharing your opinions

RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The interview will take about 60 minutes. We will provide \$50 for participating in the remote interview.**

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:

[LINK]

You may also call xxx-xxx-xxxx to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

A-2. Recruitment Initial Contact Email Template

Subject line: Invitation to participate a Census Bureau Interview

Good [Morning/afternoon], FIRST NAME,

My name is RECRUITER NAME. I am contacting you because you recently expressed interest in participating in an interview to discuss your thoughts and opinions on questions asking about you and your household. This interview is being conducted by RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS) for the United States Census Bureau.

Your responses indicate that you are in **[TIME ZONE]**. Below are some available appointments for an interview:

- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**
- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**
- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**

The interview should take about an hour, and you will receive a \$50 electronic gift card as a thank you for participating in the interview.

Please let me know what time works best for you. Once we confirm the appointment time, I will send an invitation email for the interview.

Thank you,

RECRUITER NAME

A-3. Recruitment Telephone Scripts

INBOUND PHONE CALLS AND PARTICIPANT SCREENING

If callers do not mention or inquire anything about participating in a research study:

Confirm if callers are responding to one of the recruitment advertisements and interested in participating in our study.

Conclude the call if they are not calling to participate.

If they already mentioned the study with the information from the recruitment advertisement:

Cover the following in the call:

- RTI international, a not-for-profit research organization, is conducting research on behalf of the Census Bureau
- We are conducting this research to improve the survey questions for the Current Population Survey
- We will ask you a few questions about your background and your household to determine if you are eligible for the interview
- The screening questions will take about 10 minutes
- Eligible participants can receive \$50 for completing a virtual-person interview. Interviews will last about 1 hour.

Confirm if callers want to proceed to be screened.

If they agree

Load up the web screener: [LINK]

Read the questions from the web screener to the caller, adjusting the wording as necessary so that it makes sense as a phone survey that you are administering to the respondent.

Enter their answers to the web screener on their behalf.

Thank and end the call once you completed the survey for the caller. Let the respondent know that you will contact them again if they are eligible to participate in the study.

*Notify Patrick (or Rachel) that you have conducted a screener case by phone because we need to mark it in the tracker. REMINDER: Do not include any PII in messages or emails.

If they disagree

Politely end the call.

A-4. Usability Testing Interview Calendar Invitation Template

Interview calendar invitation template

Event title: [CPS] Census Bureau Interview

This calendar invite is for your Census Bureau interview. Thank you again for agreeing to participate!

As a reminder:

Your interview is scheduled for [DAY], [DATE], from [START TIME] to [END TIME].

The interview will be conducted virtually using the video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. The link and information for joining the meeting is below. Please click on the link to connect with your interviewer at your scheduled meeting time.

You will receive a [Round 1: \$50; Round 2: \$60] electronic gift card as a thank you for your participation in the interview.

The interviewer's name is [INTERVIEWER NAME].

Before the interview, please review the consent information linked here:

[LINK]

Your interviewer will review it when you meet, and you can ask any questions you may have.

If you need to reach us before the interview, please reply to this email.

If you need to reach us on the day of your interview, please call me at **xxx-xxx-xxxx**.

Thank you for your participation!

RECRUITER NAME

A-5. Usability Testing Interview Reminder Email Template

Reminder email template – Schedule send to go out the day of the interview

EMAIL VERSION

Subject line: Census Bureau Interview Reminder – DATE at TIME

(RECRUITER: Be sure to CC the interviewer's Census email in this email)

Good [Morning/afternoon], FIRST NAME,

This is a reminder about your interview on DATE at TIME (time zone). Thank you again for agreeing to participate! Below are the details about the appointment. I have also sent you a calendar invite to help reserve the time on your schedule.

Some important notes:

The interview will be conducted using Microsoft Teams and the link is listed here for your reference. Please click on this link to connect with the interviewer at your scheduled time.

- [link]
- I have attached instructions for how to use Teams when joining from a computer or mobile device.

[ONLY INCLUDE THIS BULLET IF RESPONENT IS CALL IN ONLY] The phone number to dial in is xxx-xxx-xxxx. Use the meeting ID XXXXXXXXX to join

Before the interview, please review the consent information linked here:

[ASEC: LINK]

[CPS: LINK]

Your interviewer will review it when you meet and you can ask any questions you may have.

Please respond to this email or give me a call if you have any questions or need to reschedule your interview.

Sincerely,

RECRUITER NAME

xxx-xxx-xxxx

TEXTING VERSION IF NEEDED

Hi [FIRST NAME]. Thank you for agreeing to participate in an interview to discuss your thoughts on the U.S. Census Bureau's household survey questions. As a reminder, your interview with RTI/RSS is scheduled for **[DAY], [DATE], from [START TIME] to [END TIME] with [INTERVIEWER NAME]**. Prior to your interview, we ask that you review and sign this Consent Form [LINK], which includes details about the study. If you need to reach us on the day of your interview, please call us at **xxx-xxx-xxxx**. Thank you!

Appendix B-1: CPS Usability Testing Protocol: Round 1

MATERIALS NEEDED FOR INTERVIEW

- *[Interviewer Protocol Script]*
- *[Laptop and Snagit recording software]*
- *[Letter with User ID, make sure ID is updated for each interview]*
- *[URL link to CPS survey]*
- *[Satisfaction & Debriefing questions – in Qualtrics link]*
- *[XLS spreadsheet for note taking]*
- *[MS Teams]*

URLS (mobile/PC): access.census.gov/cps

Qualtrics URL: [\[Link\]](#)

User ID (from the recruitment tracker):

INTERVIEWER: FOR COMPUTER CASES, PREP THE SURVEY LETTER PDF WITH THE USER ID AND PREP THE EMAIL THAT YOU WILL SEND TO THEM.

Introduction (10 mins)

INTERVIEWER: Verify that the participant is joining the meeting from their assigned device (either computer or smartphone).

- Note that participants CANNOT participate on tablets
- If the participant is not on the correct device, ask them to join on the correct device.
 - If they are unable to join on the correct device, participants can switch devices until the recruitment team tells you that this is no longer flexible.
 - Reschedule the interview as needed for technical issues.
- Verify they have access to their email account on this device.
 - Reschedule the interview as needed if they do not.

*You can use your discretion about whether you should do a tech check (i.e., can they use Teams, access the chat, share their screen, etc.) before you go through the introduction.

INTERVIEWER USABILITY TESTING SCRIPT

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for [CONTRACTOR], a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the Bureau of Labor Statistics. <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE/OBSERVER NAME] who will be [taking notes for us today/observing our session].>

The purpose of today's session is to help us see how our questions work in an online survey. We're interested in how easy or difficult it is to complete and move through the survey.

You may run into difficulties as you work on the survey – and that is what we are interested in learning about today. Any difficulties are the result of the design of the web survey, not your skills or abilities. We are going to use your comments and experiences as well as those of other participants to improve the survey. I did not create the online survey, so don't feel like you have to hold back on your thoughts to be polite to me. We appreciate your help so we can make the online survey work well for everyone.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review and sign this form? [IF NO: Can you please open the link to this form in your email?] I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to video- and audio-record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- Today's interview will take about one hour.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$50 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.

[IF OBSERVER IS PRESENT: I also wanted to let you know that this interview is being observed by someone from the Census Bureau/someone from the Bureau of Labor Statistics/someone else who works on this study. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in learning how our surveys work, and whether we need to change something that does not work.]

Recording

I just need to capture your consent orally. Only those of us connected with the project will review the recording and it will be used solely for research purposes. Your name will not be associated with the recording or any of the other data collected during the session. **Do you give your consent?**

OK, great. So now I am going to turn on the recording device and capture your oral consent on the recording:

[Turn on Snagit or Logitech] Do you consent to participate in the interview today, and for the interview to be recorded and my screen to be recorded?

Think Aloud

- The purpose of our interview today is to evaluate how easy or difficult it is to fill out this survey just as you would if you accessed it online.
- We want to know what works well and what doesn't. This gives us an opportunity to fix any problems.

- I'm going to ask you to share your screen here in a minute so that I can see what you are doing. But I don't know why you are doing it. So, I need your help.
- While you are working, I would like you to share what you are thinking, tell me what you are about to do, and why. Tell me if you are looking for something and what it is, and whether or not you can find it.

Interviewer Demonstration

- Now I would like to share my screen with you to walk through an example.
- **INTERVIEWER: SHARE SCREEN AND PULL UP WIKIPEDIA.COM**
- For this example, my task is that I want to find out the state flower of North Carolina.
- I'm going to think aloud while I do this task so you can understand how this works.
- First in the search bar I'm going to type in "North Carolina" to get to the state page with more information.
- Now I'm on that page and I'm going to start looking for information about the state flower.
- I know this information is usually on the right-hand side of the Wikipedia pages, so I'm focused on scanning over here.
- I don't see it in these first few tables.
- As I scroll, I am seeing other state specific items, so I'm going to stop and read this table more closely.
- As I read through this table, I see the state flower is the flowering dogwood. That's my final answer.
- **INTERVIEWER: STOP SCREEN SHARE**

Final Instructions

- So in this example, I said out loud what I was looking for and where I was looking and whether I could find the information I was looking for.
- This is exactly what I want you to do during the interview.
- I may ask you to share more details throughout our session today by asking "what are you thinking?" And I would like you to continue telling me what you are looking for and what you are thinking.
- You can also help by pointing out anything that is confusing or unclear.
- We want your honest opinions about what you like or dislike about the survey, what worked well for you and what was difficult.
- If you find at any point that you are not sure what to do or are trying to figure something out, please tell me. I may not be able to answer your questions, but it is really helpful to hear this from you. This information will help us understand what we can do to improve the survey and make it work better.

Your first task will be to answer survey questions as they apply to your real life. Then, I will have you answer a brief satisfaction questionnaire about the screens you saw. Lastly, I will ask you some final questions about your experience and will show you some online screens to get your feedback, and that should be it. Do you have any questions for me?

Screen Sharing

I am going to need you to go ahead and share your screen with us. Please open a browser window. If possible, please only share this window today. Make sure you have closed any windows you do not want us to record, as the recording is turned on.

[If they are computer] If you don't mind, would you tell us what type of computer you are using today? [If needed] Is this Microsoft, Apple, etc.?

[If they are mobile] If you don't mind, would you tell us what type of phone you are using today?

[All] Could you tell me what browser you are using today? Is it Chrome, Safari, Firefox, Edge, or something else?

Now – do you see the share icon?

INTERVIEWER: If the participant has issues with doing this, see the instructions below.

There is also a tech help document with screenshots here: [Link to document]

Desktop/Laptop Case: In either the middle of the screen or the top of screen, you will see a square with an arrow. Go ahead and click on that. It will then ask you what screen you want to share. You can either share the full screen or just the web page you are on.

If Mac: (If in browser) At the bottom middle of the screen, you will see a square with an arrow pointing up (if you hover on it, the button will say "Open share tray".) Click this button. It will provide a list of screens to share at the bottom of the page. Click the appropriate one for sharing the CPS instrument. (If they are using the app, the share button will be at the top righthand corner of the screen by the red "leave" button and will resemble what you see on a Windows OS.)

Mobile case:

(iPhone) In the Teams App click the button with the three dots at the bottom next to the red hang-up button. Once you click on it, the display should be expanded. At the top row you will see "Share" with a square and an arrow pointing up. You can click that button. Then select "Share screen" and make sure "Audio" is toggled on next to it. There will be a "Screen Broadcast" box the opens and you can select "Start Broadcast". It will count down and it will be sharing when the red dot is blinking. Now to go to the link you just opened as you can click anywhere outside of the Screen Broadcast box.

If Android: In the Teams App click the button with the three dots at the bottom next to the red hang-up button. Once you click on it, the display should be expanded. At the top row you will see "Share" with a square and an arrow pointing up. You can click that button. You can click that button. Then select "Share screen" and make sure "Audio" is toggled on next to it. There will be a "Screen cast" box the opens and you can select either a "Single App" or "Entire Screen" in the drop down then Press "Start". (If they choose "Single App", then they will need to select the correct browser to show the CPS instrument.)

[If able to see screen] Okay great I can see your screen. Now we can get started with the task.

[If unable to see screen will need to troubleshoot it]

Task 1: CPS Letter Review and Login (5 mins)

Desktop/Laptop cases

Ensure that 'www.' is not used in the URL

Link if the participant needs it (see if they get it from the letter):

access.census.gov/cps

For this survey, you would receive a letter in the mail that would ask you to fill out the survey. I am going to send you this letter in a PDF in an email. Please open the letter and use it to log into the survey just like you would at home. Please remember to think out loud as you review the letter and log into the survey.

Mobile cases

I will now provide you this link and User ID in the chat. Please remember to think out loud as you review the link and log into the survey.

User ID: (retrieve from first page/recruitment tracker)

Observe letter review (computer cases only):

Do not read to participant

Observations of Letter Review (Check Yes/No as appropriate based on the P's statements)			
Letter Review Questions	Yes	No	Not sure
1. Does P comment on unemployment rate?			
2. Does P comment on providing email address?			
3. Does P comment on needing to make note of the email address to use again?			
4. Does P comment on responding by end of week?			
5. Does P comment on sentence about interviewers showing up?			

6. Note any questions P asked/comments P made about this mailing (make sure to include details for anything marked yes above):

7. Other notes:

Observe login process:

[If P asks whether they must use their real email address] **For the purposes of this study, please use your real email address.**

[If P reluctant to provide email address] **The email address will not be shared with anyone else.**

Observations of Login Process (Check Yes/No as appropriate based on the P's statements/observations)			
Login Process Questions	Yes	No	Not sure
8. [if mobile] Did P scroll on any of the log in screens? If so, which screen?			

Observations of Login Process (Check Yes/No as appropriate based on the P's statements/observations)			
<i>Login Process Questions</i>	Yes	No	Not sure
9. Did P comment on the image of the letter shown on the login screen?			
10. Did P have concerns about providing their email address?			
11. Verification Code Screen: Did they know where to go next after they provided their email address?			
12. Did P confuse the verification code and the User ID? (e.g., Thought the User ID was the verification code)			
13. Did P report any burden or annoyance with needing to access their email for the verification code?			
14. Does P mention using multiple devices to log in the survey (e.g. Says something like "let me check my email on my phone really quick.")			
15. Did they go back to their letter to get the User ID without asking for help?			
16. Did P read the instructions or comment on the instructions underneath the "submit" button (e.g. times out after 15 mins. Do not use browser back/forward buttons. Use the most updated versions of Chrome, Firefox, etc.)			
17. Did they comment on the FAQs or the English button on the upper-righthand corner?			

18. Email the respondent uses for logging into the survey:

19. Note any questions P asked/comments P made about the login process (make sure to include details for anything marked yes above):

20. Other notes:

Task 2: CPS Instrument

Okay, now let's turn back to the survey. Please answer these questions as you would if you had gone online and were answering it in your home. Please remember to talk me through what you are thinking. You will see a pretend address in the instrument. Please say "Yes" to these questions with the pretend addresses.

[TA: Please encourage P to think aloud especially if they seem to encounter any issues.]

Probes to use in study:

- Keep talking
- Um-hum?
- What are you thinking?

[TA: Note where user pauses and if they seem to stumble over any instructions or any of the questions.]

Completion of CPS (15 minutes):

[For everyone]: Please add yourself and up to two other household members. Please add the household members who are 15 years and older first. [TA: Stop the participant if they try adding a fourth household member].

Question/Page	Yes	No	Observation Notes
Roster adding: 55. Were they able to add the household members (up to 3)?			
56. Did they need to remove any household members? Were they able to do so?			
57. Did they try to make any additional updates on the roster screen by backing up to it?			
Roster confirmation (screen: "Please review all the people we have listed living or staying here. When you are finished making updates, press the Continue button."): 58. Did P have any issues on this screen?			
59. Did they know what to do next?			

Question/Page	Yes	No	Observation Notes
60. Did they try to add or remove any people in the household?			
61. Date of birth questions – did P have any issues reporting the date or age of people in the household?			
Labels 62. Did P try to click one of the labels like “hours” or “hours per week”? 			
63. Did P understand the meaning of the labels?			
64. When calculating actual hours, did the P back up to the time they reported taking off/losing work or the overtime hours they reported?			
65. Write down their reactions to questions with many/long response options (e.g., looking for work, why they didn’t look for work)			
66. Other usability issues: • Do they receive error messages? (e.g., which screens) • Do they use the back button? (e.g., which screens) • Struggle with pronouns (he/she) • Comment on response options being in question wording			
67. Disability –Did P report ‘Yes’ for any of the disability questions? Were they able to select who in the household had a disability?			
68. Nativity Drop Down – Did P have any issues finding the correct country?			

Using this table to document the pathways taken in the instrument for this interview. You can use this to select the correct follow-ups in the debriefing instrument. Do not read to the participant. For those who are self-employed, please be sure to also select “Single Job” or “Multiple Job” as appropriate to see the questions about probing usual hours, actual hours.

Household member (Name used)	Single Job (has one job only)	Multiple Jobs	Self-employed	Not working

<i>Household member (Name used)</i>	<i>Single Job (has one job only)</i>	<i>Multiple Jobs</i>	<i>Self-employed</i>	<i>Not working</i>

Use this table for any household members who are not working. This will help guide which debriefing questions to ask during the "not working" section.

Debriefing Questions by Household Member	<i>Household member 1</i>	<i>Household member 2</i>	<i>Household member 3</i>
Absent from work (Received: "what is the main reason you were absent from work LAST WEEK")			
Layoff (Received: "As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been on layoff?")			
Looking for Work (Received: "What are all the things you have done to find work during the last 4 week?")			
Worked in last year (Received: "When did you last work?")			
Looking for work: (Received: "As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?")			

[TA: Please move the participant along during the debriefing section of the instrument after the "Thank you for participating in the Current Population Survey" screen. If you are expecting to run short on time, the participant does not need to answer these questions – you can have them hit next until the submission screen:]

- *Did filling out the Current Population survey online increase your trust in the US Census Bureau?*
- *What did you like about completing the survey online?*
- *What do we need to do to improve the online survey?*

Satisfaction Questionnaire (2 minutes):

After they click the final Submit button to the end of the survey

Okay I am now going to share my screen with you. I will share a survey with you and I would like you to answer some questions on your experience with the survey you just completed. Please say aloud the answers for each question to me and I will fill them in.

[TA: Open the Qualtrics questionnaire: [Link] Share your screen with the participant.]

Task 3: Debriefing Probes (25 minutes):

After completing the satisfaction questions

Thank you very much for answering those questions. Now I have some questions about the letter and log in process you did earlier.

[TA: Switch away from Qualtrics instrument for now as we will be returning to the CPS letter/log-in. DO NOT CLOSE THE QUALTRICS WINDOW.]

Debriefing on the Letter and Login Process (10 minutes):

Letter questions [COMPUTER CASES ONLY; MOBILE GO TO "BOTH COMPUTER AND MOBILE" SECTION]

[TA: Open up the CPS Usability letter used in testing and share.]

Before you started the survey, you reviewed a letter that invites people like yourself to complete a survey.

21. What did you think of this letter?

22. *[If needed]* What do you think was the purpose of this letter in your words?

23. Was there anything you thought was confusing in the letter?

24. *[If P had issues logging in or identified something confusing in the letter to them]* What, if anything, would you change to make this letter easier for you to find what you needed to do?

33. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

SCREEN2: VERIFICATION CODE 1

United States Census Bureau

Current Population Survey

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

An email has been sent with your one-time verification code. Enter that code below.

Verification code

Verify

[Resend email](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/notices/privacy/privacy-policy.html>. Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

United States Census Bureau

Your Census Bureau Verification Code

Here is your one-time Census Bureau Verification Code:

XXXX-XXXX

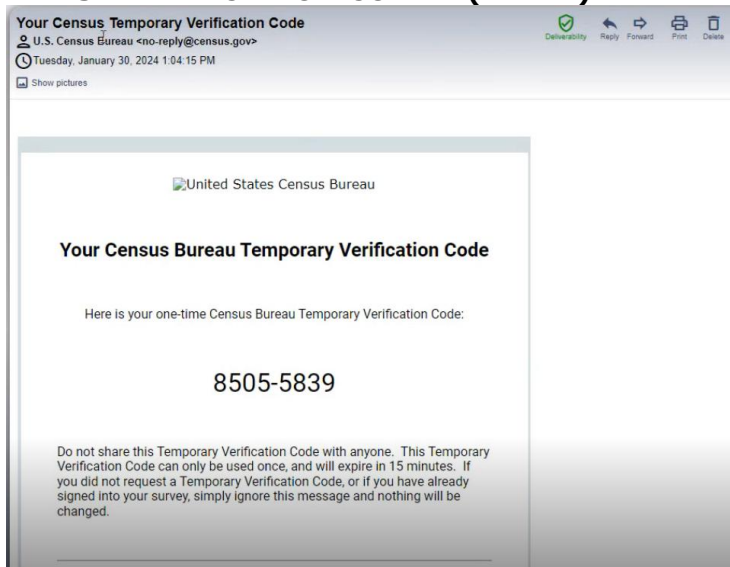
Do not share this code with anyone. This code can only be used once, and will expire in 15 minutes. If you did not request a verification code, or if you have already signed into your survey, simply ignore this message and nothing will be changed.

This message was sent to you because someone attempted to access a Census Bureau survey with your email address. This email notification is generated by a computer; please DO NOT REPLY.

About the Census Bureau

34. What did you think about this screen?
35. Was it clear what you had to do for this screen?
36. [If needed] What did you find easy about this? Tell me more about that.
37. [If needed] What did you find difficult about this? Tell me more about that.
38. [If commented on feature in log in process that they struggled with or did not like] I noticed that you commented on [insert feature] during the log in process. Can you tell me more what you were thinking?
39. [If struggled finding verification code] I noticed it took you a while to find the verification code. Was there anything that may have made it easier to find the verification code?
40. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

SCREEN3: VERIFICATION CODE 2 (EMAIL)



41. What did you think about this screen?
42. Was it clear what you had to do for this screen?
43. [If needed] What did you find easy about this? Tell me more about that.
44. [If needed] What did you find difficult about this? Tell me more about that.
45. [If commented on feature in log in process that they struggled with or did not like] I noticed that you commented on [insert feature] during the log in process. Can you tell me more what you were thinking?
46. [If struggled finding verification code] I noticed it took you a while to find the verification code. Was there anything that may have made it easier to find the verification code?
47. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

SCREEN4: USER ID

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

It looks like you are a first time user. Please enter the 12-digit User ID that can be found in the survey invitation you were sent.

Log in

[Not a first time user? Try another email.](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning
 You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/privacy/privacy-notice.html>. Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

Census ID


 U.S. Census Bureau
 Washington, DC 20540-0001
 OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR

A Message from the Director of the U.S. Census Bureau:

Dear Resident,

Your address has been selected to participate in the **Current Population Survey**. This monthly survey is the source of the Nation's unemployment rate that you may hear about in the news. The U.S. Census Bureau conducts this survey in partnership with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

We are inviting you to respond to the Current Population Survey online.

Log into the website below using your email address and your User ID. Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.

Respond this week at: access.census.gov/ps

User ID: XXXXXXXXXXXX

Respond online by the end of this week. After that, a Census Bureau interviewer will contact you to complete the survey.

The success of this survey depends on your participation. We cannot substitute another address for yours. Your address is part of a scientifically selected sample of addresses chosen throughout the country. Your answers represent hundreds of other households like yours.

Answers to frequently asked questions are on the back of this letter. If you have other questions, please visit census.gov/ps or call 1-800-424-6974, #53939.

Thank you in advance for participating in this important survey.

48. What did you think about this screen?

49. Was it clear what you had to do for this screen?

50. [If needed] What did you find easy about this? Tell me more about that.

51. [If needed] What did you find difficult about this? Tell me more about that.

52. [If commented on feature in log in process that they struggled with or did not like] I noticed that you commented on [insert feature] during the log in process. Can you tell me more what you were thinking?

53. [If struggled finding User ID] I noticed it took you a while to find the User ID. Was there anything that may have made it easier to find the User ID?

54. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

Debriefing on the CPS instrument (15 minutes):

Return to the Qualtrics instrument. You should now be on a screen that will allow you to select the different pathing through the instrument (e.g. full-time/part-time, looking for work, not in the labor force, etc.). Please select the applicable fields based on the table above.

Note to TA: If there is both a multiple job worker AND single job worker in the household, only select multiple job worker. This is so we don't ask the same probes again in single job worker.

If you have only a self-employed person in the household, you will want to also select either single job or multiple job pathway (dependent upon whether this person has more than one job) to probe on usual hours/actual hours series.

Note, you don't have to answer on these screens I am showing you as I am just asking about your thoughts. This will show fictional names in the instrument.

Overall survey

69. Tell me what you thought about answering this survey on your [computer/mobile phone].

70. Comparing this survey to other surveys you have taken on your [computer/mobile phone], did any part of the survey look or behave in an unexpected way?

71. [If needed] What did you like about completing this survey on your [computer/mobile phone]? What did you dislike about completing this survey on your [computer/mobile phone]?

72. [If needed] Did you find this survey easy or difficult to complete? Can you tell me more about that? What did you find easy? What did you find difficult?

Proceed to the Roster Questions

Roster Questions

Display the screen to add people on the roster.

What are the names of all persons living or staying here? Start with the name of the person, or one of the persons, who owns or rents this home.

Enter one person on each line. Enter names until you have listed everyone who lives or stays here, then click next.

First name

Last name



Remove

+ Add another person

Back

Next

73. What did you think of the process of adding the people to your household on the [computer/phone]?

74. Was it clear or not clear how to add them?

75. [If needed] Can you tell me more about that?

Display the screen to confirm the roster.

Please review all of the people we have listed living or staying here. When you are finished making updates, press the Continue button.

Joe Poe

 Remove

Liz Poe

 Remove

+ Add another person

Continue

76. After you finished listing people in the household, you then saw the household members you listed for review. Was it clear what to do next when you saw this screen? [\[If needed\]](#) Can you tell me more about that?

77. [\[If did not add or remove\]](#) If you needed to add or remove someone from the household, was it clear what you would have to do next?

78. [\[If added or removed\]](#) What did you think about this process adding or removing someone from the household?

79. [\[If needed\]](#) *Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or participant using the back button.*

80. [\[If used back button\]](#) I noticed you used the back button when you were listing who was in your household. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

Proceed to the Demographic Questions

Demographic Questions*Display Date of Birth question***What is Joe Poe's date of birth?****Please fill Joe Poe's birth Month, Day and Year.** [Help](#)

Month	Day	Year
-Select- ▾	-Select- ▾	-Select- ▾

Verify or enter correct age as of May 23, 2024. *For babies less than 1 year old, do not enter the age in months. Enter 0 as the age.*

Age

	years
----------------------	-------

For each household member, you answered their month, day, and year by selecting from the drop down.

81. What did you think about this process in selecting the options?

82. [\[If needed\]](#) Do you think there would be an easier way to report [your/everyone's] date of birth?

83. [\[if mobile\]](#) What did you think of the spin wheels used to select month, day, and year?

If anyone in household has multiple jobs, proceed to "multiple jobs (hours)" section.

Else, if any one in household has a single job, proceed to "single job (hours)" section.

Else, proceed to "not working" section.

Multiple jobs (hours)

Display example of usual hours screen with main job and other job

How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your main job? By main job we mean the one at which you usually work the most hours.

	Hours per week
--	----------------

How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your other job?

	Hours per week
--	----------------

You answered a couple of questions about the usual hours your work at your main and other job(s).

84. What did you think about having these questions on the same screens?

85. Would you have preferred to focus on sharing your usual hours for one job and then report on the other job later or did you like reporting them at the same time on the same screen?

86. Did you notice the wording next to where you typed the numbers in: "hours per week"?

If yes: What did you think of this wording?

Display questions with lose or takeoff, overtime, and actual hours

Next are some questions about the exact number of hours you worked LAST WEEK.

LAST WEEK, did you lose or take off any hours from your MAIN job, for ANY reason such as illness, lack of work, vacation, or holiday?

☒ Yes

☐ No

LAST WEEK, did you work any overtime or extra hours at your MAIN job that you do not usually work?

☒ Yes

☐ No

So, for LAST WEEK, how many hours did you ACTUALLY work at your MAIN job?

	Hours
--	-------

LAST WEEK, how many hours did you ACTUALLY work at your other job?

	Hours
--	-------

[If they took time off/reported overtime]: Previously you saw these screens that ask you about any hours you did not work last week due to illness, lack of work, vacations or holidays and overtime you worked last week. You were then asked the final question to report your actual hours worked for last week.

87. How did you come up with your answer to how many hours you worked at your main job last week?

88. Did you account for the time you took off/your overtime hours when you reported the actual hours for your main job?

89. Was it easy or difficult for you to account for time you took off or worked overtime as part of your calculation for the actual hours you worked at your main job last week? [If difficult]: What would have made this easier for you?

90. [If used back button] I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

91. What did you think about reporting the actual hours you worked for your main job and for your other job(s) on the same screen?

[If they did not take time off and did not report overtime]: Previously you saw these screens that asked whether you had any hours you did not work last week and about

whether you worked overtime. You said “no” to each of these. You were then asked to report the actual hours you worked last week for your main and other job(s).

92. What did you think about reporting the actual hours you worked for your main job and for your other job(s) on the same screen?

93. [If used back button] I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

*If anyone is not working, proceed to “not working” section.
Else, if anyone is self-employed, proceed to “self-employed” section.
Otherwise, proceed to disability section.*

TA: DO NOT ADMINISTER THIS SECTION IF YOU HAVE ALREADY ASKED ABOUT USUAL HOURS/ACTUAL HOURS AS PART OF A MULTIPLE JOB PATHWAY.

Single job (hours)

Display usual hours

How many hours per week do you USUALLY work at your job?

	Hours per week
--	----------------

You answered a series of questions about the time you/household member usually work(s) per week.

94. Do you have any comments on this screen?

95. Did you notice the wording next to where you typed the numbers in: "hours per week"?

If yes: What did you think of this wording?

Display lose time, overtime and actual hours on same screen

Next are some questions about the exact number of hours you worked LAST WEEK.

LAST WEEK, did you lose or take off any hours from work, for ANY reason such as illness, lack of work, vacation, or holiday?

☒ Yes

☐ No

LAST WEEK, did you work any overtime or extra hours that you do not usually work?

☐ Yes

☒ No

So, for LAST WEEK, how many hours did you ACTUALLY work at your job?

	Hours
--	-------

[If they took time off/reported overtime]: Previously you saw these screens that ask you about any hours you did not work last week due to illness, lack of work, vacations or

holidays and overtime you worked last week. You were then asked the final question to report your actual hours worked for last week.

96. How did you come up with your answer to how many hours you worked at your main job last week?

97. Did you account for the time you took off/your overtime hours when you reported the actual hours for your main job?

98. Was it easy or difficult for you to account for time you took off or worked overtime as part of your calculation for the actual hours you worked at your main job last week? **If difficult:** What would have made this easier for you?

99. **[If used back button]** I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

[If they did not take time off/reported overtime]: Previously you saw these screens that asked whether you had any hours you did not work last week and about whether you worked overtime. You said “no” to each of these. You were then asked to report the actual hours you worked last week for your job.

100. What did you think about the question that asked you to report the actual hours you worked for your job? **[If needed]** Can you tell me more about that?

101. **[If used back button]** I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If any one in household is not working, proceed to “not working” section.

Else, if anyone is self-employed, proceed to “self-employed” section.

Otherwise, proceed to disability section.

Not Working

Note, you will need to consult the "not working" table above to guide which questions to administer in probing. Due to complexity of programming, the Qualtrics instrument is showing all of the questions in this section if "not working" is selected in the earlier interviewer check.

What was the main reason you were absent from work LAST WEEK?

- ☐ On layoff or furlough
- ☐ Business was slow
- ☐ Accepted a job offer and waiting to start
- ☐ Vacation or personal time off
- ☐ Sick, injured, or had other medical reason, including being pregnant
- ☐ Child care problems
- ☐ Caring for family or personal obligation
- ☐ Maternity/paternity leave
- ☐ Labor dispute
- ☐ Weather conditions
- ☐ School or training
- ☐ Civic/military duty
- ☐ Does not work in the business
- ☐ Other (specify)

Specify:

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

102. *[Administer as time permits]* Can you tell me what you were thinking when you answered this question?

103. *[Administer as time permits]* Were you able to select the main reason from the list provided?

104. *[Administer as time permits]* Did you have any trouble selecting only one answer for this question?

105. *[if needed/as time permits] Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially the participant using the back button.*

106. *[If used back button/as time permits]* I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If participant saw "how long on layoff" screen, ask below probes and display "how long on layoff" image.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been on layoff?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

-Select-

▼

Back

Next

Please enter a number in the box below.

Please select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been on layoff?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

-Select-

▼

Back

Next

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

107. Can you tell me what you were thinking when you answered this question?

108. [If needed] As you may recall, you had to write in a number and select a timeframe from the buttons. Can you me more what you were thinking when doing this?

109. [if needed] *Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or participant using the back button.*

110. [If error message] I noticed the error message came up when you were answering this. What did you think about this? [If needed] Did you find this error message helpful?

111. [If used back button] I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If participant saw "looking for work" screen, ask below probes and display "looking for work" image

What are all the things you have done to find work during the last 4 weeks?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Interviewed for a job
- ☐ Applied for a job or answered a job ad
- ☐ Checked a union/professional register
- ☐ Posted a resume or an ad/listing
- ☐ Contacted employment agency/school employment center
- ☐ Asked friends, relatives, network about job leads
- ☐ Looked at job ads
- ☐ Participated in a job training course or other activity to improve job skills
- ☐ Worked on resume
- ☐ Other (specify)
- ☐ Nothing

Back

Next

[Administer as time permits] I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

112. *[Administer as time permits]* Can you tell me more about what you were thinking as you answered this?

113. *[Administer as time permits]* Were you able to find the option or see all the options that best fit your or the household member's situation?

If participant saw "when did you last work" question, ask below probe and display "when did you last work" image

When did you last work?

Month

Year

-Select- ▼		▼
------------	--	---

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

114. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered this question.

115. *[If needed]* As you may recall, you had to select both a month and year from a list of options. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

116. *[if needed]* *Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or participant using the back button.*

117. *[If error message]* I noticed the error message came up when you were answering this. What did you think about this? *[If needed]* What did you think you should do to proceed?

118. *[If used back button]* I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If saw "how long had you been looking for work" screen, ask below probes and display "how long had you been looking for work" image

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years from the dropdown.

 -Select- ▾

Back

Next

Please enter a number in the box below.

Please select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years from the dropdown.

 -Select- ▾

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

119. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered this question.

120. *[If needed]* As you may recall, you had to select a time frame (weeks, months, years) and enter a number. Can you me more what you were thinking when doing this?

121. Did you have any difficulty entering the number and selecting the appropriate time frame?

122. *[If needed]* Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or participant using the back button.

123. *[If error message]* I noticed the error message came up when you were answering this question. What did you think about this? *[If needed]* What did you think you should do to proceed?

If anyone in the household is self-employed, proceed to "self-employed" section. Otherwise, proceed to disability section.

Self-employed

Display "paid employees" image

Excluding all owners, how many paid employees does your business usually have?

	Paid employees
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[Administer as time permits] You answered a question about how many paid employees your business has.

124. *[Administer as time permits]* Can you tell me what you were thinking as you answered this question?

125. *[Administer as time permits]* What did you think of the wording next to the write-in box?

Proceed to disability section.

[TA: Administer the disability section as time permits.]

Disability

Display following "difficulty" images.

Is anyone deaf or does anyone have serious difficulty hearing?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Is anyone blind or does anyone have serious difficulty seeing, even when wearing glasses?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does anyone have serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Does anyone have serious difficulty walking or climbing stairs?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Does anyone have difficulty dressing or bathing?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does anyone have difficulty doing errands alone such as visiting a doctor's office or shopping?

☐ Yes

☒ No

I am showing you the questions that you answered for your household

126. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered these questions.

127. *[If needed] Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially participant using the back button.*

128. [If used back button] I noticed you used the back button when answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If participant answered 'Yes' to any of the difficulty questions, show the "Select all that apply" question.

Who is that?

Select all that apply.

☐ Joe Poe

I am showing you the follow-up question when you answered 'Yes' to [insert disability questions they said 'Yes' to]

129. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered [this question/these questions]

130. Was it clear what you had to do when answering this question?

131. [If needed] *Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially participant using the back button.*

132. [If used back button] I noticed you used the back button when answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

Proceed to nativity section.

Nativity

Display "Nativity" image

In what country were you born?

Country

In what country were you born?

Country

UNITED STATES
ABU DHABI
ADEN
AFGHANISTAN
AFRICA
ALBANIA

You answered a series of questions about which country members of your household and their parents were born in.

133. What did you think about this process in selecting the country?

134. [If someone selected born outside of USA for any household member] For [insert household member and relationship if needed], you selected [insert country name] in the list? Can you tell me more about what you were thinking.

135. [If needed] Do you think there would be an easier way to report the birth of country?

136. [If mobile] What did you think of the spin wheels used to select the birth of country?

*Make sure that the participant clicks **Next** to **submit** their Qualtrics responses.*

Proceed to Final Debriefing

Final Debriefing (2 minutes)

137. Were there any other parts of the survey that were confusing or difficult?

138. Do you have any additional thoughts on the screens we looked at today that you would like to share?

139. Is there anything else you'd like to mention that we haven't talked about?

Let me turn to the team and see if they have any questions...

Finishing up session (1 minute)

TA: End Recording. Also make sure you submit the Qualtrics satisfaction questionnaire.

Okay, that's it for today. Thanks so much for all your answers. Now I will just stop the recording and then I will confirm with you the email you would like us to send your \$50 digital gift card.

INTERVIEWER: Confirm email after recording has stopped.

NOTE THE TIME THAT THE INTERVIEW HAS ENDED.

ROUND 2 SCHEDULING INSTRUCTIONS (see interviewer instructions document for the full instructions):

Round 2 dates are 10/1-11/18

- Try to do Round 2 scheduling while still on the call with the participant, but follow-up with them as needed.
- Look at the recruitment tracker to see if we are scheduling them for Round 2 or keeping them as a backup.
- For those that are marked schedule:
 - We would like to interview you again in a few months to test more of this survey. I would like to schedule a date and time for the next interview in [insert month/week].
 - Schedule with them as needed.
 - Please confirm email and phone number for them.
 - Please ask how they would like to receive monthly reminders (phone, text, email).
- For those that are marked backup:
 - We would like to interview some people again in a few months to test more of this survey. If there is an opening for the next round, we will potentially reach out to you around [insert month].
- If the participant refuses to participate in Round 2, mark them as a refusal in the tracker.
- If the participant asks—the incentive for Round 2 will be \$60 but they will ONLY receive this if they participate in an interview.

Appendix B-2: CPS Usability Testing Protocol: Round 2

MATERIALS NEEDED FOR INTERVIEW

- [Interviewer Protocol Script]
- [Laptop and Snagit recording software]
- [Email address from Round 1]
- [Primary P working recruitment criteria from Round 1]
- [XLS spreadsheet for note taking]
- [MS Teams]

URLS (mobile/PC): access.census.gov/cps

Qualtrics URL: [Link]

Email address (from the recruitment tracker):

Round 1 respondent name and date of birth:

Primary P recruitment criteria from Round 1 (Circle one of the following): Multiple jobs/Single job/Not Working

Please skim summary from Round 1 for this household to see if anything interesting happened in the interview (e.g., P struggled with work questions, P had a unique work scenario, P struggled answering nativity question, etc.)

Please have the email address the person used to log in during their first interview in case they need it.

Introduction (15 mins)

- Please confirm the participant's name and date of birth and that it matches who we talked to in Round 1 (to avoid risk of disclosure)

If participant's name and date of birth do not match: Unfortunately, these do not match our records. Because of this, we will have to end the interview due to privacy reasons. I am going to talk to my supervisor about this and we will reach out if we want to reschedule. INTERVIEWER: Verify that the participant is joining the meeting from their assigned device (either computer or smartphone).

- **Note that participants CANNOT participate on tablets**
- If the participant is not on the correct device, ask them to join on the correct device.
 - If they are unable to join on the correct device, participants can switch devices until the recruitment team tells you that this is no longer flexible.
 - Reschedule the interview as needed for technical issues.
- Verify they have access to their email account on this device.
 - Reschedule the interview as needed if they do not.

*You can use your discretion about whether you should do a tech check (i.e., can they use Teams, access the chat, share their screen, etc.) before you go through the introduction.

INTERVIEWER USABILITY TESTING SCRIPT

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for [CONTRACTOR], a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the Bureau of Labor Statistics. <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE/OBSERVER NAME] who will be [taking notes for us today/observing our session].>

Note, this is the second of the two research sessions you will participate with us.

The purpose of today's session is to help us see how our questions work in an online survey. These questions will be similar to the ones you answered last time, but you don't need to try to remember what you told us last time. We're interested in how easy or difficult it is to complete and move through the survey. We are going to use your comments and experiences as well as those of other participants to improve the survey.

We do want to note that while we have made some changes to the web survey since you last spoke to us, some of these difficulties with the survey may still be present. Also, we may ask some similar questions about your opinions on the questions and the design of the survey as last time so we apologize in advance if it seems repetitive.

Before we start, you may recall that you signed a consent form before your first interview a few months ago. I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to video- and audio-record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- This study is the second interview. This interview will take about one hour.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$60 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.

[IF OBSERVER IS PRESENT: I also wanted to let you know that this interview is being observed by someone from the Census Bureau/someone from the Bureau of Labor Statistics/someone else who works on this study. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in learning how our surveys work, and whether we need to change something that does not work.]

Recording

I just need to capture your consent orally. Only those of us connected with the project will review the recording and it will be used solely for research purposes. Your name will not be associated with the recording or any of the other data collected during the session. **Do you give your consent?**

OK, great. So now I am going to turn on the recording device and capture your oral consent on the recording:

[Turn on Snagit or Logitech] Do you consent to participate in the interview today, and for the interview to be recorded and my screen to be recorded?

Think Aloud

- The purpose of our interview today is to evaluate how easy or difficult it is to fill out this survey just as you would if you accessed it online.
- We want to know what works well and what doesn't. This gives us an opportunity to fix any problems.
- I'm going to ask you to share your screen here in a minute so that I can see what you are doing. But I don't know why you are doing it. So, I need your help.
- While you are working, I would like you to share what you are thinking, tell me what you are about to do, and why. Tell me if you are looking for something and what it is, and whether or not you can find it.

Final Instructions

- I may ask you to share more details throughout our session today by asking "what are you thinking?" And I would like you to continue telling me what you are looking for and what you are thinking.
- You can also help by pointing out anything that is confusing or unclear.
- We want your honest opinions about what you like or dislike about the survey, what worked well for you and what was difficult.
- If you find at any point that you are not sure what to do or are trying to figure something out, please tell me. I may not be able to answer your questions, but it is really helpful to hear this from you. This information will help us understand what we can do to improve the survey and make it work better.

Your first task will be to answer survey questions as they apply to your real life. Then, I will ask you some final questions about your experience and will show you some online screens to get your feedback. Do you have any questions for me?

Screen Sharing

I am going to need you to go ahead and share your screen with us. Make sure you have closed any windows you do not want us to record, as the recording is turned on.

- [If they are computer] If you don't mind, would you tell us what type of computer you are using today? [If needed] Is this Microsoft, Apple, etc.?
- [If they are mobile] If you don't mind, would you tell us what type of phone you are using today?
- [All] Could you tell me what browser you are using today? Is it Chrome, Safari, Firefox, Edge, or something else?

Now – do you see the share icon?

INTERVIEWER: If the participant has issues with doing this, see the instructions below.

There is also a tech help document with screenshots here: [Link]

Desktop/Laptop Case: In either the middle of the screen or the top of screen, you will see a square with an arrow. Go ahead and click on that. It will then ask you what screen you want to share. You can either share the full screen or just the web page you are on.

If Mac: (If in browser) At the bottom middle of the screen, you will see a square with an arrow pointing up (if you hover on it, the button will say "Open share tray".) Click this button. It will provide a list of screens to share at the bottom of the page. Click the appropriate one for sharing the CPS instrument. (If they are using the app, the share button will be at the top righthand corner of the screen by the red "leave" button and will resemble what you see on a Windows OS.)

Mobile case:

If iPhone: In the Teams App click the button with the three dots at the bottom next to the red hang-up button. Once you click on it, the display should be expanded. At the top row you will see "Share" with a square and an arrow pointing up. You can click that button. Then select "Share screen" and make sure "Audio" is toggled on next to it. There will be a "Screen Broadcast" box the opens and you can select "Start Broadcast". It will count down and it will be sharing when the red dot is blinking. Now to go to the link you just opened as you can click anywhere outside of the Screen Broadcast box.

If Android: In the Teams App click the button with the three dots at the bottom next to the red hang-up button. Once you click on it, the display should be expanded. At the top row you will see "Share" with a square and an arrow pointing up. You can click that button. You can click that button. Then select "Share screen" and make sure "Audio" is toggled on next to it. There will be a "Screen cast" box the opens and you can select either a "Single App" or "Entire Screen" in the drop down then Press "Start". (If they choose "Single App", then they will need to select the correct browser to show the CPS instrument.)

[If able to see screen] Okay great I can see your screen. Now we can get started with the task.

[If unable to see screen will need to troubleshoot it]

Task 1: CPS Login (5 mins)

Give the participant the web address and instruct them to log in to the survey. Ensure that 'www.' is not used in the URL

Link (can be put in the chat or read aloud): access.census.gov/cps

Please remember to think out loud as you log into the survey.

Observe login process:

- *[If P is unsure what to type for email address or asks whether they need to use the same email address they provided last time] What would you do if I were not here?*
- *If they start typing the wrong email address, we can interrupt them and provide them the email address from Round 1.*
 - *Thank you for that feedback. Please type in this email address you provided us last time, [read email address].*
- *If they no longer have access to the email they used in Round 1, please end the interview and pay them an incentive. Reach out to Rachel/Alisu/Leah as we will need to recruit a replacement.*

Email address: (retrieve from recruitment tracker)

Observations of Login Process (Check Yes/No as appropriate based on the P's statements/observations)			
<i>Login Process Questions</i>	Yes	No	Not sure
1. <i>[if mobile] Did P scroll on any of the log in screens? If so, which screen?</i>			
2. <i>Did they express that they were unsure which email address they used?</i>			
3. <i>Did they try to type in a different email address than from Round 1?</i>			
4. <i>Verification Code Screen: Did they know they have to check their email after they provided their email address?</i>			
5. <i>Did P report any burden or annoyance with needing to access their email for the verification code?</i>			
6. <i>Does P mention using multiple devices to log in the survey (e.g. Says something like "let me check my email on my phone really quick.")</i>			

7. Note any questions P asked/comments P made about the login process (make sure to include details for anything marked yes above):

8. Other notes:

Task 2: CPS Instrument (15 minutes)

Please answer these questions as you would if you had gone online and were answering it without me. Please remember to talk me through what you are thinking. You will see a pretend street address in the instrument. Please say “Yes” to these questions with the pretend address.

[TA: There is a question that says “Are you [respondent’s name]”. Please ensure that this is the person you are interviewing or at least someone in the household. If it is not you will need to end the interview to prevent any disclosure risks.]

[TA: Please encourage P to think aloud especially if they seem to encounter any issues.]

Probes to use in study:

- Keep talking
- Um-hum?
- What are you thinking?

[TA: Note where user pauses and if they seem to stumble over any instructions or any of the questions.]

Household Roster

Participant gets to roster screen. Please let me know when you are finished with this screen before clicking next.

Let participant add or remove someone if they want to. We will want the participant to do at least one ‘add’ and one ‘remove’ task.

A. If someone has a person under 15 in their household, read the text below to remove the person. If nobody is under 15, go to B below.

For this study, I would like you to please remove NAME. Please show me what you would do to remove this person.

9. Did they react to the pop-up asking “Are you sure you want to remove this person?” If so, note what happened:

10. *[When they get to the reason for removing question]* Please read this question. We know this question does not fit your current situation. Please let us know if you have any comments about this question wording you see on screen. This can either be comments whether the question wording makes sense or if there is anything confusing.

Observation notes:

[Have them select “Person moved out” and continue with B below]

B. For this study, I would now like you to please add a person named John Doe to your household. Please show me what you would do. To help the participant come up with the fictitious person, they can choose the birthday to be 1/1/2000, White, non-Hispanic, high school graduate.

Observation notes:

11. Were they able to add people to this screen?

12. Note any issues the participant had:

Once John Doe is added. Okay, now I would like to please remove John Doe. Please show me what you would do.

Observation notes:

13. Were they able to remove people from this screen?

14. Note any issues the participant had:

15. Did they react to the pop-up asking "Are you sure you want to remove this person?" If so, note what happened:

If this is the first time they are doing the remove task, go to #16 below to read the task once they navigate past the pop-up modal. If they already did this task in A, you can just have them select "Person moved out" and return to the roster dashboard.

16. *[When they get to the reason for removing question]* Please read this question. We know this question does not fit your current situation. Please let us know if you have any comments about this question wording you see on screen. This can either be comments whether the question wording makes sense or if there is anything confusing.

Observation notes:

[Have them select "Person moved out"]

OTHER OBSERVATIONS ABOUT THE HOUSEHOLD ROSTER:

17. Note any other issues the participant had on the roster dashboard ("Previously it was reported that the following people were living or staying at this address...."):

18. [Only if participant saw the expanded roster review screen, which lists each person and each of their demographic information]: What was the participant's reaction to this screen? Did they report any issues?

19. [Only if participant clicked "Edit" button and saw a demographic question with "Return to Review" button]: What did participants think of the "Return to Review" button? Did they click this button or try to move through the survey clicking "Next"?

20. [Only if participant saw the expanded roster review screen] Did they know how to return to the roster dashboard and continue with the survey?

Education

Education	Yes	No	Observation Notes
21. How did P react to answering the education questions? Was there any concern or confusion about the prefilled answer?			
22. Did they comment on the instruction placed on the first question on highest level of education? ("Occasionally, we re-ask certain questions in case anything has changed. Please confirm or update the following schooling or certificate information for Joe Poe.")			
23. Did they receive an error message indicating they had selected a lower grade than previously reported? If so, how did they react?			

Labor Force

Using this table to document the pathways taken in the instrument for this interview. You can use this to select the correct follow-ups in the debriefing instrument. Do not read to the P. For those who are self-employed, please be sure to also select "Single Job" or "Multiple Job" as appropriate to see the questions about probing usual hours, actual hours.

Household member (Name used)	Single Job (has one job only)	Multiple Jobs	Self-employed	Not working

Use this table for any household members who are not working. This will help guide which debriefing questions to ask during the "not working" section.

Debriefing Questions by Household Member	Household member 1	Household member 2	Household member 3
Absent from work (Received: "what is the main reason you were absent from work LAST WEEK")			
Layoff (Received: "As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been on layoff?")			
Looking for Work (Received: "What are all the things you have done to find work during the last 4 week?")			
Worked in last year (Received: "When did you last work?")			
Looking for work (Received: "As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?")			

Labor Force	Yes	No	Observation Notes
Working hours 24. Did the P have any problems reporting any of the following hours: • Usual • Time took off/Lost • Actual • Overtime			
Questions where they had to write number and select time period (e.g., weeks, months) in drop down 25. Did P understand how to answer? Which order did they answer in?			

Labor Force	Yes	No	Observation Notes
Industry and Occupation <i>Note to interviewers, these I & O questions we would like detailed notes for so please make sure to mention the individual questions they reacted to or possibly overlooked.</i> IO1DP1: Last month, it was reported that NAME worked for ORGANIZATION. Does [he/she] still work for ORGANIZATION? IO1DP2: Have the usual activities and duties changed since last month? IO1DP3: Last month NAME was reported as (a/an) POSITION and [his/her] usual activities were ACTIVITIES. Is this an accurate description of his current job? IO1IND: What kind of business or industry is this? IO1OCC: What kind of work did you do, that is, what was your occupation? IO1DT1: Describe your usual activities or duties at this job? 26. (If prefilled data for HH member) What was P's reaction to the question, IO1DP3, to confirm the description of the current job and usual activities?			
27. (If prefilled data for HH member) Did they find the confirmation question listed above redundant with the prior question, IO1DP2, that asked about job description and usual activities changing?			
28. (If prefilled data for HH member) Did P notice dependent data for these questions? • IO1DP1 • IO1DP2 • IO1DP3 • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			

Labor Force	Yes	No	Observation Notes
29. (If prefilled data for HH member) What was P's reaction to the dependent data in these questions? • IO1DP1 • IO1DP2 • IO1DP3 • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			
30. (If prefilled data for HH member) Did they overlook any of the dependent data before proceeding? • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			
31. (If prefilled data for HH member) Did they change any of the data? • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			
32. (If prefilled data for HH member) If so, which questions did they make changes and what changes were made? • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			
33. (If no prefilled data for HH member) Were P able to answer these questions? • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			
34. (If no prefilled data for HH member) Did they have any additional comments? • IO1IND • IO1OCC • IO1DT1			
35. Any other observations about industry and occupation:			

Other CPS questions

Other CPS	Yes	No	Observation Notes
Disability- 36. (only fill in if new person in household, else put "N/A") Did P report 'Yes' for any of the disability questions? Were they able to select who in the household had a disability?			
37. Did P report any confusion or annoyance with the instructions to confirm or update (Previously you answered the following question as shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct.)			
Nativity Drop Down – 38. (only fill in if new person in household, else put "N/A") Did P have any issues finding the correct country?			
39. If the P was presented with a prefilled country, did they have any issues or make any comments about being unsure what to do next?			
40. If the P was presented with instructions with prefilled data, did they make any comments on the instruction or indicate any confusion about what to do next? ("Please confirm or update the following information.")			
41. Other usability issues: - Do they receive error messages? Did they understand the messages and did they resolve it? (e.g., which screens) - Do they use the back button in the survey? (e.g., which screens) - Struggle with drop downs - Struggle with pronouns (he/she) - Comment on response options being in question wording			

Task 3: Debriefing Probes (20 minutes):

After completing the CPS survey

Thank you very much for answering those questions. I am now going to share my screen with you.

[Open up Qualtrics link for probing: [\[Link\]](#)

Debriefing on the Login Process (5 minutes):

Both computer and mobile: Log in questions

Next, I'm going to show you some screens that you saw before you started the survey. You will see these screens one by one.

[TA: Share the Login images in the respective PowerPoint for your cases. Use the "Desktop Laptop Login Images" for desktop or laptop cases. Use the "Mobile Login Images" for mobile cases.]

Note, we will show one screen at a time and these questions will repeat for each screen.

Interviewer will show image 1, ask all of the below questions, then image 2, repeat questions, etc.

Display "enter email" screen.

An official website of the United States government [Here's how you know](#)

United States Census Bureau

Current Population Survey FAQ

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

Please log in using your email address. We use your email address to verify and provide access to your survey. If you are a returning interview, please use the same email you previously provided.

You will receive a one-time verification code in your email.

Email

[Need help logging in?](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/policies/privacy/privacy-policy.html>.

Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

If you were selected to participate in this survey, you would have received an invitation, like the one below.

U.S. Census Bureau
Washington, DC 20540-0001
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR

A Message from the Director of the U.S. Census Bureau:

Dear Resident,

Your address has been selected to participate in the **Current Population Survey**. This monthly survey is the source of the Nation's unemployment rate that you may hear about in the news. The U.S. Census Bureau conducts this survey in partnership with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

We are inviting you to respond to the Current Population Survey online.

Log into the website below using your email address and your User ID. Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.

Respond this week at: access.census.gov/cps

User ID: XXXXXXXXXX000000

Respond online by the end of this week. After that, a Census Bureau interviewer will contact you to complete the survey.

The success of this survey depends on your participation. We cannot substitute another address for yours. Your address is part of a scientifically selected sample of addresses chosen throughout the country. Your answers represent hundreds of other households like yours.

Answers to frequently asked questions are on the back of this letter. If you have other questions, please visit census.gov/cps or call 1-800-424-6974, #33939

Thank you in advance for participating in this important survey.

42. [If P struggled] What did you think about this screen?

43. [If P struggled] What did you find difficult about this? Tell me more about that.

44. [If commented on feature in log in process that they struggled with or did not like] I noticed that you commented on [insert feature] during the log in process. Can you tell me more what you were thinking?

45. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

Display "verification code" screen.

An official website of the United States government [Visit Us Now](#)

United States Census Bureau

Current Population Survey FAQ

Welcome to the Current Population Survey

An email has been sent with your one-time verification code. Enter that code below.

Verification code

Verify

[Resend email](#)

Your session will expire if you remain on one screen for 15 minutes without navigating to another screen.

Do not use the web browser buttons (back, forward, or close browser). Use the buttons within the questionnaire to navigate. For best results, use the latest version of Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari. Enable cookies.

U.S. Census Bureau Notice and Consent Warning

You are accessing a United States Government computer network. Any information you enter into this system is confidential. It may be used by the Census Bureau for statistical purposes and to improve the website. If you want to know more about the use of this system, and how your privacy is protected, visit our online privacy webpage at <https://www.census.gov/about/policies/privacy/privacy-policy.html>

Use of this system indicates your consent to collection, monitoring, recording, and use of the information that you provide for any lawful government purpose. So that our website remains safe and available for its intended use, network traffic is monitored to identify unauthorized attempts to access, upload, change information, or otherwise cause damage to the web service. Use of the government computer network for unauthorized purposes is a violation of Federal law and can be punished with fines or imprisonment (PUBLIC LAW 99-474).

Check your email for the 8-digit verification code.

United States Census Bureau

Your Census Bureau Verification Code

Here is your one-time Census Bureau Verification Code:

XXXX-XXXX

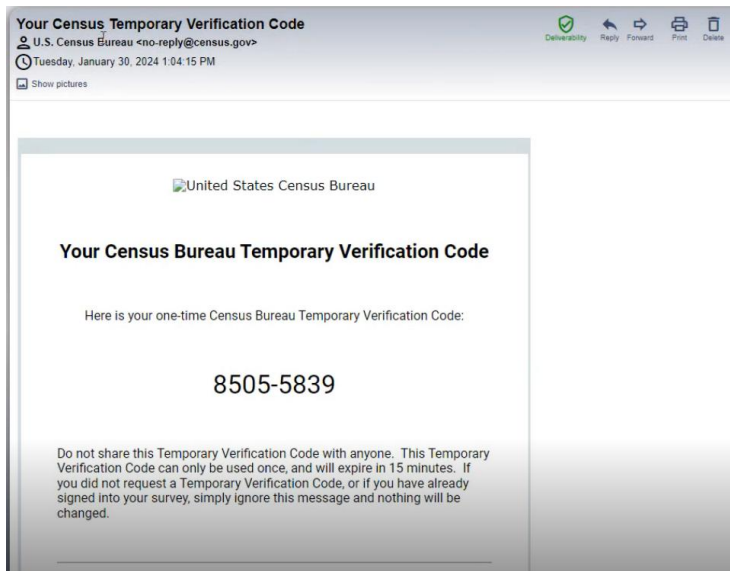
Do not share this code with anyone. This code can only be used once, and will expire in 15 minutes. If you did not request a verification code, or if you have already signed into your survey, simply ignore this message and nothing will be changed.

This message was sent to you because someone attempted to access a Census Bureau survey with your email address. This email notification is generated by a computer, please DO NOT REPLY.

About the Census Bureau 2:28 PM

46. [If P struggled] What did you think about this screen?
47. [If P struggled] What did you find difficult about this? Tell me more about that.
48. [If commented on feature in log in process that they struggled with or did not like] I noticed that you commented on [insert feature] during the log in process. Can you tell me more what you were thinking?
49. [If struggled finding verification code] I noticed it took you a while to find the verification code. Was there anything that may have made it easier to find the verification code?
50. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

Display "verification code email" screen.



51. [If P struggled] What did you think about this screen?
52. [If P struggled] What did you find difficult about this? Tell me more about that.
53. [If commented on feature in log in process that they struggled with or did not like] I noticed that you commented on [insert feature] during the log in process. Can you tell me more what you were thinking?
54. [If struggled finding verification code] I noticed it took you a while to find the verification code. Was there anything that may have made it easier to find the verification code?
55. [If mobile and scrolled]: I noticed that you scrolled on this screen. Can you tell me more about what you were looking for?

Debriefing on the CPS instrument (20 minutes):

Now I would like to ask you some questions about some of the survey questions you saw. Note, you don't have to answer the questions on these screens I am showing you as I am just asking about your thoughts. This will show fictional names in the instrument.

High priority items

Overall survey

56. First, tell me what you thought about answering this survey on your [computer/mobile phone].

57. [If needed] Did you find this survey easy or difficult to complete? Can you tell me more about that? What did you find easy? What did you find difficult?

Proceed to the Roster Questions

Roster Questions

Display the screen to confirm the roster.

Previously, it was reported that the following people were living or staying at this address.

Please list everyone who is living or staying at this address. Remove anyone who is no longer living or staying there. When you have finished listing the names of everyone who lives or stays there, press "Continue".

Select "Edit" to update or correct information about a person in the household.

Mario Martinez Male; 39 years old	Edit
Suzi Martinez Female; 37 years old	Remove Edit

[+ Add another person](#)

[Back](#) [Continue](#)

58. You saw the people you listed in your home during the previous interview. Was it clear what to do next when you saw this screen? [\[If needed\]](#) Can you tell me more about that?

59. [\[If used back button\]](#) I noticed you used the back button when you were listing who was in your household. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If added household member, administer 60 to 61.

60. What did you think of the process of adding the people to your household on the [computer/phone]?

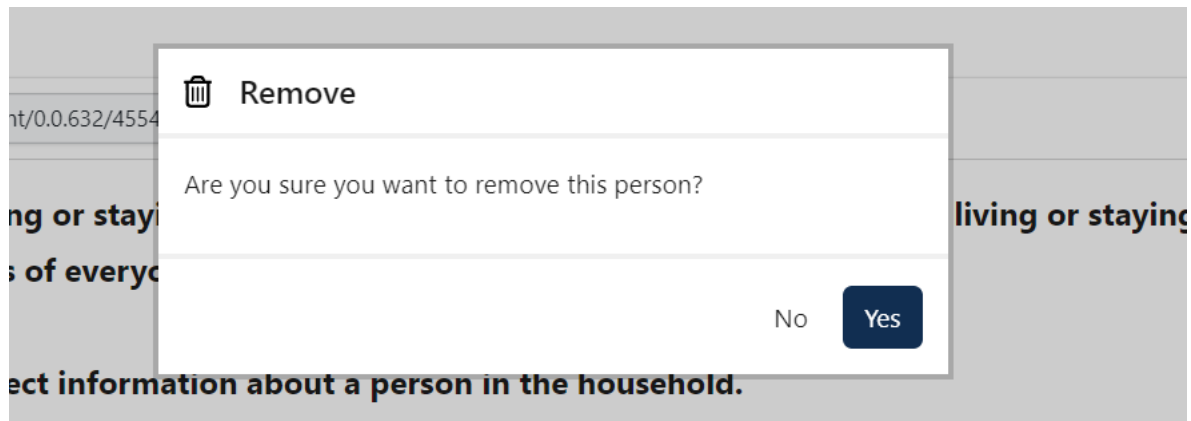
61. Was it clear or not clear how to add them? [\[If needed\]](#) Can you tell me more about that?

If removed household member, administer 60 to 62.

62. What did you think of the process of removing the people in your household on the [computer/phone]?

63. Was it clear or not clear how to remove them? [\[If needed\]](#) Can you tell me more about that?

Display pop-up removing modal



64. You saw this pop-up message when removing a person. What did you think about this?
[If needed] Can you tell me more about that?

Roster edit

Display roster edit screen only if they saw it.

Please review the data for each household member and select edit if needed to make updates.

- RICK MARTINEZ

Question	Answer	Issue	
Sex	Male	No issues found!	Edit
Age	45	No issues found!	Edit
Ever serve on active duty in U.S. Armed Forces	No	No issues found!	Edit
Education	HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATE- high school DIPLOMA or the equivalent (For example: GED)	No issues found!	Edit
Race		No issues found!	Edit

+ CINDY MARTINEZ

+ JULIO MARTINEZ

+ MARIE MARTINEZ

+ SUSAN GONZALEZ

[Back](#)[Next](#)

65. You selected the "Edit" button and then saw this screen where you could add or edit information for each household member. What did you think about this screen?

66. Was it clear what to do next when you saw this screen? [\[If needed\]](#) Can you tell me more about that?

67. [\[If P mentioned issues\]](#) You commented about this [issue] when reviewing this screen. Can you tell me more about it?

[Proceed to "education" section below.](#)

Education

INTERVIEWERS: Because of a glitch in the instrument, the education questions are getting skipped for interviews conducted in November. Please still show them this education question and ask the probes, rewording as needed.

Display the "education" screen

Occasionally, we re-ask certain questions in case anything has changed. Please confirm or update the following schooling or certificate information for RICK MARTINEZ.

What is the highest level of school RICK MARTINEZ has completed or the highest degree RICK MARTINEZ has received?

- ☐ Less than 1st grade
- ☐ 1st, 2nd, 3rd or 4th grade
- ☐ 5th or 6th grade
- ☐ 7th or 8th grade
- ☐ 9th grade
- ☐ 10th grade
- ☐ 11th grade
- ☐ 12th grade NO DIPLOMA
- ☒ HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATE- high school DIPLOMA or the equivalent (For example: GED)
- ☐ Some college but no degree
- ☐ Associate degree in college - Occupational/vocational program
- ☐ Associate degree in college -- Academic program
- ☐ Bachelor's degree (For example: BA, AB, BS)
- ☐ Master's degree (For example: MA, MS, MEng, MEd, MSW, MBA)
- ☐ Professional School Degree (For example: MD, DDS, DVM, LLB, JD)
- ☐ Doctorate degree (For example: PhD, EdD)

68. You saw the questions that asked about the education for each household member. What did you think about these questions?

69. This question had an instruction at the top explaining that we re-ask certain question and asked you to update or confirm the information you provided last time. The question was prefilled with the answer you gave last time. What was your reaction to this instruction?

70. Was it clear what this screen was asking you to do?

71. *[If received error message, ask probe and display image below]* You received this error message earlier. Was it clear what you had to do after reading this? *[If needed]* Can you tell me more about?

Education level is lower this month compared to last month, please check your entry.

Occasionally, we re-ask certain questions in case anything has changed. Please confirm or update the following schooling or certificate information for Mario Martinez.

What is the highest level of school Mario Martinez has completed or the highest degree Mario Martinez has received?

- ☐ Less than 1st grade
- ☐ 1st, 2nd, 3rd or 4th grade
- ☐ 5th or 6th grade
- ☐ 7th or 8th grade
- ☐ 9th grade
- ☐ 10th grade
- ☐ 11th grade
- ☐ 12th grade NO DIPLOMA
- ☒ HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATE- high school DIPLOMA or the equivalent (For example: GED)
- ☐ Some college but no degree
- ☐ Associate degree in college - Occupational/vocational program

If a household member is working, proceed to "Industry and Occupation (job)".

Industry and Occupation (job)

If P saw this question, display "industry and occupation (job)" screens, else proceed to "Nativity" section.

Display "usual activities and duties since last month" (IO1DP2) and "last month xx reported as xx and usual activities were xx" (IO1DP3) if they said 'No' to the first question for at least one household member.

Have the usual activities and duties of his job changed since last month?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Back

Next

Last month Mario Martinez was reported as (a/an) manager and his usual activities were working sales register . Is this an accurate description of his current job?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Back

Next

I am showing you some questions that you answered about [your/NAME]'s job. You mentioned that their usual activities and duties of their job had not changed.

72. What did you think about these two questions? [If needed] Did these questions make sense to you? Can you tell me more about that?

If P saw the business name confirmation (IO1DP1), type of business or industry (IO1IND), type of work (IO1OCC), and usual activities or duties screens (IO1DT1), display the images below.

Last month, it was reported that Mario Martinez worked for Acme Inc.. Does he still work for Acme Inc. ?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Back

Next

What kind of business or industry is this?

Include the main activity, product or service provided where employed.

Big Box Store

Back

Next

Previously it was reported that Mario Martinez was doing the kind of work shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct.

What kind of work does Mario Martinez do, that is, what is his occupation?

For example: 4th grade teacher, plumber.

manager

Back

Next

Previously it was reported Mario Martinez did the following usual activities or duties at their job as shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct.

Describe his usual activities or duties at this job.

For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe section and review building plans for work details.

working sales register

Back

Next

I am showing you some additional questions that you answered about [your/NAME]'s job.
73. What did you think about these questions? [If needed] Did these questions make sense to you? Can you tell me more about this?

74. Was it clear the prefilled information was what you provided in the last interview?

75. [If they did not change answer to any of prefilled data] Are you still in the same job position as the last time we spoke? Have there been any changes in your everyday activities at work since we last spoke?

76. [If they did change answer to the prefilled data] Can you tell me more about the reasons you changed your answer? [If needed] Do you think you were able to successfully change your answers to your current situation?

Proceed to "Nativity" section if P answered.

Else, if any in household was not working, proceed to "Not Working" section.

Else, proceed to "Low Priority" items if there is time.

Otherwise, proceed to "Final debriefing" section.

Nativity

If saw this question, display "Nativity" screens.

In what country was Mario Martinez born?

Country

Back

Next

-Select-

UNITED STATES

ABU DHABI

ADEN

AFGHANISTAN

AFRICA

ALBANIA

ALBERTA

ALGERIA

ALGIERS

ALSACE LORRAINE

AM SAMOA

AMERICAN SAMOA

AMSTERDAM

ANDORRA

ANEGADA

ANGOLA

ANGUILLA

ANGUILLA BWI

ANOJOUAN

-Select-

Back

Next

77. [\[If dependent data instruction displayed\]](#) This question had an instruction at the top explaining that we re-ask certain questions and asked you to update or confirm the information you provided last time. The question was prefilled with the answer you gave last time. What was your reaction to this screen?

78. [\[If prefilled data\]](#) These questions included answers from the first interview. What did you think about having these answers? [\[If needed\]](#) Was it clear what you had to do next? Can you tell me more about that?

79. [\[If new person was added to the roster\]](#) You answered a series of questions about which country [NAME] and their parents were born in. What did you think about this process in selecting the country?

80. [\[If mobile\]](#) When answering this question, you may have noticed a display pop up to select the country. What did you think about this display used to select the birth of country?

If any in household was not working, proceed to "Not Working" section.

Else, proceed to "Low Priority" items if there is time.

If there is no time, proceed to "Final debriefing" section.

Not Working

Note, you will need to consult the "not working" table above to guide which questions to administer in probing.

Note, only administer these probes below "main reason absent from work" screen if there were usability issues. Else, go to instruction above "how long on layoff" screen.

What was the main reason you were absent from work LAST WEEK?

- ☐ On layoff or furlough
- ☐ Business was slow
- ☐ Accepted a job offer and waiting to start
- ☐ Vacation or personal time off
- ☐ Sick, injured, or had other medical reason, including being pregnant
- ☐ Child care problems
- ☐ Caring for family or personal obligation
- ☐ Maternity/paternity leave
- ☐ Labor dispute
- ☐ Weather conditions
- ☐ School or training
- ☐ Civic/military duty
- ☐ Does not work in the business
- ☐ Other (specify)

Specify:

81. *[If P struggled]* I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME]. Can you tell me what you were thinking when you answered this question?

82. *[If P struggled picking one answer]* I noticed you had difficulty selecting the main reason for this question? Can you tell me more about that?

83. *[If needed] Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially the P using the back button.*

84. *[If used back button]* I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If P saw "how long on layoff" screen, display the below screens and ask the following probes.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been on layoff?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

-Select- ▾

Back

Next

Please enter a number in the box below.

Please select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been on layoff?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

-Select- ▾

Back

Next

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

85. Can you tell me what you were thinking when you answered this question?

86. *[If needed]* As you may recall, you had to write in a number and select a timeframe from the buttons. Can you me more what you were thinking when doing this?

87. *[If needed]* *Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or P using the back button.*

88. *[If error message]* I noticed the error message came up when you were answering this. What did you think about this? *[If needed]* Did you find this error message helpful?

89. *[If used back button]* I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

Note, only administer these probes below "activities look for work" screen if there were usability issues. Else, go to instruction above "when did you last work" screen.

What are all the things you have done to find work during the last 4 weeks?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Interviewed for a job
- ☐ Applied for a job or answered a job ad
- ☐ Checked a union/professional register
- ☐ Posted a resume or an ad/listing
- ☐ Contacted employment agency/school employment center
- ☐ Asked friends, relatives, network about job leads
- ☐ Looked at job ads
- ☐ Participated in a job training course or other activity to improve job skills
- ☐ Worked on resume
- ☐ Other (specify)
- ☐ Nothing

Back

Next

[If P struggled answering] I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

90. Can you tell me more about what you were thinking as you answered this?

91. [If P struggled answering] Were you able to find the option or see all the options that best fit your or the household member's situation?

If P saw "when did you last work" screen", display image and ask below probes.

When did you last work?

Month	Year
-Select- ▼	▼

Date entered is longer than 12 months ago.

When did he last work?

Month	Year
-Select- ▼	▼

Back

Next

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

92. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered this question?

93. *[If needed]* As you may recall, you had to select both a month and year from a list of options. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

94. *[if needed] Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or P using the back button.*

95. *[If error message]* I noticed the error message came up when you were answering this. What did you think about this? *[If needed]* What did you think you should do to proceed?

96. *[If used back button]* I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

If saw "how long had you been looking for work" screen, display image and ask below probes.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years from the dropdown.

 -Select- ▾

Back

Next

Please enter a number in the box below.

Please select weeks, months, or years in the dropdown.

As of the end of LAST WEEK, how long had you been looking for work?

Please enter a number and select weeks, months, or years from the dropdown.

 -Select- ▾

I am showing you this question now that you answered for [yourself/NAME].

97. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered this question?

98. *[If needed]* As you may recall, you had to select a time frame (weeks, months, years) and enter a number. Can you me more what you were thinking when doing this?

99. Did you have any difficulty entering the number and selecting the appropriate time frame?

100. *[If needed]* Please probe based on any observations you made in the table during the interview especially any error messages that appear or P using the back button.

101. *[If error message]* I noticed the error message came up when you were answering this question. What did you think about this? *[If needed]* What did you think you should do to proceed?

Proceed to "low priority" section if there is time.

Else, proceed to "Final debriefing".

Low priority items

Multiple jobs (hours)

Note to TA: If there is both a multiple job worker AND single job worker in the household, only ask multiple job worker. This is so we don't ask the same probes again in single job worker.

Note, only administer these probes below "usual hours with main job and other job" screen if there were usability issues. Else, go to instruction above "lose or takeoff, overtime, and actual hours" screen.

Display example of usual hours screen with main job and other job

How many hours per week does Jane Doe USUALLY work at her main job? By main job we mean the one at which she usually works the most hours.

- Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked
- Consider the LAST 4 MONTHS
- If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week
- If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess

	Hours per week
--	----------------

How many hours per week does she USUALLY work at her other job?

- Estimate the USUAL number of hours worked per week, not the actual hours worked
- Consider the LAST 4 MONTHS
- If hours vary from week to week, give the number of hours worked in a typical week
- If you do not know your usual hours, give your best guess

	Hours per week
--	----------------

102. [If P has issues on this screen] You answered a couple of questions about the usual hours your work at your main and other job(s). Can you tell me more about what you were thinking as you answered this question?

Note, only administer these probes below "lose or takeoff, overtime, and actual hours" screen if there were usability issues. Else, go to "disability" section.

Display questions with lose or takeoff, overtime, and actual hours

Next are some questions about the exact number of hours you worked LAST WEEK.

LAST WEEK, did you lose or take off any hours from your MAIN job, for ANY reason such as illness, lack of work, vacation, or holiday?

- ☒ Yes
☐ No

LAST WEEK, did you work any overtime or extra hours at your MAIN job that you do not usually work?

- ☒ Yes
☐ No

So, for LAST WEEK, how many hours did she ACTUALLY work at her MAIN job?

You reported she lost or took off 1 hours.
 You reported she worked 2 extra hours.

	Hours
--	-------

LAST WEEK, how many hours did she ACTUALLY work at her other job?

	Hours
--	-------

103. [If P has issues on these screens]: Previously you saw these screens that ask you about any hours you did not work last week due to illness, lack of work, vacations or holidays and overtime you worked last week. You were then asked the final question to report your actual hours worked for last week. Can you tell me more about how you answered both of these questions?

104. [If P had hours off or extra hours displayed in instruction] Did having the number of hours display for [lost or took off hours/extra hours] influence the number of actual hours you reported for this question? [If needed] Can you tell me more about?

Proceed to "disability" section if P answered.

Otherwise, proceed to "final debriefing".

Single job (hours)

TA: DO NOT ADMINISTER THIS SECTION IF YOU HAVE ALREADY ASKED ABOUT USUAL HOURS/ACTUAL HOURS AS PART OF A MULTIPLE JOB PATHWAY.

Note, these probes should only be asked if there was any usability issues P experience during the example. For example, this could be comments on instructions, scrolling back and forth, navigating backwards, not liking having both instructions on the same screen, etc.

Display lose time, overtime and actual hours on same screen

Next are some questions about the exact number of hours you worked LAST WEEK.

LAST WEEK, did you lose or take off any hours from work, for ANY reason such as illness, lack of work, vacation, or holiday?

☒ Yes

☐ No

LAST WEEK, did you work any overtime or extra hours that you do not usually work?

☐ Yes

☒ No

So, for LAST WEEK, how many hours did you ACTUALLY work at your job?

	Hours
--	-------

[If they took time off/reported overtime and if needed]: Previously you saw these screens that ask you about any hours you did not work last week due to illness, lack of work, vacations or holidays and overtime you worked last week. You were then asked the final question to report your actual hours worked for last week.

105. [If needed] How did you come up with your answer to how many hours you worked at your main job last week?

106. [If needed] Did you account for the time you took off/your overtime hours when you reported the actual hours for your main job?

107. [If mentioned difficulty calculating actual hours] You mentioned it was difficult for you to account for time you took off or worked overtime as part of your calculation for the actual hours you worked at your main job last week? What would have made this easier for you?

108. [If used back button] I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

Note, these probes should only be asked if there was any usability issues P experience during the example. For example, this could be comments on instructions, scrolling back

and forth, navigating backwards, not liking having both instructions on the same screen, etc.

Previously you saw these screens that asked whether you had any hours you did not work last week and about whether you worked overtime. You said “no” to each of these. You were then asked to report the actual hours you worked last week for your job.

109. *[If needed]* You mentioned that it was difficult to report the actual hours you worked for your job? Can you tell me more about that?

110. *[If used back button]* I noticed you used the back button when you were answering these questions. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when doing this?

Proceed to “disability” section if P answered.

Otherwise, proceed to “final debriefing”.

Disability

Display following "difficulty" screens if they saw this question.

Previously you answered the following question as shown below. Please update the information below if this has changed or select "Next" if this information is still correct.

Is anyone deaf or does anyone have serious difficulty hearing?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Is anyone blind or does anyone have serious difficulty seeing, even when wearing glasses?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does anyone have serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Does anyone have serious difficulty walking or climbing stairs?

☒ Yes

☐ No

Does anyone have difficulty dressing or bathing?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does anyone have difficulty doing errands alone such as visiting a doctor's office or shopping?

☐ Yes

☒ No

This question had an instruction at the top explaining that we re-ask certain questions and asked you to update or confirm the information you provided last time. The questions was prefilled with the answers you gave last time.

111. What was your reaction to these questions? [If needed] Was it clear what you had to do next? Can you tell me more about that?

Only administer these probes if they checked a box for the new person in their household.

Who is that?

Select all that apply.

☐ Joe Poe

112. [If answered "Yes" to any follow-up for new person] You answered "Yes" to [insert disability question] for NAME. Can you tell me more what you were thinking when you answered these questions?

Proceed to "final debriefing" section.

Final Debriefing (2 minutes)

113. Were there any other parts of the survey that were confusing or difficult?

114. Do you have any additional thoughts on the screens we looked at today that you would like to share?

115. Is there anything else you'd like to mention that we haven't talked about?

Let me turn to the team and see if they have any questions...

Finishing up session (1 minute)

TA: End Recording. Also make sure you submit the Qualtrics satisfaction questionnaire.

Okay, that's it for today. Thanks so much for all your answers. Now I will just stop the recording and then I will confirm with you the email you would like us to send your \$60 digital gift card.

INTERVIEWER: Confirm email after recording has stopped.

NOTE THE TIME THAT THE INTERVIEW HAS ENDED.

Appendix C: Current Population Survey Usability Session Participant Informed Consent Form

What is the purpose of this interview?

The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting interviews to help with the design and content of the Current Population Survey (CPS). The CPS is an important source of information about our nation on topics such as employment. It's important that the questions make sense, are easy to answer, and that everyone understands the questions in the same way. You are one of about 80 people who are being asked to participate in these interviews. Findings from these interviews will be used to clarify survey questions and instructions on the CPS.

What will happen if I take part in this interview?

If you agree to take part in this study, you will be asked to complete two separate interviews. You will be asked to answer questions about your household, including yourself and other people that live with you. The interviews will be conducted virtually by a staff member from RTI International or Research Support Services, who are doing this study for the U.S. Census Bureau.

We would also like to audio and video record the interview. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. It will help us make sure we accurately capture your answers. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview.

How much time is required to participate?

Each of the two interviews will last approximately 1 hour.

Do I have to take part in this interview?

No, participation in this interview is voluntary. You can stop the interview at any time, and you don't have to answer a question if you don't want to. You will not lose any rights you would normally have if you choose not to join this interview.

What are the possible risks and benefits from participating in this interview?

There are no direct benefits to you from doing this interview. Your involvement in this study will help us improve the questions for the Current Population Survey. There is no more than minimal risk in participating.

How will my privacy be protected?

This interview is being conducted under the authority of 13 U.S.C. Sections 6, 141, and 182. Federal law requires that your answers are kept confidential (13 U.S.C. Section 9), and protects your privacy under the Privacy Act (5 U.S.C. Section 552a). Only research staff from the U.S. Census Bureau and its survey vendor, RTI International and Research Support Services will know your answers and/or comments from the interview. The Census Bureau can use your responses only to produce statistics, and is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you, your business, organization, or institution.

Additionally, per the Federal Cybersecurity Enhancement Act of 2015, your data are protected from cybersecurity risks through screening of the systems that transmit your data. Your information is secured by strictly adhering to the provisions of Title 13, United States Code, the Privacy Act, and other regulations and policies that protect the privacy and confidentiality of the information.

This collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB). This eight-digit OMB approval number, 0607-0725, confirms this approval and expires on 12/31/2025. Without this approval, we could not conduct this study.

How will I be compensated?

When you complete the first interview, you will receive \$50. When you complete the second interview, you will receive \$60.

What if I have questions about the interview?

If you have concerns or questions about the interview, you may contact RTI's project director, [PROJECT LEAD], at xxx-xxx-xxxx or xxx@rti.org.

Appendix D: Survey Invitation Letter



United States®
Census
Bureau

U.S. Census Bureau
Washington, DC 20233-0001
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR

A Message from the Director of the U.S. Census Bureau:

Dear Resident,

Your address has been selected to participate in the **Current Population Survey**. This monthly survey is the source of the Nation's unemployment rate that you may hear about in the news. The U.S. Census Bureau conducts this survey in partnership with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

We are inviting you to respond to the Current Population Survey online.

Log into the website below using your email address and your User ID. Please make note of the email address you use to complete this month's survey as you will use the same one each month.

Respond this week at: access.census.gov/cps

User ID: XXXX-XXXX-XXXX

Respond online by the end of this week. After that, a Census Bureau interviewer will contact you to complete the survey.

The success of this survey depends on your participation. We cannot substitute another address for yours. Your address is part of a scientifically selected sample of addresses chosen throughout the country. Your answers represent hundreds of other households like yours.

Answers to frequently asked questions are on the back of this letter. If you have other questions, please visit census.gov/cps or call 1-800-424-6974, #53939

Thank you in advance for participating in this important survey.

What is the Current Population Survey?

The Current Population Survey is the primary source of monthly labor force statistics. It is used to keep the Nation informed of the economic and social wellbeing of its people. This survey measures how the economy and labor force are doing across the country and in your community. It asks questions about employment, and in certain months includes questions about education, health, family income, housing, and other important subjects.

How was I selected?

The U.S. Census Bureau chose your address, not you personally, to participate in this survey. We select about 60,000 addresses across the United States to interview each month. This ensures that the survey represents all kinds of households across the country. This is why your participation is so important. Your address and your household represent thousands of other addresses and people.

How long will this take?

On average, this survey takes 10 to 15 minutes. You will be contacted for four consecutive months this year. You will be contacted again during the same four months next year. This type of interview schedule ensures high-quality statistics while reducing the burden on participants. We will work with you to schedule interviews at the best times for you. Interviews can be over the phone or in person at the location of your choosing. Send comments regarding this burden estimate or any other aspect of this collection of information, including suggestions for reducing this burden, to: dsd.cps@census.gov; use "Demo Survey Comments 0607-0049" as the subject.

Will information I provide be confidential?

The Census Bureau is required by law to protect your information. The Census Bureau is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you or your household. Per the Federal Cybersecurity Enhancement Act of 2015, your data are protected from cybersecurity risks through screening of the systems that transmit your data.

Federal law protects your privacy and keeps your answers confidential (Title 13, United States Code, Section 9). Title 13, United States Code, Sections 8(b), 141, and 182; and Title 29, United States Code, Section 2 authorize the collection of most of the information we request in this survey. The information provided to us may only be shared with other Census Bureau staff for the work-related purposes as identified in the Privacy Act System of Record Notice COMMERCE/Census-3, Demographic Survey Collection (Census Bureau Sampling Frame).

In some months, the survey may contain questions authorized under laws other than those cited; further information concerning the authority for any particular portion of the survey can be obtained from the representative who contacts your household. Your voluntary participation in this survey is important. This collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB Number: 0607-0049). Without this number, we could not conduct this survey.